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SATURDAY, AUGUST 22, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

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RED FACES AFTER CEREMONIAL WELCOME REHEARSAL ANNOUNCEMENT

Rashtrapati Bhavan announces, retracts Rahman visit statement

Nothing to say right now: MEA; Dhaka too says no decision made on visit yet

Divya A & Shubhrajit Roy
New Delhi, August 21

THERE WERE red faces in New Delhi Friday after Rashtrapati Bhavan announced the cancellation of Saturday's Change of Guard ceremony "due to the full rehearsal for the ceremonial welcome" of Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, and then withdrew the communication an hour later. The Ministry of External Affairs,

which usually announces the visits of heads of state and dignitaries in coordination with the governments concerned, said it had "nothing to say right now" on Rahman's visit. Dhaka too did not confirm a date for the start of the visit.

The announcement and its retraction by Rashtrapati Bhavan added to the uncertainty over Rahman's visit. New Delhi has invited the Bangladesh Prime Minister and the two



Delhi wants to host the Bangladesh PM for a stand-alone bilateral visit and has also invited him to the BRICS Summit next month

sides have been in touch to work out suitable dates. Ties between the two countries, severely strained following the August 2024 ouster of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina

who sought refuge in India, had been looking up after Rahman took charge of Bangladesh in February this year. But Hasina's public interaction in New Delhi via an audio link on August 5 — it marked two years of her ouster — angered Dhaka which has been seeking her extradition to Bangladesh where she faces a death sentence. It also cast a shadow over Rahman's visit to India.

Around 2 pm Friday, Rashtrapati Bhavan, in a press release titled "No change of guard ceremony this Saturday", stated: "The Change of Guard

•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



22 Indians on board 2 ships hijacked near Yemen and Somalia

Sukalp Sharma & Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, August 21

A TOTAL of 22 Indian seafarers are on board two ships that were hijacked by armed pirates off the coast of Somalia and Yemen this week, according to sources aware of the developments.

Sources said that while the shipping companies related to the two vessels are working in close coordination with the government, the seafarers are learnt to be safe.

The two vessels are Eritrea-flagged oil products tanker *Sibu 1*, which was hijacked in



the Gulf of Aden off the coast of Yemen Thursday, and Cameroon-flagged general cargo carrier *Lafit*, which was hijacked last Monday off Somalia's coast.

Sibu 1 has 20 seafarers on board. •CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Gayatri-Tresa ensure a World medal

Gayatri Gopichand Pulela and Tresa Jolly with their coach Pulela Gopichand, who is Gayatri's father, after winning the doubles quarterfinal at the Badminton World Championships in New Delhi, Friday. The victory guarantees a medal for the duo in the Championships. PTI

REPORT, PAGE 20

Most retail traders in F&O earn less than Rs 5 lakh a year, are under 30

Akash Mandal & Siddharth Upasani
Mumbai, New Delhi, August 21

• 88% retail traders lost Rs 91,685 cr in 2025-26

	2024-25	2025-26
Retail investors in F&O	98.1 lakh	78.6 lakh
How many made losses	91%	88%
Total net losses	Rs 1.12 lakh crore	Rs 91,685 crore
GenZ* trading in F&O	44.1 lakh	32.83 lakh
No. of GenZ* who lost money	NA	29.07 lakh
Losses made by GenZ*	NA	Rs 19,287 crore

NOTE: GENZ ARE RETAIL INVESTORS UNDER 30; SOURCE: SEBI

Business as Usual
By EPUNNY



THE BIG PICTURE

THE SILVER BULLET: WHY EVERYONE LOVES A METRO PAGE 13

EXPRESS special

Dip in production, stocks at 9-year low: Soaring sugar prices leave bitter taste

Retail prices surge by Rs 20/kg in a month

Harish Damodaran
New Delhi, August 21

DUSSEHRA is on October 20 and Diwali on November 8. But sugar is already tasting bitter, well before the festival season. According to the department of consumer affairs, the all-India

modal retail price, the rate at which most purchases are reported, was Rs 65 per kg on Friday. It was only Rs 45 on July 21 and rose to Rs 50 by July 31.

Simply put, retail prices of the sweetener — the most vital ingredient in every

Diwali mithai and Cadbury Celebrations, Nestle Kit Kat or Ferrero Rocher chocolates — have soared by Rs 20/kg in just a month.

No less significant are ex-factory prices. These rates, which mills realise from selling sugar net of goods and sales tax, were at Rs 57-60 per kg in



Govt has allowed import of raw sugar up to 10 lakh tonnes at zero duty until October 31

• 25-YEAR-OLD WAS AMONG 21 PEOPLE WHO DIED IN FIRE AT A BnB IN HAUZ RANI IN JUNE

Degree for Shrutika: At TISS convocation, remembering student killed in Delhi fire

Pallavi Smart
Mumbai, August 21

A DEGREE will be waiting for Shrutika Baranwal at the 86th convocation of the Tata Institute of Social Sciences Saturday. A testimonial will also summarise her achievements and life on campus. But, unlike the testimonials for her batchmates, hers will be issued posthumously. Shrutika, 25, was among 21 people who died in a fire that

engulfed a bed and breakfast facility in south Delhi's Hauz Rani in June.

Her parents, Ramesh Prasad Baranwal and Babita, have travelled from their home in Jaina More in Jharkhand's Bokaro district to Mumbai to receive the Master's degree in Water Policy and Governance that their daughter had earned. TISS authorities told *The Indian Express* that Shrutika secured a



Shrutika with her parents, Ramesh Prasad Baranwal and Babita, during their Mumbai trip in April 2025

•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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Rahman visit statement

Ceremony at the Forecourt of Rashtrapati Bhavan will not take place this Saturday (August 22, 2026) due to the full rehearsal for the ceremonial welcome of the Prime Minister of Bangladesh.

Since full dress rehearsals are usually conducted a day ahead of the ceremony, this was considered as a formal announcement of Rahman's visit. But an hour later, Rashtrapati Bhavan withdrew the press release. Its new statement said, "Press release issued on the subject 'No Change of Guard Ceremony this Saturday', which was issued on August 21, 2026, stands withdrawn."

The flip-flopped to speculation whether either side had pulled the plug on the visit.

Responding to questions on Rahman's visit, Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for the Ministry of External Affairs, said, "I

have nothing to say right now. If I have any update, I will share with you."

Bangladesh Prime Minister's Press Secretary AAM Saleh told news agency Reuters. "No decision has yet been made on the visit." He said Dhaka was waiting for India's response on the extradition of Hasina and "other fugitive criminals".

Rashtrapati Bhavan hosts a ceremonial welcome for visiting heads of state and other dignitaries on state visits to India. It takes place in the forecourt, featuring a formal tri-services Guard of Honour, national anthems of India and the country of the visiting dignitary, and introductions by the President and the Prime Minister.

Later, the President also hosts a dinner reception for the visiting leader. It is attended by

the visiting delegation and Indian dignitaries, including the Prime Minister and Union Ministers.

At the heart of scheduling Rahman's visit is Dhaka's pre-condition that a "propitious environment needs to be created" for it — a reference to the presence of Hasina in India and her public statements on August 5.

Bangladesh wants to get a clear answer on the steps being taken on the issue of Hasina's extradition. Delhi has not yet responded, and a battle of nerves is being played out amid hectic negotiations to find a "middle ground".

The Indian side had proposed August 21 as a possible date for a stand-alone bilateral visit by Rahman. It expanded the scope up to August 25, but there has been no finality in scheduling the visit.

The request for Hasina's extradition was first moved by the interim government led by Muhammad Yunus in 2024, and has been reiterated by the BNP government which entered office in February this year.

"To this end, we have requested the Indian authorities to expeditiously act on our request to extradite Sheikh Hasina and other fugitive criminals, and to hand over to Bangladesh the accused killers of Shaheed Sharif Osman in compliance with our bilateral extradition treaty," the Bangladesh Foreign Ministry had said in a statement last Sunday.

When New Delhi has stated that the extradition request is "being examined", the Indian side has been emphasising on a forward-looking relationship built on "mutuality of interests and reciprocity". New Delhi has signalled that it aims to address broader bilateral and security concerns alongside Dhaka's requests.

Sources said that Delhi and Dhaka are "aware" of the significance of the visit, and both sides have much to benefit from a strong and robust relationship.

"We do not want to jeopardise the relationship over a single issue. So we are working with our Bangladesh counterparts as we have a range of issues to discuss—from connectivity to energy, water sharing to infrastructure, border management to people-to-people contacts. We are optimistic of a visit soon," the sources said.

While Delhi wants to host Rahman for a stand-alone bilateral visit, it has also extended an invitation to the Bangladesh PM to attend the BRICS leaders' summit next month. With BNP's longest-serving secretary general, Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir, being elected President of Bangladesh, there is a possibility he may attend the BRICS summit in case Rahman cannot make it.

Two ships

board, including 16 Indians. *Lutuf* has 10 people on board, of which six are Indian seafarers. The ship was carrying Turkish weapons, communications, and satellite equipment. Notably, *Sibu* was sanctioned by the US in December 2025 under its former name *Sagull* for its alleged participation in Iranian petroleum trade.

According to the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO) centre, an tanker was boarded Thursday by six armed persons who took control of the vessel and were redirected it towards Somalia. Sources indicated that this UKMTO hijack warning was about *Sibu*.

According to another hijack warning issued by the UKMTO, a cargo vessel reported being boarded by eight "armed unauthorised persons" off the Somali coast, who then took con-

trol of the vessel. This report was about *Lutuf*, it is learnt. As of Friday, both the ships were not transmitting their location, which means that the pirates likely switched off their transponders.

Apart from increased risk to maritime security in the broader West Asia-North Africa region due to the conflict in the Gulf, piracy-related security incidents have also been seen recently. Incidents involving Somali pirates had seen a significant fall over the past decade, but hijacking is on the rise this year.

Some shipping analysts are of the opinion that piracy-related incidents and hijackings have risen near East and North African trade corridors, specifically the Gulf of Aden, the Red Sea, and off Somalia, because international naval forces shifted their focus and assets to West Asia and the Strait of Hormuz.

Indian seafarers are a dominant group in the global seafarer community. India is the world's

second-largest supplier of seafarers, contributing 311,936 maritime professionals to the global shipping industry, according to the BIMCO-ICS Seafarer Workforce Report 2026.

The report estimates that India now accounts for 12.2% of the global seafaring workforce, ranking behind only the Philippines and ahead of China, Russia, and Indonesia. Given their widespread presence, the growing number of maritime security incidents have left Indian seafarers particularly vulnerable.

A number of Indian seafarers have already borne the brunt of the West Asia conflict, with a few of them even losing their lives. Several merchant vessels that have come under attack in the region (since early March) had a number of Indian seafarers on board. In some cases, they had to be rescued by regional militaries after attacks disabled the ships they were serving on.

F&O

In what may worry policymakers, individuals with lower income under Rs 10 lakh a year make up an overwhelming majority of retail F&O (futures and options) traders. From 75% in 2024-25, it is down only marginally to 73% in 2025-26. This shows "derivatives participation remained concentrated among lower-income individuals", a SEBI report said.

Futures and options are underpinning

company stocks or indices — hence called derivatives. They allow two parties to agree to trade a security at a later date at a predetermined price. This can help traders protect themselves from unexpected stock price movements. While options can lead to big losses, the possibility of outsized returns has made them very popular globally over the last decade or so.

According to this report titled "Profitability of individual traders in the equity derivatives segment (FY24-FY26)", the number of retail traders has dropped 20% to 78.6 lakh from 98.1 lakh in 2024-

25. But those who made losses remained high at 88% in 2024-25 compared with 91% in the previous year. The net losses, however, dropped 18% to Rs 91,685 crore in 2025-26 compared with Rs 1,12,146 crore in 2024-25.

The number of youth trading in futures and options has, however, seen a sharper 26% decline to 32.83 lakh in 2025-26 from about 44 lakh the previous year. Still, the youth or GenZ (those under 30 years) made up the bulk of the retail traders at 43% of the total in 2025-26.

While comparable numbers for 2024-25 are not available, of the 32.83 lakh youth who traded in F&O in 2025-26, a massive 29.07 lakh or 89% made losses. Their losses were, however, only Rs 19,287 crore, which is around 20% of the total retail net losses of Rs 91,685 crore.

In another report "Trading behaviour of individual traders in the equity derivatives segment", SEBI said the data does not establish that its tightening measures caused a higher exit rate. "The analysis does not establish a causal relationship," it said.

Interestingly, more and more women are participating in the F&O segment — they made up

17.1% of retail traders in 2025-26, up from 15.6% in 2024-25. And while fewer women make losses compared to men, the proportion remains highly elevated.

In 2025-26, 85% of women made losses while trading in F&Os, down from 88% the previous year. The corresponding figures for men are 89% in 2025-26 and 92% in 2024-25.

The profiteers

The F&O losses of India's small traders gained global attention during US-based proprietary trading firm Jane Street's April 2024 legal battle in the US over what it said was its confidential and "most profitable" trading strategy. It was then that SEBI began looking into the firm's activities in India for any market abuses, resulting in its July 2025 order that said the firm had manipulated stock indices and made "unlawful gains" to the tune of Rs 4,844 crore.

Backed by years of experience in the market, the fastest available internet, specialised algorithms, high-frequency trading strategies, and access to real-time, market-moving news, proprietary trading firms made a gross profit of Rs 44,483 crore in 2025-26 — not far from the Rs

45,955 crore profit they made in 2024-25.

Proprietary, or prop, firms use their own capital to trade. Foreign Portfolio Investors' (FPIs) profits fell 55% to Rs 13,896 crore in 2025-26, with other big players, such as corporates, mutual funds, and Domestic Institutional Investors also posting declines.

"There are multiple factors behind this decline in profit, but the two primary drivers are the higher Securities Transaction Tax (STT) and lock-in market conditions," said Vipin Kumar, Assistant Vice President of equity research at Globe Capital Market. Currency depreciation and lower participation of retail investors — leading to the counterparty volumes shrinking — were among the other factors. The Union Budget for 2026-27 hiked the STT on the F&O segment to suppress speculative trading. However, F&O trade volumes crashed long before, following a crackdown by SEBI in October 2024. According to data from the World Federation of Exchanges, from a peak of 12,941 billion in October 2024, the total number of F&O contracts traded on the NSE collapsed nearly six times to 2.3 billion by February 2025.

and his mother is standing here... Till there is an FIR, we will not move from here. We are being told that in India, a young man can be shot at. The Union Minister of Amit Shah will not allow justice to prevail," he said.

Several cases of pellet-gun injuries came to light after the police cracked down on thousands of young men and women protesting against paper leaks from the streets of Delhi on the first day of Parliament's Monsoon Session. *The Indian Express* had reported earlier that the CRPF had found that a Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel had fired seven rounds from a pellet gun, five of which had hit protesters.

"On July 20, pellet guns were used at Connaught Place. What is the proof of that? It is here," Gandhi said as he showed a small box apparently containing pellets. "Where did they come from? They came from his (Sahil's) body," he said.

Nadga said Gandhi had been informed by the DCP that Sahil's case was being referred to the Delhi Police Crime Branch, which was investigating cases relating to the July 20 march. Also, Nadga said, the Supreme Court had already constituted a high-power committee to look into the matter. "When the country's highest court is investigating the matter, what does Rahul Gandhi seek to prove by sitting outside a police station in front of cameras? Has the Leader of Opposition lost faith in the country's judiciary?" he asked.

Nadga alleged the Congress was "surrounded" under the Vande Mataram issue. "To divert attention, Rahul Gandhi hastily orchestrated this diversionary drama," he said.

FIR over pellet firing

Nyasa Sanhita, causing (BNS) relating to voluntarily causing hurt using dangerous weapons, and rash or negligent act that endangers human life.

Gandhi, who was accompanied by the 19-year-old, Sahil Lochab, who was hit by a pellet in his right eye, and his mother, said the FIR was the first step towards justice. "The case has been lodged. It took eight hours. This is New Delhi and justice is not being given here. Imagine what happens at police stations in the villages. Imagine how many women are raped and children are beaten in the country," he said.

Gandhi claimed the FIR was registered only after "final permission" from Union Home Minister Amit Shah. "You should understand who was stopping the FIR. These policemen wanted to lodge the FIR, but brakes on justice were put from the top," he alleged.

The BJP accused the Congress leader of "cheap and diversionary politics". Union Minister J P Nadga said his protest was "neither for students nor for justice" but a display of "political desperation" and his "insatiable hunger for 'footage'".

Sahil told reporters that the FIR was "a win for justice". He said he was disappointed that "despite being with the Leader of Opposition, it took eight hours to lodge an FIR... Had the LOP not supported me, this may not have happened".

In the FIR, Sahil said that he was hit by pellets during a stampede-like situation on July

20. "I suddenly felt as if something had struck the right side of my body, including my chest near the heart, my arm, and my eye. When I turned around, I saw a person in a blue uniform, holding a large gun, and I was struck by several metal pellets fired from it," the FIR states.

"The doctor clearly mentioned in my MLC (medical legal case report) that the injury to my eye had been caused by a pellet. It was also mentioned that the possibility of recovery of vision in my eye was less than 1 per cent. Some pellets will remain inside my eye for the rest of my life," it said.

Earlier in the day, Gandhi went to the Mandir Marg police station, and then to the office of the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Central Delhi, at Parliament Street. Congress leaders said he wanted to help Sahil, who had submitted a written complaint to police on August 14, but was being ignored.

"He (Sahil) pursued (the case) on 17th (August) by email and phone. But he was not given details of the Investigating Officer. No acknowledgment was given either," a Congress leader said.

Gandhi, who was joined at the time by his sister and Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and senior Congress leaders Jairam Ramesh, Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury and Kamur Selja, claimed police officers had told him they were under "orders from the higher-ups to not lodge an FIR".

"A young Indian is injured

Why have projections been off the mark?

The sugarcane crop in Maharashtra, Karnataka and Gujarat suffered from excess rainfall in September-October last year with a delayed withdrawal of the southwest monsoon.

The resultant waterlogged fields in combination with lack of sunshine, deprived the standing crop of aeration and daylight. If affected cane growth and accumulation of sucrose in the stalks, translating into lower yields and sugar recovery by mills.

ISMA had, in November, projected sugar output in Maharashtra and Karnataka at 130.1 and 63.5 lt, whereas the mills there could only produce 99.21 and 47.2 lt respectively. UP factories have also produced 89.7 lt, as against the earlier estimate of 103.2 lt, with the red rot fungal disease and top shoot borer insect pest being the chief villains.

The dominant Co-028 sugarcane variety grown in the state has been increasingly susceptible to the attacks, showing up in yield and sugar recovery losses.

Average ex-factory sugar prices in Maharashtra fell from Rs 38.31 to Rs 36.98 per kg between September 2025 and April

How much is sugar diversion for ethanol to blame?

On the face of it, the 30 lt of sugar that went for making ethanol in the current season seems significant. But the effect of that has been magnified by gross sugar production itself — i.e. before ethanol diversion — being 34.5 lt lower than the initial estimates.

Not many would have envisaged this further decline, leave alone aspart prices from July, at the start of the season.

Attributing the present skyrocketing of sugar prices to the ethanol-blending petrol programme may not be right for a second reason as well.

Of the total 8,016.67 crore litres of ethanol supplied to oil marketing companies for blending during November 2025 to July 2026, only 259.24 crore litres or 3.2% was from sugarcane-based feedstock: Direct juice/syrup (14.76 crore), B-heavy molasses (98.19 crore) and C-heavy molasses (134.5 crore). The balance 551.43 crore

What has government done to check sugar prices?

On May 13, the Modi government banned export of all sugar from the country until September 30, 2026. This was more of a precautionary move on its part, rather than any firm conclusion of an impending supply shortage.

On Thursday, it allowed import of up to 10 lt of raw sugar at zero duty until October 31, as opposed to the standard tariff of 100% on the sweeter. This raw sugar can be processed by companies such as Shree Renuka Sugars and Shri Datta India Private Ltd that operate refineries in Gujarat's Kandla port.

The refined sugar from the imported raws can potentially supply the domestic market till Indian mills are ready to commence cane crushing operations from end-October to early-November.

Besides banning exports and permitting duty-free imports, the Modi government, on July 28, imposed a stocking limit of 400 tonnes on all sugar dealers. Further, no dealer could hold any sugar beyond 30 days of receiving such stock.

On August 13, it issued a letter to all sugar mills directing them to furnish details of bulk consumers (soft drink and confectionary makers, sweetmeat sellers, etc.) to whom 500 tonnes or more sugar had been sold annually "directly or through agents" during the 2025-26 financial year (April-March).

One can expect the government to furnish details of bulk consumers (soft drink and confectionary makers, sweetmeat sellers, etc.) to whom 500 tonnes or more sugar had been sold annually "directly or through agents" during the 2025-26 financial year (April-March).

at the premier social science institute and were also worried because Mumbai was so far from their hometown. "But when she cleared the TISS entrance procedure (in 2024), the excitement I saw in her eyes cannot be put into words," said Ramesh, who accompanied her to Mumbai.

"I had to see the institute with my own eyes, meet its people, check her living conditions to ensure her safety so far away from home," he said.

Pranjal Deshpande, chairperson of TISS Centre for Water Policy and Governance, had earlier told *The Indian Express*, "Shrutika was doing great work

in the area of groundwater preservation. Her Master's dissertation on shallow aquifer management in Dhanbad was well-appreciated by faculty as well as those working in the field."

As Ramesh got ready to accept the degree on her behalf, he said, "She was the life of every gathering. Wherever she went, she would bring light and joy. Today too, she is giving us a reason to be joyful in celebration of her success."

The Baranwal couple will be attending TISS Centre for Water Policy and Governance, had earlier told *The Indian Express*, "Shrutika was doing great work

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C. Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Iran, S/o: Asraf, R/o: H.No. E-1339, Gali No. 14, Shri Ram Colony, Khajoori North East, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case Reg. No. 1214/24, U/s: 138 NI Act, Police Station Maurya Enclave, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Iran** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Iran** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Iran** of **Police Station Maurya Enclave, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **26.09.2026**.

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0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-ssjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SP City South, Jammu has intimated that accused person named Mohit Arora @ Lamba @ Mani @ Vipin Arora R/o H.No. 1344, Nehru Colony Majitha Road A/P H.No. 152, Lakshmi Vihar 27 foot Road City Amritsar is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 18/2026 U/s 303(2) BNS of P/S Satwari. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused. Kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Note :-

Name : Mohit Arora @ Lamba @ Manu
S/O : Vipin Arora
Address : H.No. 1344, Nehru Colony Majitha Road City Amritsar
A/P : H.No. 152, Lakshmi Vihar 27 foot Road City Amritsar

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-
1. DPO, Jammu : 091-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail ID : ssjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2609949
4. SP City South : 0191-2433778
5. SDPO City South : 0191-2430002
6. Landline of P/S Satwari : 01912-2430364

Sr. Superintendent of Police
Date:- 08.2026
DDJP-8591/26 - DATE 21 AUG 2026

ATTACKER LOCKED ALL OTHER HOUSES ON THE FLOOR WHERE WOMAN LIVED, SAYS FAMILY

Retired teacher killed at Jangpura home; youth spotted in CCTV clip

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, August 21

EVERY MORNING, 69-year-old Preeti Kumari, a retired school teacher, made tea and stepped out to distribute it among the homeless and vagabonds in her neighbourhood before heading to a community dispensary where she volunteered. Police suspect the attacker knew her routine and used it to target her early Friday, entering her ground-floor home in Jangpura's Punt Nagar, where Preeti was found dead on her bed, with her hands tied and face bearing injuries.

Preeti used to live alone. Police suspect the attack took place between 3 am and 4 am, after the assailant ransacked the house and fled.

Preeti was found dead around 8 am by her daughter Vijeta Arora, who had come to check on her.

"A case of trespassing, robbery and murder has been reg-

istered at Nizamuddin police station," a senior police officer said. Police are examining CCTV footage and questioning people in the area to identify the accused, who is suspected to be in his 20s.

Police said the accused — who wore a face mask, a T-shirt and capri — allegedly waited patiently for Preeti to open the door in the early hours. There were no signs of forced entry, they added.

Vijeta, who lives nearby, said, "I entered the house and saw her lying on the bed. She had injuries on her face and her hands were tied. All the items in the house were scattered."

The attacker locked some of the houses in the locality from outside before carrying out the crime," she added.

Vijeta's husband, Deepak Sachdeva, said that as per CCTV camera footage, it appears that the accused entered the house around 3.15 am. He alleged that the man had conducted a reconnaissance of the area and



had been seen in the locality on Thursday.

"It was a planned murder. My wife had gone to drop off our daughter, after which she told me that she wanted to go meet her mother. She resided on the ground floor and the doors of all five houses on the ground floor were latched from outside," Deepak said.

The family urged the residents' welfare associations and police to strengthen night patrolling in the area. "Several elderly people stay alone at their residence and security should be of prime importance," Deepak said.



Victim Preeti Kumari; (left) police officers outside her house on Friday. EXPRESS

robbery.

The attackers allegedly entered the house after knowing the doctor's routine, restrained him and strangled him with his pet dog's leash before fleeing with valuables.

The investigation later pointed to an alleged inside job, with the family's domestic help of nearly 24 years accused of sharing information about the house and its valuables with the perpetrators.

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 21

SEPTEMBER 13 is closing in on Delhi-NCR's eateries.

That is when the temporary relaxation allowing restaurants, hotels and other establishments to use fuels such as coal and high-speed diesel (HSD) is set to expire, amid a continuing disruption in natural gas supplies due to the West Asia conflict.

But Delhi-NCR's primary air pollution watchdog, the Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and Adjoining Areas (CAQM), is unlikely to extend the relaxation beyond September 13, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

"The decision on the matter is pending. Officials are concerned that continuing the relaxation through the winter could dilute the gains from restrictions on polluting fuels," a government official said.

Kitchens hit

At Khadak Singh Ka Dhabha, the pressure is already visible on the menu.

Disruptions in the supply chain have pushed up costs of raw material, forcing the restaurant to raise prices. LPG is available, but at a higher cost.

"Prices remain shot up, that's the concern for now," said Akshith Behl, growth and investment head at the restaurant.

For Behl and other restaurant owners, the fuel squeeze is part of a larger fallout from the West Asia crisis, which has disrupted natural gas supplies since March.

Temporary reprieve

Coal, kerosene and HSD are not part of NCR's normal approved fuel regime for industrial and commercial activities. Their use was allowed temporarily after the gas disruption left businesses looking for alternatives.

CAQM first relaxed the restrictions on March 13, allowing industries, hotels, restaurants and other establishments in NCR to use HSD, biomass and refuse-derived fuel pellets in place of natural gas. Where these alternatives were unavailable, coal and kerosene were also permitted.

Since then, the relaxation was extended three times — in April, June and August.

The relaxation until Sep-

EXPRESS exclusive

Extension of fuel relaxation unlikely for Delhi eateries



Zen restaurant in Connaught Place. The relaxation deadline runs out on September 13. EXPRESS

tember 13 came following a communication from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) dated August 13, which said that "the disruption in natural gas supply, which commenced in early March 2026 due to geopolitical developments in the Middle East, continues to persist".

Industries, hotels, restaurants and other establishments were allowed to use alternate fuels. "In case of limitation in availability of such alternative fuels," the order also permitted the use of coal or kerosene as an interim measure.

But, officials said, there is unlikely to be a fourth relaxation. "Supply related disruptions, alongside pollution concerns, would be taken up by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas. The decision then taken would determine the final outcome," said a senior official.

Coal and other unapproved fuels have been banned across Delhi-NCR for industrial and commercial use since January 1, 2023, as part of the region's transition towards cleaner fuels.

Their continued use could add to the pollution burden at a time when stagnant weather conditions already make it harder for the city to disperse pollutants.

Not going back to coal

Manpreet Singh, owner of Zen restaurant in Connaught Place and a member of the National Restaurants Association of India, said that while costs remained above pre-war levels, the sector's formal segment had not returned to coal.

But, Singh said, the larger concern was the continued dependence on coal among the unorganised sector, including

smaller eateries and dhabhas.

He also pointed at the difficulty of reversing the transition once establishments have invested in clean systems. "Once modern kitchens have shifted to electricity or non-gas-based tandoors, it's nearly impossible to go back," he said.

Higher costs

The shift towards PNG or LPG, however, has not come cheap. While industrial areas have transitioned to PNG, the shift has also meant higher costs, which has discouraged a full PNG adoption, the CAQM's Report of the Air Quality Experts on Identification of the causes for worsening AQI in Delhi-NCR had noted earlier this year.

It added, "While LPG penetration is fairly high in NCT, the use of solid fuels is prevalent in urban slums. Further, burning of solid fuels is highly prevalent in the semi-urban areas of NCR districts for both cooking and heating needs."

Winter emissions

CAQM had introduced its Standard List of Approved Fuels in 2022 as part of the shift towards cleaner fuels. It had identified natural gas, PNG, LPG, electricity, CNG, LNG and specified biofuels among the cleaner options, while coal, HSD, naphtha and light diesel oil were among the more polluting fuels being phased out.

Industry emissions are one of the dominant causes of air pollution with an overall 9% contribution in winter and 14% during summer. At 27%, secondary particulate emissions from power generation, including from industries, is the topmost contributor to pollution during winter.

AAP files complaint with ACB to probe 'corruption' in govt's bicycle scheme for girls

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 21

THE OPPOSITION AAP escalated its pitch on corruption against the BJP-led Delhi government as its Bharat MLA Sanjeev Jha on Friday filed a formal complaint with the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) of Delhi Police, seeking registration of an FIR and a criminal probe into alleged irregularities in the centrally sponsored scheme for Class 9 girls students.

Jha alleged large-scale corruption, bid-rigging and product substitution in a Rs 90-crore tender floated by the Directorate of Education (DoE) for procurement of 1,30,000 bicycles for Class 9 girls students under the Vidya Vahini Yojana, a flagship Delhi government scheme.

Education Minister Ashish Sood had previously said that the bicycle procurement was carried out through the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) following prescribed parameters and that the tender was awarded to the lowest eligible bidder. Sood's office refused to comment on the complaint.

In the letter, addressed to the Joint Commissioner of Police, ACB, Jha, the vice president of AAP's Delhi unit and the chief whip of the Opposition in the Delhi Assembly, alleged that DoE officials "conspired criminally with private entities" in the tender. "The target of this scheme has been completely subverted. It has been turned into a vehicle for illicit enrichment," the complaint said.

Further, the complaint alleged that the tender for Mountain Terrain Bicycles (MTBs) was floated at an estimated Rs 9,233 per unit, even as genuine mar-



AAP MLA Sanjeev Jha

ket values show that the identical tender specification MTBs can be procured at Rs 4,100 per unit. It alleged the final contract price of Rs 6,957 per unit caused a loss of Rs 36.7 crore to the state exchequer.

Jha claimed that the bidding process was manipulated by eliminating pre-bid interactions and putting in place unreasonable turnover caps, which he alleges systematically forces out the manufacturing hub in Punjab's Ludhiana.

The contract, the complaint said, was awarded to Mita Sports Private Limited, a local sports goods trading firm, whose promoters "have openly admitted they have never manufactured or sold a single bicycle prior to this tender". It further alleged that the originally specified model, the Hero Skyler 26T, stands discontinued with an expired trademark, and that the vendor is instead supplying a Hero Bonfire 26T variant with substandard wheel rims, tyres, pedal cranks and brake assemblies.

Jha requested the registration of an FIR for offences of criminal conspiracy, cheating and criminal misconduct by public servants against DoE officials, Mita Sports and sister concerns, as well as a probe into the alleged role of Sood.

Protest against reservation at Jantar Mantar — led by NEET aspirant and bizman brother

Alok Singh
New Delhi, August 21

AROUND A month after Jantar Mantar witnessed students' protests over the 2026 NEET-UG paper leak, the site in Delhi once again saw a stir on Friday. This time, the demonstration was over the reservation system — with students, farmers, homemakers, businessmen and others demanding reforms in caste-based reservation and UGC equity norms.

"We are not against reservation, but the criteria should be people's financial condition. If someone becomes a collector or SP, their children should not continue to get the benefit of reservation. Talented, poor children and widows should get the benefit," said Bablu Shukla, a farmer who came from UP's Barabanki.

Shukla's friend Anand Singh, a contractor, said: "Several generations have come and gone... All of them have used us as vote banks. Opportunities should be given to those who deserve, not based on reservation. The kind of reservation structure India has will weaken the country."

Friday's protest was led by NEET aspirant Harsh Dubey and his businessman brother Abhishek Agnihotri.

Dubey gained attention during a TV debate where he spoke about reservation and argued that students were failing to qualify due to the marginal difference in marks created by the reservation system.

Dubey, who hails from Uttar Pradesh, later posted videos on social media calling for a protest in demand of reforms in the reservation system.

On August 2, he announced that he would sit at Jantar Man-



The protesters at the site on Friday. EXPRESS

tar alone after obtaining permission from the Delhi Police. However, his request was turned down by the authorities citing the imposition of Section 163 of the BNSS that pertains to preventive orders to stop nuisance, danger or public disorder.

Sudha Sharma, a homemaker from northeast Delhi, arrived at the site with her sister. She said: "My sister is economically and financially weak, but she cannot get the reservation because she belongs to an upper caste. Why?"

"I came here after seeing Harsh Dubey on social media appealing to people to come to Jantar Mantar. He talked sense... He was raising our voices," Sharma said.

"We are holding a reservation reform movement. Reservation should be given to those who require it, not to everyone," Agnihotri said.

"The equity in UGC norms should be abolished," he added.

On Thursday, the Delhi Police had issued a rebuttal to social media posts on permission for the Jantar Mantar stir, stating that no permission had been granted. The police also advised citizens not to amplify,

forward or share "unverified content", adding that legal action could be initiated against people found creating or disseminating false news.

However, hours after protesters started arriving at Jantar Mantar on Friday, the Delhi Police offered Ramilla Maidan as an alternative venue.

Police later issued an NOC, allowing up to 500 protesters to hold a peaceful demonstration at Ramilla Maidan until 4 pm.

The protesters, however, refused to move.

Agnihotri said, "We are setting up our stage here at Jantar Mantar and are not going to shift. We have been here since morning, and the numbers are increasing. We are not going to leave this place."

Some protesters also demanded the abolition of the SC/ST Act. In the evening, protesters were also seen reciting the Hanuman Chalisa.

Officers kept appealing to the protesters to leave the site before a large number of Delhi Police and Rapid Action Force personnel cleared the site around 7.30 pm. Some protesters were detained, but released later.

HC dismisses Jockey Association plea against eviction from Delhi Race Club

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, August 21

THE DELHI High Court on Friday dismissed a plea by Jockey Association of India, which had moved the court challenging an order evicting them from Delhi Race Club premises on Lok Kalyan Marg.

The eviction order, passed by the estate officer on August 11, directed that the premises of Delhi Race Club be vacated within 15 days.

Justice Harish Vaidyana-

than Shankar, took note that the association is not a lessee

and dismissed the plea as not maintainable.

The association, in its petition, argued that though the eviction proceedings are against the Delhi Race Club, the association and its "jockeys, trainers, stable boys, and other members" are directly affected, "as eviction would disrupt their employment and livelihood" and leave them "without facilities to stable, train and exercise their horses".

According to the Club, it houses around 250 finely bred horses and that around 244 horse races and 1,600 inter-

venue races are conducted each year, and "directly and indirectly provides livelihood to more than 5,000 families."

The association pointed out that the Club "is a recognised heritage site... and the only facility in North India providing the specialised infrastructure required for thoroughbred horse racing, stabling, training and exercise."

The Central government's standing counsel Ashish Dixit argued that the association has no locus to challenge the eviction order and that they are not a lessee.

DESIGNER'S NEW FLAGSHIP NEAR QUTB MINAR IS PART LUXURY STORE, PART IMMERSIVE MUSEUM THAT REVIVES THE AURA OF THE CALCUTTA HE GREW UP IN

Sabyasachi's 'museum of memories': 120 chandeliers, 300 paintings, a love of past

Rinku Ghosh
New Delhi, August 21

"MY DAYS do not get over, my nights do not end, my memories refuse to step back or fade away" (*Amar din kaate na, amar raat kaate na/Smriti guch Kichuti picchu haate na*). The 70th hit Bengali song by Asha Bhonsle is a joyful celebration of holding on and not letting go. It helps you traipse into an elegant parlour and overwrought boudoir with paintings, family portraits, crystals, vases and porcelain figurines lit by 120 chandeliers, guiding your way to a Calcutta that was a way of life before it became Kolkata.

"Luxury lived and breathed under the vaulted arches and grand mansions of Chowringhee, in the jalsaghars of old zamindar homes and the Doric

pillars and louvered windows in the narrowest of galls," says designer Sabyasachi while treating guests to Makabari tea and his playlist of songs that left an imprint on him while growing up. "This is my museum of memories. It's an immersive experience of heritage anchors us in a world that does not make sense at times," he says, while walking his guests through his new 26,000 sq ft flagship store at One Style Mile, just behind Qutb Minar.

This also has a Gen Z connection. "The younger generations struggle for their identity and authenticity. And my experience tells me that the propensity to know their past which can anchor them comes only after their museum visits. A walkthrough here may give young people a sensory experience under one roof," he says.

The connection with museums is becoming more literal for Sabyasachi. Recently, the designer and The Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York announced a multi-year collaboration that will draw on the museum's collection of more than 5,000 years of art and culture and is in a world that does not make sense at times," he says, while walking his guests through Indian craftsmanship. The first chapter is a high jewellery collection inspired by the art of the Byzantine Empire, to be unveiled during New York Fashion Week in September. A few are on display here. "That chunky necklace looks cool, European, Egyptian and Indian at the same time. It is maximal without looking maximal," says a young influencer making reels.

The store is just not about selling his clothes, saris, jewels or art, it is about a mini exposi-



The 26,000 sq ft flagship store. EXPRESS

tion of history and adding a layer to wedding tourism. "Wedding is a reason for the family together from all parts of the globe. So while some decide on their wardrobe, others can take a tour of this place instead of a heritage tour," he says.

The layout mimics corridors alongside vintage salon cars



and first-class cabins in the imperial railways of yore. "Travels are the reason that antiques have now found me," he says. Now he gets them recreated by artisans in and around Kolkata. The walls are overlaid with textiles and carpets and are lined by glass cabinets full of curios, enamel boxes, jewellery, acces-

sories and knick-knacks, a perfect blend of European baroque and Indian excess.

Walking past the trademark Bengal tiger in a glass case reminiscent of the Calcutta tram, he recalls how it all began with the showcase, a glass-fronted wooden cabinet that was used in old Calcutta homes. "They had everything, from stone and gem boxes to clay fruits and ridiculously unimpor-

tant things or a broken piece of something, everything that the owner thought was valuable in his life. That's personal history and I have kept that concept across the store," he says.

For Sabyasachi, the impulse to collect and preserve is increasingly tied to a world in which the meaning of history

itself is becoming unstable.

"For a lot of people, history is six years old. There may be a time when history is six months old." In a digital world, he worries about how little there is to verify in the physical world that surrounds us. "Propaganda, fake news, what is being propagated, which is being obliterated, rewritten — where do you go to find the truth? It is in a museum," he says. Museums, he adds, are "beacons of truth and information".

It brings him back to the younger generation and their search for identity. "I have seen younger generations struggle for their identity and authenticity," he says. To form an opinion and an identity on their own

terms, he believes, people need to understand the past. That is why the propensity to seek truth, in his view, can begin with museum visits.

A portion of proceeds from the sales goes to the weavers and artisans. The 26,000 sq ft space brings together a dedicated well-stocked library, a parlour, a labyrinthine corridors lead through 120 chandeliers, nearly 200 antique carpets, 300 original paintings and more than 100 antique textiles, mirrors and decorative objects. "A luxury store should simply sell products. It should inspire curiosity, preserve culture and create memories. Commerce may bring people through the door, but culture is what makes them return," he says. That's why a 60-year-old and Gen Z bond over a gem-encrusted ring and a lacquer powder box.





Villagers assault CJP members visiting a government school as part of the outfit's 'School Think Karo' campaign, in Bagru village near Jaipur on Friday. (1)

Dipke warns of Jantar Mantar-like protest after attack on CJP volunteers

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, August 21

COCKROACH JANTA Party founder Abhijeet Dipke on Friday warned that he will lead a sit-in protest in Rajasthan after CJP leaders were allegedly attacked during an inspection of a government school near Jaipur.

Dipke, in a video message posted on social media, said that CJP leaders were assaulted and barred from entering the school, demanding action against those involved over the next 48 hours.

Earlier, CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka, who was with Dipke, said the team was stopped from entering the village by people who claimed to be residents but were actually 'goons summoned by the Bharatiya Janata Party'. "Their leader, Kamal Pradhan, engages in the work of encroaching on the land of poor people there. Children are being taught in a cowshed among buffaloes, and when attempts are made to stop this, the BJP is sending its goons. What a shameful situation," he said in a post on X.

The CJP team was trying to inspect a school in Rampura Kanwarpara village of Jaipur's Bagru Assembly constituency Friday morning as residents opposed a visit by the team to local government primary school.

Education Minister Madan Dilwar posted on X, "This is extremely regrettable. A school is a sacred space for building the future of children. Here, the focus should be on education, values, and a bright future for students — not politics... I appeal to all teachers, parents, and the general public. Refrain from such efforts and join hands in protecting the dignity of schools."

On Monday the Rajasthan

SC sets aside Madras HC order allowing Maran to call telecom secy as witness

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 21

THE SUPREME COURT on Friday set aside the Madras High Court's order allowing former Union Minister and DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran's request to summon the then Union Telecom Secretary as a court witness in the illegal telecom exchange case against him.

A bench of Justices K.V. Viswanathan and Arun Pillai said he could summon the Secretary as a defence witness if he wished to. "...We set aside the HC's order and restore the trial court's order. We permit the respondent to have the option to summon the Secretary. Telecom secy, as a defence witness if he so desires," the court ordered.

The SC was hearing an appeal by the CBI challenging the March 25, 2026, order of the Madras HC setting aside the October 10, 2025, trial court order refusing his plea. Hearing it on August 10, the HC asked the CBI if it would have any objection if the Telecom Secretary is summoned as a defence witness.

The top court restored the trial court order while allowing Maran to examine the Telecom Secretary as a defence witness.

Shah: Mamata govt refused land for fencing, shielded 'syndicate raj'

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, August 21

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah, who is on a three-day visit to West Bengal, lashed out at former chief minister and Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee for allegedly delaying land allotment needed for border fencing. He also claimed the previous TMC government did not notify the new criminal laws in the state to protect the "syndicate raj".

"I had been asking for 1,129 acres of land from 2014. I was tired of holding hands and feet. But she did not give the land," Shah said at a function organised by the Sahasra Seema Bal (SSB) in Siliguri.

Shah then praised Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari, saying, "Now, the state government's permission comes with just a phone call. The letter is sent later."

He further alleged that Banerjee did not attend any SSB function in the last 15 years. The SSB sent invitations, but she never responded, he claimed. Shah said that Banerjee had never attended a function of the central paramilitary forces such as the SSB or the Border Security Force. He emphasised that these agencies are not aligned with any political party or ideology and are neutral in safeguarding the nation.

Shah laid the foundation stones of several key border-security projects and later joined



Union Home Minister Amit Shah and West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari and others during a review meeting in Siliguri on Friday. (1)

SSB jaspers for lunch.

Highlighting the strategic importance of the Siliguri Corridor, Shah said 560 acres of land were required to secure the Chicken's Neck—the corridor in Bengal that connects the northeastern states with the rest of India—and Adhikari had granted approval. He added that a triangular security grid would be established for the area. The entire corridor is being monitored from three angles—Chopra, Kishanganj and Dhupguri—Shah said.

Shah also alleged that the previous Mamata-led TMC government did not notify the new criminal laws passed by Parliament, alleging that it wanted to protect the "syndicate, cut-money and extortion regime".

He asserted the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNS) and Bharatiya Sakshya

Adhiniyam (BSA), implemented by the Suvenudh Adhikari-led BJP government, was a "decisive" step towards "replacing the environment of fear (bhoi) with that of trust (bharosa)".

The BNS, BNSS and the BSA, which came into effect in the country on July 1, 2024, replaced the British-era Indian Penal Code, Code of Criminal Procedure and the Indian Evidence Act, respectively.

Addressing a gathering in Siliguri where Shah inaugurated an exhibition on the three criminal laws, he said, "While the entire country had begun implementing the new criminal laws, Banerjee never notified them. She knew that the laws would sound the death knell for her syndicate, cut-money and extortion regime."

The Union Home minister said Suvenudh Adhikari signed the file for notifying the new

laws as one of his first moves after taking charge as chief minister, enabling replacement of the British-era laws in the state. "You will now see how the three new criminal laws will protect citizens and safeguard property. These laws will ensure that justice can be delivered even up to the Supreme Court within three years. The Bengal Police will do what is required," Shah said.

Asserting that the BJP government has brought in the rule of law in the state, Shah claimed the regime change in Bengal and the introduction of various new rules have brought about positive changes in people's everyday lives. "Earlier, all you could hear was the sound of bombs," he said as he took a swipe at previous administrations, alleging the "cadre raj" during the Left Front's (BNS) rule was replaced by "gondra raj" under the Trinamool Congress. WITHPTI INPUTS

Day after SFI-ABVP clashes on JU campus, three FIRs registered

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, August 21

A DAY after the violent clashes broke out at the Jadavpur University campus, the Jadavpur Police on Friday registered three FIRs, including one against unknown persons and "outsiders" for alleged arson, vandalism and intimidation, in connection with the incident.

The first FIR followed a written complaint by the JU Vice-Chancellor, Prof (Dr) Chiranjib Bhattacharjee, at the Jadavpur Police Station.

The two other FIRs were filed against the two student groups — the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), and the Students' Federation of India (SFI) — for allegedly taking out protest rallies and blocking roads within the Jadavpur University jurisdiction, without any prior permission.

A clash had broken out on campus late Wednesday night over a conflict between two groups of the ABVP and the SFI.

In his complaint, the V-Chancellor said after 12.30 am on Thursday, a group of "unknown persons and outsiders" forcibly entered the campus and indulged in arson, vandalism, and intimidation.

Burning materials were allegedly thrown into Aurobindo Bhawan, where students and security personnel had taken

shelter, thereby endangering their lives, he added.

The complainant further stated that university property, including CCTV cameras, gates, and installations, were also damaged, and an attempt was allegedly made to forcibly open the main hostel gate. Further vandalism was reported around 2pm on Thursday, including damage to the University emblem and adjoining installations, the V-Chancellor said.

Based on the complaint, the first FIR was filed at Jadavpur Police Station and the police have started an investigation into the incident.

Charges have been invoked under Sections 3 and 4 of the Prevention of Damage to Public Property (PDPP) Act, and Sections of the BNS pertaining to unlawful assembly and riotous behavior, violent intimidation, causing hurt or grievous hurt, and wrongful restraint or damage to property.

As the clash spilled outside the campus on Thursday, the historic university emblem originally designed by legendary artist Nandalal Bose was also damaged.

The charges under the PDPP Act explicitly mention the destruction and disrespect of public property during the rampage, specifically the damage caused to the historic university emblem created by freedom fighter Nandalal Bose.

Imphal-Guwahati bus services to resume after 3 yrs

Imphal: Public transport along the Imphal-Dimapur-Guwahati route on National Highway-2 (NH-2) resumed on Friday after nearly three years, marking a significant step in the Manipur government's efforts to restore connectivity and normalcy in the state.

On the first day of the resumption, 125 passengers travelled along the route in two buses and five other passenger vehicles.

The vehicles passed through the sensitive districts of Kangpokpi, a Kuki-inhabited area, and Senapati, a Naga-inhabited area, during the afternoon without disruption before entering Nagaland en route to Guwahati. The restoration is vital for strengthening connectivity between Manipur and neighbouring states. ENS

The Manipur government's efforts to restore connectivity and normalcy in the state. On the first day of the resumption, 125 passengers travelled along the route in two buses and five other passenger vehicles.

ENS

Uttar Pradesh New and Renewable Energy Development Agency (UPNEDA)
(Deptt. of Additional Sources of Energy, Govt of U.P.)
Vibhuti Khand, Gomi Nagar, Lucknow-226010
Tel: 0522-2720179, 2720229, Mobile No: 9415690906
Website: www.upneda.org.in, E-Mail: ho_upneda@rediffmail.com

Notice Inviting Tender
UPNEDA invites Online Bids from Prospective Bidders through e-tender Portal for Supply, erection, testing and commissioning including comprehensive warranty maintenance for 5 years of Solar Power Plant under Capex Mode at various Government buildings in the State of Uttar Pradesh as per specification given in Scope of Work of Bid Document.

S. No.	Description	Capacity	Estimated Cost including GST (Rs)
1	ON GRID SOLAR ROOFTOP POWER PLANT		
1	1kW to 10 kW	5 MW	Rs 26.32 Crore
2	11kW to 100 kW	5 MW	Rs 25.07 Crore
3	101kW to 500 kW	1 MW	Rs 4.07 Crore
4	OFF GRID SOLAR POWER PLANT		
4	1kW to 10 kW	1 MW	Rs 10.14 Crore
5	11kW to 50 kW	1 MW	Rs 9.47 Crore
6	51kW to 75 kW	0.5 MW	Rs 4.64 Crore
7	HYBRID SOLAR POWER PLANT		
7	1kW to 10 kW	1 MW	Rs 10.34 Crore
8	11kW to 50 kW	1 MW	Rs 9.62 Crore
9	51kW to 75 kW	0.5 MW	Rs 4.70 Crore

The work completion time for all the above work is 4 (four) month from the date of issuance of work order. The Bid document is available at e-tender Portal from 22.08.2026 Interested bidders may view, download the Bid document, seek clarification and submit their Bid through e-tender Portal (https://vender.up.nic.in) upto the date and time mentioned in the table below:

(a) Availability of tender document on e-tender Portal	From: 22.08.2026
(b) Bid submission and date & time	On: 15.09.2026 upto 6:00 pm
(c) Pre Bid Meeting	On: 27.08.2026 at 12:30 pm
(d) Online technical Bid Opening date & time	On: 16.09.2026 at 11:30 am
(e) Financial Bid Opening date & time (Only of technically qualified bidders)	Shall be intimated later
(f) Venue of opening of technical & financial Bids	UPNEDA Head Office, Vibhuti Khand, Gomi Nagar, Lucknow-226010

Director, Uttar Pradesh New and Renewable Energy Development Agency, (UPNEDA) reserves the right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason thereof. The decision of Director UPNEDA will be final and binding.

हस्ताक्षर प्रण कर्जा सरदारण

Director, UPNEDA

SHILP DIDI 2026 Handicrafts Exhibition

Featuring 80 Women Artisans

Discover the artistry, craftsmanship and stories behind India's handicraft heritage

Duration: 16th - 31st August, 2026
Timings: 11:00 AM to 9:00 PM

Dilli Haat, INA, New Delhi

Aeronautical Development Agency
(Ministry of Defence, Govt. of India)
PB No. 1778, Vimanapura Post, Bangalore-560017

ADA: ADV-139-2026 20-08-2026

Engagement as Project Assistants on Tenure Basis

ADA is looking for meritorious Indian Nationals for Engagement as Project Assistant-4 on tenure basis in the following Disciplines.

Sl. No.	Engineering Discipline	No. of Tentative Vacancies
1.	Computer Science Engineering	15
2.	Electronics & Communication Engineering	20
3.	Aeronautical Engineering	10
4.	Electrical & Electronics Engineering	20
5.	Mechanical Engineering	43
6.	Metallurgy Engineering	01
7.	Civil Engineering	02

2. For Online Application and detailed advertisement, please log on to ADA website <https://ada.gov.in>

3. Online Applications shall be accepted w.e.f 24th August 2026 1000 hrs upto 02nd September 2026, 1700 hrs.

Director (Admin & HR), ADA

कपलिय बरेली विकास प्राधिकरण, बरेली
रामगं नगर बाबाजी चौक, सेक्टर-2, बरेली (उ.प्र.)
www.bareillyinfo.org, email: bdbareilly@gmail.com, bdbareilly@up.nic.in

पत्रांक: 885 / टी- / कापलियारा / 26 दिनांक- 21.08.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is a general information that Bareilly Development authority has been accorded Environmental Clearance by STATE LEVEL ENVIRONMENTAL IMPACT ASSESSMENT AUTHORITY (SIEAA) Uttar Pradesh for its EWS and LIG Housing Scheme At Village-Ilausa Beniram, Tehsil- Bareilly, District- Bareilly, State- Uttar Pradesh through Proposal No. SIA/UP/INFRA/2 57361/2026 File No.-11128 Dated 24-07-2026 the copy of Clearance letter is available on website (<https://iparishad.nic.in>).

Chief Engineer

ICAR-CENTRAL INSTITUTE FOR RESEARCH ON GOATS MAKHDHOM, P.O.FARAH-281 122, MATHURA U.P.
Phone: 0565-2763380 (Director), 0565-2763327 (Admin. Officer)
Fax No.0565-2763246

F.No.3-7(R&P)2026 Dated: 20th August 2026

VACANCY NOTIFICATION

Five (05) contractual position of Young Professionals in the various Projects and Institute are proposed to be filled through walk-in-interview on **03.09.2026 from 10:00 AM onwards**. Corrigendum if any will be published/uploaded on the Institute website/office only. Interested candidates may visit our website www.cirg.res.in for details.

Sd/- (Jagbir Singh) Administrative Officer

AstraZeneca
AstraZeneca Pharma India Limited
CIN No: L24231KA1979PLC003563
Regd. Office: Block N1, 12th Floor, Manya Embassy Business Park, Rachenahalli, Outer Ring Road, Bangalore - 560 045
Email: comp.secy@astrazeneca.com, Website: <https://www.astrazeneca.in/>
Tel: 080 6774 8000

PUBLIC NOTICE

(Under paragraph 24(i) of the Drugs Price Control Order, 2013)
Attention of the general public is drawn to the fact that AstraZeneca Pharma India Limited has revised the Maximum Retail Price (MRP) of following formulations due to waiver of Basic Customs Duty (BCD). The revised prices for the following products shall be applicable:

Product Name	Composition	Pack Size	Previous MRP (₹)	Revised MRP (₹)	Relevant S.O./GSR No. with date
IMJUDOB 300 mg	Tremelimumab concentrate for solution for infusion 300mg/15ml	1 vial	444,885.00	417,522.64	1. NPPA OM dated 12th February 2026 File No. 12/24/2021 (OP/NPPA/ Div/IV/II)-Part(1)
					2. Department of Revenue Notification No. 02/2026-Customs dated 01.02.2026

For AstraZeneca Pharma India Limited

Date: 22-08-2026
Place: Mumbai

Venkat Natarajan
Director - Market Access India

Approval ID: IN-17778, Date of Approval: 21/08/2026, Date of Expiry: 21/08/2028

No. ADM-120111/02/2024-office
Government of India
Ministry of Health and Family Welfare
Directorate General of Health Service
Central Drugs Standard Control Organization
(Drug Section)

Ministry of Health and Family Welfare invites applications from eligible candidates for filling up the post as mentioned below at Regional Drugs Testing Laboratory, Guwahati by **Deputation (including short term contract)**. Interested candidates are requested to submit the applications with full bio-data to Sh. Pawan Kumar, Deputy Director(Admin), Central Drugs Standard Control Organization (CDSCO), FDA Bhawan, Kotla Road, New Delhi-110002 within 60 days from the date of publication of this advertisement in the Employment News.

2. For further details please visit CDSCO website <https://cdsco.gov.in>.

Sl. No.	Name of the Post	Pay as per 7 th CPC	No. of Post	Office for which the post is filled up
1.	Senior Scientific Officer	Pay Level 11 of 7 th CPC (Rs. 67700 - 208700)	01	Regional Drugs Testing Laboratory, Guwahati

Sd/-
Deputy Director (Admn.)
C.D.S.C.O Headquarters



Let it Roll

LEADER of Opposition Rahul Gandhi took a quick snack break during his sit-in protest at the Parliament Street police station on Friday. Leading the dharna in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi, the senior Congress leader was seen having a roll from a popular eatery, along with a Diet Coke, amid sloganeering and demands for registration of an FIR over pellet injuries suffered by a youth during the BJP-led Jantar Mantar protests last month. Gandhi, who was sitting with Rajiv Lochav, the alleged victim of the 2020 protests, and his mother, however, ensured his fellow protesters were served the same snack before he savoured his share.

Packed Schedule

BJP PRESIDENT Nitin Nambin has a packed weekend ahead of him as he returns to the Capital after a significant interaction with the top leadership of the RSS at the latter's three-day Samanway Bathak in Vizag. Over the coming two days, Nambin is set to interact with over 60 newly appointed members of his team, brainstorm over a national programme aimed at taking Prime Minister Narendra Modi's achievements to households and chalk out a strategy to reach out to the Gen Z youths who have more than made their presence felt following the protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar.

Srinagar: Mirwaiz returns to lead Friday congregation at Jamia Masjid

Srinagar: Kashmir's chief cleric Mirwaiz Umar Farooq returned to Jamia Masjid, Srinagar, on Friday after being restricted to his residence several times over the past two weeks.

Addressing the Friday congregation, Mirwaiz said that "every opportunity he gets to lead prayers at Jamia Masjid, he counts as a blessing from Allah", as that restrictions and attempts to "silence the pulpit" of the historic mosque seem to be part of the state policy nowadays.

Mirwaiz further said that "it is a time to bear with patience, and continue the good work, however, possible." ENS

Vande Mataram row: Himachal House adjourned in 11 minutes

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, August 21

THE OPENING day of the monsoon session of the Himachal Pradesh Vidhan Sabha on Friday was washed out amid an uproar over the singing of the National Song, Vande Mataram. The House was adjourned for the day within 11 minutes of the beginning of the proceedings.

The session began with the National Anthem, after which BJP MLA Vipin Singh Parmar demanded that Vande Mataram should be sung and sought permission from Speaker Kuldeep Singh Pathania to raise the issue. Parmar also accused the Congress of "insulting" the National Song by deciding to sing only two stanzas of Vande Mataram at its events. He said the Centre has enacted a new law making it mandatory to sing the full version of the National Song first whenever Vande Mataram and the National Anthem are performed together.

Pathania, who was about to read the obituary references, said that the provision concerning the singing of the National Song has been introduced by the Centre for government events and did not directly apply to the proceedings of the Vidhan



Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu and Congress MLAs outside the Himachal Pradesh Assembly in Shimla on Friday. **PH**

Sabha. Citing convention, he said it was a long-standing practice that House proceedings begin with the National Anthem, while the National Song is sung at the conclusion of the session. Parmar further said that in keeping with the tradition, Assembly sessions will begin with Jana Gana Mana and conclude with Vande Mataram.

Urging the Opposition to cooperate, he said that the first day is reserved for obituary references and paying tribute to departed members and assured that the full version of Vande Mataram would be sung at the

conclusion of the session.

The explanation, however, failed to cut ice with the Opposition members who started raising slogans against the ruling Congress. From treasury benches, Congress MLA Kewal Singh attacked the Opposition. He, along with other Congress members raised slogans against the BJP and accused the Opposition of disrespecting the National Anthem. Amid the face-off, the Speaker adjourned the House for the day.

Outside the House, Congress leaders, including Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu, Cab-

net ministers Rajesh Dharami, Vikramaditya Singh, state Congress chief Vinay Kumar, raised slogans against the BJP.

Sukhu alleged that the BJP MLAs insulted the National Anthem by raising objections regarding the tradition of singing it before the National Song. He said a controversy over the national song is being "manufactured" and it has caused resentment among the public. He urged the BJP not to "stoop to such a low level of politics" that the issue of respecting national symbols becomes a subject of political confrontation. He also accused the BJP of bowing out of proportion to divert public attention from issues like inflation, NEET paper leak, corruption, and increase in sugar prices.

Meanwhile, Pathania said, "The House is supreme. The Vidhan Sabha runs as per convention. Today was the first day of the monsoon session. As per the set precedent and convention, the obituaries of legislators who have passed away are read. The Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha function as per their respective rules. In the Lok Sabha too, the National Anthem is sung first; the same convention will be followed here... The House is not bound to any authority."

'Vande Mataram debate not going to get us anywhere'

AT TELANGANA'S Independence Day function last weekend, the entire Vande Mataram was sung. It was one of the three Congress-ruled states to do so along with Karnataka and Himachal Pradesh. Days later, the Congress Working Committee (CWC) reiterated its 1937 resolution that only the first two stanzas of the song would be sung at party events. This has created a sense of unease in sections of the party.

In an interview, state Congress president **B Mahesh Kumar Goud** tells **Nikhila Henry** that while the party has its stand on Vande Mataram, it cannot arm-twist the elected government to choose one version or the other. The party, which is battling internal disciplinary issues, is still concentrating on what the common man needs in the country and not on debates over Vande Mataram, Goud says. Excerpts:

The Congress leadership recently decided to stick to singing 2 stanzas of Vande Mataram instead of all 6.

But in Telangana's I-Day event, the party sang all 6 stanzas. Why?

Going by the All India Congress Committee's decision, the Telangana Pradesh Con-



B MAHESH KUMAR GOUD
TELANGANA CONGRESS CHIEF

gress Committee will follow the same rule about Vande Mataram — decided by the CWC. But, as far as the government is concerned, what version of Vande Mataram should be sung is entirely up to the CM and Cabinet. It is the discretion of the CM which version should be followed. As far as the party is concerned, we will follow the AICC directive.

Was there a need to get into the Vande Mataram debate given that several party workers and leaders are not comfortable with it?

We have been singing one version of Vande Mataram for the past several decades. So, what is the need for a controversy over this now? Ultimately,

everyone has to respect the nation, democracy, and the Constitution. We are all bound to respect them as true Indians. So, this debate over Vande Mataram is not going to get us anywhere.

Our job is to get welfare to the poorest of the poor. That should be our prime agenda and not Vande Mataram. What have we gained in the past 12 years of the (PM Narendra) Modi government? What did the common man gain?... They are closing public sector institutions one by one. The whole of the government is now in favour of the corporate sector. No common man has gained from this government. Instead of debating what concerns common people, we are debating Vande Mataram.

Congress in Telangana is dealing with disciplinary issues. Notices have been served to many leaders. What is happening?

...These are senior party leaders. We respect them. But irrespective of their seniority or personality, if someone crosses the line, we will have to act... There are forums in the party to express disagreement or opinion, but to speak publicly against party leadership is uncalled for. So, the disciplinary measures.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

A b'day wish with perfect timing: Why PM's greeting to Sitharaman says a lot

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, August 21

AS THE BJP organisational revamp sparks off talk again of a Union Cabinet reshuffle, one Minister's stock shot up this week. Wishing Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on her birthday on August 18, Prime Minister Narendra Modi lauded her role in "India's reforms and economic development" and "in the Centre's endeavours for a strong and self-reliant" India.

Sitharaman replied within the hour, telling the PM, "Your guidance has always served as a motivation to me".

In Delhi's power corridors, the exchange is being seen as vote of confidence for Sitharaman, India's longest-serving full-time woman finance minister. Modi's mention of her role in "reforms and economic development" is particularly significant at a time when India hopes to maintain its 7% growth momentum while keeping inflation in check and overcoming the setbacks of capital outflows and the energy- and supply-chain disruptions resulting from the West Asia conflict.

That she is at the forefront of these efforts was also underlined by her "leading" a ministerial delegation to Singapore to participate in the 4th India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable



Union ministers Nirmala Sitharaman and S Jaishankar with Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary during a meeting in New Delhi on Friday. **PH**

(ISMR) on August 19-20. A post on X by the Ministry of Finance specified this clearly. "The FM is leading a delegation that comprises Dr D K Joshi, Minister of External Affairs; Shri Piyush Goyal, Union Minister for Commerce & Industry; and Shri Atin Prasad, Union Minister of State for Electronics & IT and Commerce & Industry."

The ISMR provides a platform to review progress in India-Singapore collaboration efforts and to explore new areas across six pillars: advanced manufacturing, connectivity, digitalisation, healthcare and medicine, skills development, and sustainability. On August 17, Sitharaman chaired the third meeting of the Apex Monitoring Authority of the National Industrial Corridor Development

and Implementation Trust.

At the meeting, also attended by Piyush Goyal, Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav and NITI Aayog Vice-Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri, she urged states to resolve bottlenecks relating to land, connectivity, utilities, and statutory clearances in industrial corridors.

Most significantly, after the students' protest at Jantar Mantar last month, Sitharaman has been among the few leaders of the BJP fronted by the party to make an outreach to young citizens. She spoke about how the young have their ears closer to the ground, has denied that the government ever tried to stop protesters over examination paper leaks, and acknowledged issues in the education and employment sectors.

In an interview with *The Indian Express* earlier this week, she reiterated this, when asked about a significant number of graduates being neither in education nor training. Admitting deeper structural issues, she said, "...courses which all of us go and join and come out of... they don't ready you for jobs. But ironically, they don't even ready you for becoming an entrepreneur... Our university courses give you a certificate, which is a bachelor's degree, on something. If you have done Economics or Political Science, what do you do with it afterwards? After BA, what do you do? You go for an MA. But after an MA, you need to have something."

Also during the week, Sitharaman held meetings with chiefs of 12 public sector banks, where she nudged them to up their "cool" quotient in the eyes of the young, without sacrificing the prudence that the business requires. She said that having grown up with smartphones, the young are tech savvy and expect banking to be simple, intuitive, personalised, and available at all times. And, public sector banks could "not be 'not cool'". "Please get some young people to talk to you about what makes you appear cool. At least one portion of your banks, where they deal with customers, you can make sure that everything is 'cool'."

Telangana CM's trip to US cancelled after Govt denies clearance

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, August 21

TELANGANA CHIEF Minister A Revanth Reddy's visit to the United States has been cancelled after the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) denied permission, saying "clearance from political angle is denied", his office said on Friday.

"The visit of Chief Ministers, as in the case of other dignitaries, is assessed by the ministry in order to accord political clearance. The program proposed in such cases should be appropriate to the office held and the purpose of the visit. In this particular case, that was not so in respect of the US. Therefore, clearance has not been given. Incidentally, his visit to the UK has been cleared," the MEA said in a statement.

Reddy, who had embarked on a 10-day tour of the UK and the US with a "Telangana Rising" delegation on August 20 to sign MoUs with educational institutions, will return from London to Hyderabad on August 23, instead of leaving for Boston. "Future of youth, development of state, country should be above politics. I have always believed we should all think beyond politics and polls when it comes to nation-building and the future of the youth," Reddy said, responding to the development.

Officials said that the state government had sought per-



Telangana CM A Revanth Reddy will return from London to Hyderabad on August 23. FILE

mission from the Centre on August 16, but only the UK trip was approved. The Centre informed the state government of its refusal of permission after the official delegation reached the US. Reddy has instructed the delegation to proceed with the US tour and sign MoUs with top educational institutions such as Harvard, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Northeastern University and Virginia Tech.

On Friday and Saturday, Reddy is scheduled to meet officials from Oxford, Cambridge and other top British schools in London. "Telangana Rising is unstoppable. The only purpose of the visit was to, as part of the Centre's new education policy, bring the world's best institutions to India, to Telangana, to Hyderabad... We will make Hyderabad a global knowledge hub..." Reddy said.

48 teachers from across country to be honoured on September 5

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 21

PRESIDENT Droupadi Murmu will confer the National Teachers' Awards on 48 school teachers on September 5, on the occasion of Teachers' Day, the Ministry of Education said on Friday.

According to the Ministry, the awardees were selected through a three-stage selection process carried out at district, state and national levels by the Department of School Education & Literacy — to identify teachers who made exemplary contributions to school education and student development.

The 48 awardees represent 27 states, seven UTs and six organisations under the Central government. Of the total awardees, 26 are men and 22 are women. Short documentaries highlighting the exemplary work and achievements of each awardee will also be showcased during the award ceremony.

The Department organises the National Teachers' Day event annually on September 5, to honour outstanding school teachers from across India.

"The purpose of the Award is to celebrate the unique contribution of some of the finest teachers in India and honour those teachers who, through their commitment, have enriched the lives of their students," the Ministry said.

Remembering Niketu Iralu: Peace activist, bridge between Nagas, mainland India



WE WORK with people professionally all our lives, but it is only a few who really touch us in a meaningful way. Niketu Iralu from Nagaland, who became my introduction to the Northeast. In 1968, he took me and Kalpana Sharma, both aspiring journalists then, to Chedema, perched on a hilltop surrounded by lush green vegetation, not far from Kohima. A peace camp had been set up there which had negotiated a ceasefire in 1964 between the rebel Naga Federal Government (NFC) which declared Nagaland's independence on August 14, 1947. He, however, chose another path — and came to be known as a peace activist dedicated to the pursuit of solutions through non-violence, dialogue and reconciliation.

As news spread of the death of "uncle Niketu" as he was popularly known, social media

was flooded with glowing tributes. Hundreds gathered at the Dimapur airport to pay their last respects as his body arrived from Delhi. People lined up along the roadside villages to say a final farewell as the convoy made its way to his home, *Kuryung Ki* or "The House of Listening", in Sechu Zubza in Kohima district, where many had sought wisdom and healing touch from him.

I met Niketu Iralu in Delhi first in the mid-1960s. He became my introduction to the Northeast. In 1968, he took me and Kalpana Sharma, both aspiring journalists then, to Chedema, perched on a hilltop surrounded by lush green vegetation, not far from Kohima. A peace camp had been set up there which had negotiated a ceasefire in 1964 between the rebel Naga Federal Government (NFC) which declared Nagaland's independence on August 14, 1947. He, however, chose another path — and came to be known as a peace activist dedicated to the pursuit of solutions through non-violence, dialogue and reconciliation.

As news spread of the death of "uncle Niketu" as he was popularly known, social media

found a solution though a new ministerial panel was formed by the Centre last week to take forward the stalled talks. Our Chedema visit was a discovery of the colourful tapestry of tribes and communities that make up the Northeast region — a confluence of diverse races, a gateway to Southeast Asia connected to the rest of India by a narrow "chicken's neck".

We experienced the Nagas' incredible hospitality, and saw the amazing community spirit of a clan. This was visible even as Niketu lay in a Delhi hospital during his last days, with many nieces and nephews who accompanied him and his wife Christine — a city girl from Mumbai who made the Naga hills her home — to the national capital for his treatment. They took care of him round the clock, along with his son Kevipule.

Niketu's long journey

The life of Niketu ran parallel to the saga of modern Nagaland. He would recall the time when the Japanese Army invaded Nagaland in 1944 during the Second World War. Their village Khonoma was run over by the invaders, forcing them to escape

to the forest. One day, Niketu and his brother were fishing in a stream when they suddenly found the Japanese soldiers bathing nearby. He looked straight into their eyes and ran in the opposite direction, through the thorny bushes.

When his mother and a teenage sister went back to their home in Khonoma to pick some provisions, they found a Japanese soldier helping him to tie a Naga shawl. Incensed, his sister slapped the soldier. His mother was petrified about what the soldier would do. But he just bowed slightly, and left. Recalling the incident years later, Niketu said, "Maybe he also had a sister back home."

The Japanese retreated after the battle of Kohima. Had they not been halted, they might have reached the Brahmaputra valley and then on to mainland India — and history would have been written very differently. The words at the Kohima War Cemetery, which Niketu took to us to visit, were to stay with me to this day: "When you go home, tell them of us and say, for their tomorrow, we gave our today."



{ NIKETU IRALU }
1935-2026

people and the rest of India. When Phizo died in April 1990 in London, Niketu was asked by the NNC leaders to help them get his body back to India. Phizo had been in exile since 1960 when he left for the UK to mobilise world opinion for the Naga cause.

The V P Singh government was then at the helm in Delhi. Rajmohan Gandhi, grandson of Mahatma Gandhi, was a Janata Dal Rajya Sabha MP, and Niketu's friendship with him went three decades back as they had worked together in an or-

ganisation. Initiatives of Change, to bring about social transformation through "personal change".

The Janata Dal-led government was worried that bringing back Phizo's body might lead to violence in Nagaland. Rajmohan told PM Singh and Union Minister Mufti Sayeed, "Let the Nagas grieve as much as they want. If we don't allow that, then there might be violence." Finally, they agreed.

The then finance minister Madhu Danavate, who used to start his day early, met Rajmohan and Niketu at 5 am at his residence. Niketu told him he did not need money, which the Nagas had collected, but only foreign exchange clearance. Rajmohan received Phizo's mortal remains and Niketu at the Palam airport's technical area. The casket was immediately shifted to a Home Ministry plane which took the group to Kohima where the funeral was held.

One of the enduring images I have of Niketu is of him getting out of a Mahashila transport bus in which our group were travelling, and rushing to a wash room at a village stop — cleaning it with water and bare

hands, for all of us to use. The gesture reflected his care, and respect, for other people.

Humour and music were his language, and it endeared him to the young and old alike. He used to describe his first encounter with mainland India when he left for Madras Christian College in the 1950s for studies. "When I reached Kolkata... the number of people trying to board the train made me say to myself we have no chance to survive in this — India, which has so many people!" Even on his hospital bed a day before he passed away, he joked about the balding head of one of his old friends who had rushed from Pune to see him, and then clung onto his hand. While deeply committed to his people, he had befriended many across India.

A Naga elder associated with many prominent organisations in the Northeast, who was recipient of several prestigious awards including the Bhupen Hazarika Integration Award, Niketu's work deepened the idea of peace and reconciliation today in the midst of spiralling global conflicts. This was summed up in a

tribute in Ukhrul Times by a young writer Markson V. Luikham, who never met him but was in touch with him on the phone and through emails.

"He was a deeply human man who spent decades asking Nagas to... confront their failures, resist hatred and recover the courage to listen," Niketu did not see reconciliation as weakness, he wrote, adding that to him moral courage also involved "telling one's own side what it does not want to hear."

When he heard of his passing away, a Parsi friend of Niketu, sitting far away in London, decided to honour his memory by singing to herself a song he loved: "Kohima, all night the stars salute you, your forests dark and towering hills above, deep in our hearts, though far away and few, we yearn for home, a land we love."

And now he lies in rest, forever under those Nagaland stars, as when he sang to herself of his house in Sechu Zubza.

Neeraja Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, *The Indian Express*, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of 'How Prime Ministers Decide'

Protests in Kishtwar as minor girl dies during abortion, headmaster who raped her arrested

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 21

A GOVERNMENT school headmaster allegedly raped a minor tribal girl student over several months, inducing a pregnancy that ended with her death after a failed abortion attempt and subsequent stillbirth in Jammu and Kashmir's Kishtwar district.

Following the girl's death late on Thursday night, protests broke out in her village and spread to different parts of the district by Friday morning. The girl was pregnant for seven months and died on her way to Jammu, where she was being delivered after her condition deteriorated following the stillbirth in another district of the region, protesters alleged.

Police have arrested the accused headmaster and his brother who accompanied him while taking the girl to different districts for the abortion bid and the delivery, respectively.

Kishtwar SSP Naresh Singh said that an FIR has been registered under relevant provisions of the BNS and further investigation is underway. The education department has initiated an enquiry and placed the headmaster under suspension.

Giving details, a local tribal leader from the girl's village said the headmaster had been raping her for months but she did not inform her parents out of fear and shame. However, a fortnight ago, the girl complained of stomach pain and was taken to the local primary health centre where it emerged after treatment that she was pregnant, said the local leader. The girl then informed her parents about the headmaster who, when called over, offered money and threatened them into remaining silent.

The tribal leader said the girl's family lives in a remote part of Kishtwar with no mobile phone connectivity. Her father did not approach police, fearing the stigma that it would bring to the family, he said.

On Wednesday, the accused and his brother visited the girl's family again and took her to a Kishtwar facility for abortion. The girl's father and an uncle accompanied them in their vehicle, locals said. After a medical check-up, the girl was referred to a nearby town where efforts were made to induce child birth through surgery, locals said.

Sources said that during the delivery, the girl's condition deteriorated, and the accused and his brother decided to take her and her stillborn towards Jammu. By Thursday night, on the way, the girl breathed her last near Udhampur. The accused then arranged a private ambulance to take both the bodies to the girl's village.

As the bodies arrived, villagers erupted in protest. The next day, the town under which the girl's village falls observed complete bandh. After Friday prayers, protests spread to several other parts of Kishtwar district, with protesters demanding judicial enquiry into the matter.

The accused have been arrested under BNS section 6(1) that deals with criminal conspiracy, section 65 (1) pertaining to rape on minor female, section 90 (death caused by act intended to cause miscarriage), and section 92 (causing death of an unborn child). Apart from these, both the accused have also been booked under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

The three-judge bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Augustine George Masih gave the majority opinion while Justice K Vinod Chandran dissented. "We find considerable force in the reasoning that a civil judgment from the very first day in office will be required to deal with matters of life, liberty, property and personal rights and therefore familiarity with the actual working of courts, courtroom procedure and the respective roles of the Bench and Bar is necessary," the CJ said.



Rescue Mission

Rescue teams help residents in a flood-affected area in Guwahati on Friday. PTI

SC modifies 3-year practice rule for judicial service entry

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 21

THE SUPREME COURT Friday declined to revisit its May 2025 judgment restoring a minimum three-year practice requirement for entry into the judicial service but modified the manner in which the condition will now operate.

The three-judge bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Augustine George Masih gave the majority opinion while Justice K Vinod Chandran dissented.

"We find considerable force in the reasoning that a civil judgment from the very first day in office will be required to deal with matters of life, liberty, property and personal rights and therefore familiarity with the actual working of courts, courtroom procedure and the respective roles of the Bench and Bar is necessary," the CJ said.

The matter stems from the top court's May 2025 ruling that restored the requirement for a candidate to have three years of practice as an advocate before entering the judicial service, reversing a 2002 decision that had allowed fresh law graduates to apply directly. This judgment was challenged by aspirants who argued that the ruling was unsupported by empirical data and ignored the practical training already built into legal education. The Supreme Court, earlier this year, subsequently allowed the review petitions to be heard in open court.

While pronouncing the order on Friday, the bench observed that "the sudden restoration of the requirement without any transitional arrangement has visited hardship upon law graduates who have prepared their professional lives on the basis of the regime that prevailed for over two decades" and held that the same objective could be achieved through "a structured combination of institutional training at the State Judicial Academies and supervised law clerkship, which shall be treated as equivalent to practice at the Bar for the purposes of eligibility."

The court carved out a two-year transition window for recruitment notifications issued between May 20, 2025, and March 31, 2027. During this period, fresh law graduates will be allowed to apply for judicial service examinations despite not having completed the practice requirement.

The bench said that since more than a year has elapsed since the 2025 judgment, such candidates would be deemed to have completed one year of practice and would not be required to furnish any certificate to that effect.

PM: India's stability, reforms bright spot for global growth

On regulations, Modi says moving from 'prohibited unless permitted to permitted unless prohibited'

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 21

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Friday said India has political stability and continuity in its policies, and the world sees it as a "bright spot of growth and hope".

Speaking at the Economic Times World Leaders Forum 2026, the PM said India has always moved forward with the spirit of a shared future at a "structured combination of institutional training at the State Judicial Academies and supervised law clerkship, which shall be treated as equivalent to practice at the Bar for the purposes of eligibility."

"This atmosphere of distrust is bringing numerous new challenges for the world. Even in such times, the world is seeing India as a bright spot of growth and hope," he said.

Seeking to underline India's growth journey, the importance of next-generation reforms and the transformation underway across key sectors such as manufacturing, technology, infrastructure and governance, PM Modi said India today is moving forward with political stability, policy continuity and a strong reform mindset.

"We are moving from 'prohibited unless permitted' to 'permitted unless prohibited'. Through Jan Vishwas, decrimi-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaks during the Economic Times World Leaders Forum 2026, in New Delhi on Friday. PTI

nalisation, removal of many obsolete laws, we are reducing the burden on citizens and enterprises," he said.

At the core of India's "reform journey," he said, is a change in the "philosophy of governance" and a "completely different" approach that incentivised production, encouraged ambition and "trusted our entrepreneurs," India, he said, has moved "from controlling enterprises to enabling them". "Our approach is rooted in trust, ease of living, ease of doing business and creating greater opportunities for the people. In the times to come, the reform express will continue to move with greater speed and determination," the PM said.

"Nothing is possible in isolation, so this theme of Shared Future has become even more relevant. India has always moved forward with this very spirit. That is why, during India's G20 Presidency, the man-

tra was 'One Earth, One Family, One Future,'" he said.

Referencing his speech from the Red Fort on August 15, Modi reiterated his "Sapta Dhara framework for Viksit Bharat" — manufacturing, agro-food production and food processing, technology and innovation, logistics, defence, green and blue economy, and soft power.

"India today is undertaking next-generation reforms at the policy level so that our future is secure. It is reforming governance and ease of living. Reform is not a compulsion for us, it is our commitment, it is our conviction," he said. The IMF forecast for India says it will remain the world's fastest growing major economy, he said, adding that the country was taking steps that were giving momentum to the development.

"To my young generation there will be surprises to hear that there was a time in our country when if a company exceeded the fixed production limit, it would be punished. This was the PLP (Production Linked Incentive) model of the previous licence raj governments," he said. "There have also been instances where if a factory produced more due to higher demand, it would receive a notice. Those who mock Make in India and Atmanirbhar Bharat today had ancestors with the same mindset," he said.

"The foundation of the relationship between the government and the citizens should not be on suspicion, but trust... We are taking this reform mindset forward in the government-enterprise relationship" the PM said.

Sohrabuddin encounter: Plea in SC challenges acquittal of 22 accused

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 21

A PLEA has been filed in the Supreme Court challenging the Bombay High Court order acquitting 22 accused including 21 policemen in the alleged 2005 fake encounter case involving Gujarat gangster Sohrabuddin Shaikh, his wife and aide Tulsiram Prajapati.

The petition has been filed by Nayabuddin Shaikh, younger brother of deceased Sohrabuddin Shaikh, challenging the May 7 order of the high court which, while acquitting the accused, said that the prosecution had failed to establish the case. On May 7, the high court observed it finds no ground to interfere with the trial court judgment acquitting the accused and added that the prosecution case is based on circumstantial evidence and there are several broken links in the chain of circumstances.

It had dismissed the appeals filed by Rubabuddin and Nayabuddin, challenging the December 2018 judgment of a special CBI court in Mumbai acquitting all the accused in the case.

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 21

SHE USED to work as an air hostess before she left the aviation industry to begin preparation for public service examinations. After being selected in the Madhya Pradesh Public Service Commission (MPPSC), she worked in several districts of the state, including key ones such as Khandwa and Guna. During her tenure as City Superintendent of Police (CSP) in Guna, she was credited with introducing women's mobile police stations at three police stations, intended to allow women to resolve certain disputes closer to their homes.

Now, Neha Pachisia has found herself in the limelight for a very different reason.

As an investigating officer in a case in Katni, where she is the CSP, Pachisia is accused of demanding Rs 15 lakh from the family of a man accused in a murder case. When they expressed inability to pay the amount, the officer allegedly got the land belonging to the father of the accused transferred to a person linked to her

at a fraction of its market rate.

An FIR has been registered against her and two others, with investigators examining the alleged exchange of money, the disputed land transaction, and the financial links between the people involved. The allegations have now prompted Chief Minister Mohan Yadav to order Pachisia's immediate suspension.

In an official statement on Friday, Yadav said the Katni issue was extremely serious and that negligence, pressure or misuse of official position in matters concerning law and order would not be tolerated at any level. He also ordered an impartial investigation and said strict action would be taken against those found responsible in the matter.

Jabalpur Range Inspector General (IG) Pramod Verma said, "An FIR has been registered against CSP Pachisia and two other individuals under sections related to extortion, cheating, criminal conspiracy and misuse of official position. The matter relates to a murder case that Pachisia was investigating."

He said, "It is alleged that,

EXPRESS special

From airhostess to City SP to extortion accused: MP cop at centre of land grab row draws CM's ire



Neha Pachisia

with the intention of providing undue benefit to the accused, she demanded a bribe of Rs 15 lakh. When the accused said that he did not have the money, the land belonging to his father was transferred and registered in the name of one of her associates."

The police inquiry subsequently turned to the property transaction and the money trail behind it.

The family of Akash Lodhi, who was arrested in July in connection with the murder of a tribal man and released on bail in July, alleged that Pachisia pressured them to sell 2.15 hectares of land in Kanhawa in exchange for relief in the murder case. According to the complaint, Pachisia and the then station house officer allegedly demanded money in return for altering statements in court and facilitating the release of the accused.

The subsequent inquiry examined the circumstances surrounding the land transaction and found a significant disparity between its official value and the price at which it was sold.

The land had a guideline value of more than Rs 82 lakh, but the sale deed was executed for just Rs 18.20 lakh. Investigators alleged that the transaction was carried out under police pressure, with Maroof Ahmed Hanafi, named as the buyer in the documents, acting as a frontman.

The inquiry found that Hanafi did not have sufficient funds to independently finance the purchase. On April 15, the day the land was registered in his name, Rs 15 lakh was credited into his bank account — Rs 10 lakh from an account belonging to a firm called Shine

Partners and another Rs 5 lakh from one Kshitij Raj Barapatre.

The investigation was conducted by senior police officers at Jabalpur police range where statements of more than 10 people connected with the matter were recorded during the inquiry, while Pachisia also appeared before the inquiry officer and recorded her statement.

Pachisia's office was sealed after a case was registered against her and two other accused, Hanafi and Barapatre. The three have been booked under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita's (BNS) sections 61 (forgery of valuable documents), 198 (false statements), 199 (false declarations), 307 (theft after preparation made for causing death, hurt, or restraint) and 318(4) (cheating and dishonestly inducing delivery of property).

The controversy, though, is not the only one that Pachisia has found herself at the centre of this year.

In July, she faced allegations of demanding Rs 30,000 from a transporter during a vehicle check. Following this, her driver was suspended, and she was relieved of the charge of three police stations.

The all-India coordination meeting held wide-ranging discussions on demographic imbalance, drug abuse, youth concerns, systemic shortcomings

of corruption and the government must take steps to address these gaps, he said.

Officer-bearers and workers of 32 Sangh-affiliated organisations participated in the coordination meeting.

On demographic changes, Mukunda said certain communities were witnessing a massive increase in their population while others were decreasing, and this imbalance has been debated.

"The all-India coordination meeting held wide-ranging discussions on demographic imbalance, drug abuse, youth concerns, systemic shortcomings

Now, Jharkhand High Court stays cancellation of key JSSC-CGL exam

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, August 21

THE JHARKHAND High Court on Friday stayed the state government's decision to cancel the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) examination and the Child Development Project Officer (CDPO) examination.

It was the cancellation of the JSSC-CGL examination that broke the deadlock between the state government and student protesters who agreed to call off their stir on August 19 after 25 days. The development comes a day after the HC stayed the government's decision to cancel appointments made through the 11th to 13th Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) Combined Civil Services examinations, and the recruitment of Food Safety Officers (FSO).

The matter was heard by Justice Deepak Koshan, who had also heard the petitions challenging the government's cancellation of the 11th to 13th JPSC examinations and FSO recruitment on Thursday.

On Friday, several JSSC-CGL employees approached the High Court, challenging the govern-

ment's decision. The petitioners argued that blanket cancellation of examinations and appointments would adversely affect candidates who had cleared the recruitment process and, in several cases, had already joined government service.

JSSC-CGL petitioner's counsel Arpan M Ekka told The Indian Express that, following Thursday's order in the JPSC 11th-13th and Food Safety Officer matter, the petitioners in the case also approached the HC on Friday and challenged the government's cancellation notification. In the CDPO matter, the petition was filed on Thursday by candidates through advocate Arpan Mishra, and the matter was taken up by the court on Friday. Mishra told The Indian Express that the court has granted a stay on the government's cancellation of the CDPO examination. He said the order was on similar lines to the relief granted in other recruitment matters.

The court stayed the government notifications until further orders and directed that the affected selected candidates be reinstated, while seeking a response from the state government and the JPSC. The next hearings on September 15.

Veteran actress Sowcar Janaki dies at 94

Press Trust of India
Chennai, August 21

VETERAN ACTRESS Sowcar Janaki, one of the most respected names in Indian cinema, died on Friday due to age-related ailments, a hospital source said. She was 94.

Born Sankaramanachi Rana, she was married to Sankaramanachi Srinivasa Rao. She is survived by three children, four grandchildren and four great grandchildren.

Janaki acted in over 400 movies in Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, and Malayalam for over seven decades. She was conferred the Padma Shri in 2022 in recognition of her distinguished and lifelong contribution to Indian art and cinema.



Actress Sowcar Janaki

The veteran actress is famous for her depicting emotional depth and had portrayed strong-willed, modern, and highly witty roles. She smashed the mold of suffering woman stereotype of her era.

She was active from 1950 to 2023, performing across generations of cinema, commanding

screen presence alongside iconic personalities like NTR, Sivaji Ganesan, MGR, Gemini Ganesan, and Rajkumar. As she aged, she reinvented herself as a sought-after grandmother and matriarch.

Her breakthrough was in the 1950 Telugu film 'Shavukaru', which earned her the title 'Sowcar'. Her 'Bhaga Piravine' (1959) was a landmark drama alongside Sivaji Ganesan in which she played a deeply devoted wife who lost her physically challenged husband.

Condoling her demise, Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arerker said, "I am deeply saddened to learn that the veteran actress Sowcar Janaki has passed away today at a

private hospital after medical treatment failed to respond."

Recipient of prestigious honours such as the Padma Shri, Kalaimamani, and Nandi Awards, Janaki made history by acting alongside three generations of actors. "It is no exaggeration to say that she created an epoch by taking on various landmark roles, adopting a unique style of her own, and acting in over four hundred films," he said on X.

CM C Joseph Vijay said Janaki left an indelible mark in the hearts of generations of fans with her unique acting. "Her artistic work, which spanned over 70 years in the film industry and brought countless characters to life, is also commendable..." he said on X.

RSS discusses demographic imbalance and youth protests in Vizag meeting

Press Trust of India
Visakhapatnam, August 21

DEMOGRAPHIC IMBALANCE in some regions and its impact on harmony, the recent youth protests, and related systemic failures were among the issues discussed during the three-day RSS coordination meeting here, a senior Sangh leader said on Friday.

Briefing reporters about the Akhil Bharatiya Samanvay Bidhakti which concluded on Friday, RSS leader C R Mukunda said the Jantar Mantar protests reflect "failures" in the system. It cannot be seen merely as an

issue of corruption and the government must take steps to address these gaps, he said.

Officer-bearers and workers of 32 Sangh-affiliated organisations participated in the coordination meeting.

On demographic changes, Mukunda said certain communities were witnessing a massive increase in their population while others were decreasing, and this imbalance has been debated.

"The all-India coordination meeting held wide-ranging discussions on demographic imbalance, drug abuse, youth concerns, systemic shortcomings

and the need for constructive efforts by government and society," Mukunda said. "Demographic change is happening. As we all know, all over the globe, this is a very challenging thing. There are many countries which are going through an ageing population challenge."

However, he noted that India is currently endowed with the world's largest youth population while its entire population is also the largest in the world. Though India is blessed with these two strengths, Mukunda noted that demographic experts flagged that ageing crisis will hit the country in the next

three to four decades.

Mukunda said the "meeting also discussed" the "growing spread of drugs" into smaller cities, villages and schools, particularly affecting children and youth. He stressed the need for coordinated efforts to address the menace. On youth aspirations vis-a-vis protests, he said change cannot be brought through protests alone.

The meeting discussed the recent protests in the national capital as a symptom of a larger problem, he said, and added that the government must respond to concerns that extend beyond individual issues such as NEET.



On interest rates, can't be both dovish & hawkish

IN ITS last meeting, the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee voted unanimously to keep the benchmark repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent. The tone of the policy was more dovish than many at that time had expected. This led to a view among analysts that rate hikes were not imminent even as inflation was projected to be above target. But the minutes of the same meeting, released a few days ago, suggest that the current situation is unlikely to be maintained over the near term. The divergence is striking.

The members from the central bank on the committee displayed a distinct hawkishness. As a report by economists at the SBI says, "the Governor MPC minutes statement shows inclination towards policy tightening... DG, RBI calls for a possible rate hike later in the year, while ED, RBI just says just short..." Alongside, external members on the committee like Saugata Bhattacharya and Ram Singh have drawn attention to the real interest rate. The RBI's own inflation projections point towards negative real interest rates — it has pegged inflation at 5.9 per cent in the third quarter, 5.5 per cent in the fourth quarter, and 5.3 per cent in the first quarter of the next financial year. This implies that real interest rates are negative on a forward basis. Negative real rates are for stimulating economic activity, unlike the stated neutral stance of the committee. The RBI's hawkish stance, which the RBI Governor has noted in the past, implies no support for economic activity or for controlling inflation. This is also odd considering the central bank's views on "resilient" growth. "Growth continues to be supported by resilient domestic demand, sustained expansion in manufacturing and services activity, and robust exports," it notes.

Across the world, central banks are grappling with uncertainty over inflation and the course of monetary policy. In the US, for instance, even as the Federal Reserve maintained interest rates in July, the path of monetary policy remains unclear. According to the minutes of the Fed meeting, "several participants favoured an increase of 25 basis points in the target range". By the time the MPC meets next in October, there should be more clarity on agriculture and the trajectory of inflation. The central bank's inflation projections will shed light on its expectations of the underlying price pressures in the economy going forward. These could lead to adjustments in the policy rate.

Marathi mandate for cabs, autos is wrong turn

COMING AT a time when public transport is plagued by pressing issues of affordability and accessibility, the implementation of the Marathi language requirement for auto-rickshaw and taxi drivers in Maharashtra is both irrational and unconstitutional. It is part of a larger backsliding into narrow linguistic politics. This has been evident in the state for some time, from the back and forth on the three-language-policy in schools, the Hindi "imposition" bogey whipped up by the Shiv Sena (UBT), to the incidents of hoodlums unleashed by the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena, which has cast itself as a "protector" of Marathi pride. The state transport department has justified the new move on the ground that drivers should be able to understand basic instructions and communicate with passengers in the state's native language. Nine years after the Bombay High Court set aside an attempt to make proficiency in Marathi compulsory for auto-rickshaw permits, the latest move raises the same fundamental question: Why should linguistic assimilation be necessary for employability?

The government has said that drivers found lacking functional knowledge of Marathi will first receive a notice, giving them a month to learn the language. If they fail, their driving licence and Public Service Vehicle (PSV) badge may be suspended for up to three months, with repeated violations resulting in permanent cancellation of licences. These penalties are part of the Maharashtra Motor Vehicle (Third Amendment) Rules, 2026, notified on August 12, with the language proficiency deadline earlier extended from May 1 to August 15. The amended rules extend the language requirement to app-based cab drivers and vehicle permit holders. The language mandate ignores what makes Mumbai work. Dictating linguistic proficiency, making livelihoods dependent on it, tilts the field against migrants whose labour sustains urban economies. Transport systems, particularly in constantly expanding megacities like Mumbai, depend on flexibility, scale, and the willingness of workers to follow opportunities wherever they may be.

More fundamentally, it undermines the constitutional guarantee of freedom of mobility, which gives citizens the right to reside and settle in any part of India and practise any profession or occupation there. The choice before the state is clear: Pursue inclusive growth while securing constitutional freedoms, or indulge insular impulses that shrink possibilities of growth and cramp individual liberties. Maharashtra's language mandate is a turn in the wrong direction. It must be rolled back.

Harry and Meghan show is relatable. Really?

TAKE THEIR words at face value, and it seems like "royalty" is driven by the same concerns as those who have to work for a living. Harry Windsor and Meghan Markle, who left the former's homeland for the US after making much ado about the many flaws within the royal family, have announced that they will return to the UK. Reportedly, the ostensible reason for their return is that the "spare prince, entering middle age, wants his children to have a connection to their roots. There are also concerns over King Charles's health, and a reconciliation is better sooner than later. Children and parents, family and culture, the comfort of being home over an uprooted existence — it's all very relatable.

But this sense of "they are like us only" goes only so far. Harry's naivety is rooted in a unique kind of warped privilege, a gilded cage always under the spotlight. But that spotlight is part of the "job" and the royal reality TV circus stops Britons from asking why, even as public healthcare and housing crumble, they are subsidising a family. Meghan, who had some minor successes in Hollywood, should have known that good content thrives where there is drama, and the royal family is drama.

The couple's detractors will claim that the "return" is like a new season of *Keeping Up With the Kardashians*. That the spotlight will become brighter if there's family drama in the UK. That's a bit mean-spirited. Their fame and recent dip in fortunes do not preclude genuinely emotional reasons for going back. And, like most people, royals can probably lie to themselves about why they do what they do.

IN MARCH 2017, in these pages, I argued that there was no justification for a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on mobile payments, and that a less-cash India depended on keeping them free (Conditions for a less-cash India, IE, March 4, 2017). That argument concerned an infant technology; it now has fresh urgency. Earlier this month, Parliament passed the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, rewriting Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act. That section barred any charge on BHIM-UPI and RuPay. The amendment replaces the bar with an enabling provision, allowing the government to notify in the future which modes can carry a charge. No charge is imposed today. But the door has been unlocked, and we should not walk through it.

Consider what UPI has become. In 2025-26, it carried over 24,000 crore transactions — roughly 66 crore — worth about Rs 314 lakh crore, accounting for some 85 per cent of India's digital retail payments and nearly half the world's real-time payments. It is overwhelmingly a system of small sums: The average transaction is about Rs 1,300, and 86 per cent of merchant payments are below Rs 500. Such transactions involve the vegetable seller, the auto driver, and the kirana shop. A charge here is not a charge on commerce in the abstract; it is a levy on the smallest transactions of the poorest.

After Aadhaar gave every Indian a digital identity, UPI is our most visible piece of digital public infrastructure — unlike the identi-

ty proof, the citizen reaches for it many times a day. It is not any company's product but an open, protocol-based public good — a new common language for money. Before UPI, each bank ran its own closed app; UPI asked banks only to open their APIs to a shared protocol, so that any app can move money between any two accounts at any two banks, instantly and free. It is a model the world is now studying and adopting.

Why, then, is MDR the wrong instrument? It is an inheritance from the card world, where the issuer, acquirer and network each take a slice, and where a physical card, terminal and credit-default risk give the fee something to recover. None of that exists on UPI: The point-of-sale machine is the customer's own phone, on data he has paid for; there is no card, no terminal, no credit risk, and settlement is instant.

Let's apply the "work-done" principle telecom regulation uses for interconnection — a network is paid only for the work it performs. When A pays B, A's bank makes a debit entry, the NPCI a settlement instruction, B's bank a credit entry; no cash moves. The NPCI runs the whole switch for about Rs 500 crore a year — some two paise a transaction. The cost a fee would recover has all but vanished.

None of this means the system runs on air. Banks and payment providers bear real costs, and under zero-MDR, they earn nothing directly from a UPI transac-



R S SHARMA

If digitisation saves the state and the banks such sums, the answer is not to claw money from merchants and consumers through MDR. It is for the state to return a small, defined share of its savings to those who run the rails

tion. The government has bridged the gap with an incentive. But that bridge is being dismantled even as the traffic multiplies — the outlay is projected to fall to about Rs 457 crore from about Rs 3,651 crore two years ago. The gap is real. But MDR is the wrong way to close it, because the savings UPI creates accrue not to the merchant we would tax, but to the state and the banks.

Look at the state first, and conservatively: The Reserve Bank spends some Rs 5,000-6,400 crore a year merely printing currency notes — more than the government spends keeping UPI free — before the cost of storing and moving cash is even counted. Then look at the banks, the largest beneficiaries. A bank must serve its customer somehow, and the channels differ hugely in cost: A counter transaction costs it Rs 40-50, an ATM withdrawal Rs 19 in interchange alone, while a UPI transaction is a small fraction of either. And by making an account as usable as cash, UPI keeps money in accounts rather than idle in pockets — the low-cost float on which banks earn their spread and lend.

If digitisation saves the state and the banks such sums, the answer is not to claw money from merchants and consumers through MDR. It is for the state — the steward of the foreign public good, and no longer obliged to print and move the cash, which UPI displaces — to return a small, defined share of its savings

The limits of my language mean the limits of my world.
— Ludwig Wittgenstein

to those who run the rails. This is not a grudging subsidy but payment for value delivered, as the state pays a transmission company to carry electricity: A transparent, formula-based support funded from the savings in currency management, never a price tag before the citizen.

An MDR would also be self-defeating. India is intensely price-sensitive — if paying digitally costs even a rupee more than cash, many will return to cash. A merchant charged MDR passes it on as a 2 per cent extra for digital, or refuses digital altogether. Even 0.5 per cent on merchant payments would take some Rs 27,000 crore a year out of a thin-margin retail economy. To tell a hundred crore users that what was always free now costs money is the surest way to slow, even reverse, a transition still forming: We would collect a little and lose a great deal. And confining the charge to large merchants offers no lasting protection — thresholds slip, and definitions widen.

India has done what no other country has managed — made real-time digital payment free, instant and universal, pulling hundreds of millions into the formal economy. That rests on a simple bargain — paying digitally will never cost more than cash. Keep UPI free, fund it from the savings it so visibly creates, and it will repay the country many times over. That, not MDR, is the road to a truly cashless India.

The writer is a former secretary, Government of India. Views are personal

On Vande Mataram, Congress hasn't learnt from its past



RAM RAJIYA
BY RAM MADHAV

NINE DECADES ago, in 1937, the Congress leadership committed the blunder of surrendering before the communal forces led by Muhammad Ali Jinnah. Today, it wants to present that as a virtue in defence of its defiance against singing "Vande Mataram" in full.

Before it was truncated in 1937, in the Congress sessions, had a four-decade history. Taken from Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's *Anandamath*, it was first sung at the Congress session in 1896 by Rabindranath Tagore.

The song became the mantra for the movement launched by the Congress against the partition of Bengal — it was to be sung to be called the Vande Mataram Movement. Renowned Hindu-stani musician Vishnu Digambar Paluskar used to sing it at the Congress sessions every year until he died in 1931, a tradition continued by Pandit Omkarnath Thakur, another vocalist.

Muslim League leader Maulana Muhammad Ali, who chaired the Congress session at Kakinada in 1923, objected to its singing for the first time. Paluskar ignored the objection and went ahead with the singing. The tradition continued. It was only to ponder to Jinnah that Nehru initiated the debate over its future in 1937. It led to a furore in Bengali circles. Ramananda Chatterjee, renowned editor of the *Modern Review* published from Kolkata, strongly decried the song's "trial" by Congress.

Yet Nehru, who once said that the outcry against the song was "a manufactured one by the communists", began to insist that the Muslims had genuine grievances against it.

Tagore proposed the truncation of the song on the spurious claim that the second part of it was against his and his family's "monothestic ideals".

That's how the song itself became a victim of vivisection.

For Jinnah, it was just an alibi. He continued to argue even after its truncation that the song was a "hymn of hatred to Muslims". Nehru's argument that it hurt the sentiments of Muslims was facetious because the objection never came from Muslim Congressmen. Even Jinnah, in his earlier avatar as a Congress leader, used to rise in reverence when the song was sung in Congress sessions. Tagore's "monothestic" is not India's creed.

As far as the idolatry complaint is concerned, except for references to Durga, Kamala (Lakshmi) and Vani (Saraswati), the song contains the names of no other Hindu gods.

The argument of idolatry was irrational because the country itself was worshipped as Bharat Mata by all the freedom fighters. Aurobindo called her "Shakti"; Gandhi went to Varanasi to inaugurate a Bharat Mata temple in 1936; and Indira Gandhi, as prime minister, inaugurated another Bharat Mata Mandir in Haridwar in 1983.

Primarily, what the Congress leadership today is trying to defend was an act of communal appeasement, which resulted in horrible consequences for India.

The Congress never stood by nationalist Muslims during the freedom movement and after.

In his book *India Wins Freedom*, Maulana Azad blames Gandhi for giving undue importance to Jinnah, and by implication, reducing the importance of nationalist Muslims like him. "Jinnah had lost much of his political importance after he left the Congress in the 1920s. It was largely due to Gandhi's acts of commission and omission that Jinnah regained his importance in Indian political life," he writes.

Habeebur Rehman wrote to Gandhi in 1944, complaining, "Yesterday, I read your statement. You are again ready to give Pakistan to Jinnah. The fact is that since Jinnah is a Gujarati, you love him and cannot forget him. You want to see him victorious despite his being wrong. This kind of gentle behaviour has strengthened the reactionary forces."

The biggest repudiation came from "Frontier Gandhi" Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan. When Congress surrendered before Jinnah and agreed to Partition, he wept uncontrollably, asking why the sturdy Pathans, who had fought for freedom in a united India, were being subjected to this punishment. "You have thrown us to the wolves. Which Muslims, who joined you, will ever trust you?" he agonisingly asked the Congress leadership.

By resorting to similar dubious actions, Congress is committing the blunder of supporting the communal elements, just as it did during the freedom movement.

The writer is president, India Foundation and national vice-president, BJP



SAPTARSHI BASAK

What we lose when we stop seeing migrants as people

PHOTOGRAPH that has been trapped in my mind for the past few days is of a young woman, around my age, wearing a jersey that could easily be mistaken for Atlético Madrid's, smiling at the camera with a football field stretching out behind her and a goalpost standing in the distance. Faten Ben Omar El Azizi drowned last month while trying to cross into the Spanish enclave of Ceuta. Playing in a women's league in Morocco while working part-time at a cemetery — where she is now buried — offered little prospect of a better future, and so she decided the crossing was worth the risk. El Azizi was among nearly 150 who died at the Morocco-Ceuta border last month. This was no anomaly: In 2025, at least 3,400 people died or went missing while trying to reach Ceuta. What is the natural human response to a tragedy like Ceuta? Grief, surely? Shock, perhaps even anger, at the circumstances that could make thousands decide that risking death was preferable to remaining where they were. But listen to the reaction of much of the Western political establishment and you encounter a vocabulary so impoverished that there appears to be little to say beyond "security" and "legality".

The obvious claim is that crossing a border illegally is, in fact, illegal. But an illegal act does not make a human being illegal. There is, as migration scholar Nicholas De Genova argues, nothing matter-of-fact about the "illegality" of a migrant; it is not an inherent characteristic of the person but a status produced through the state's immigration law and its enforcement. The natural rights of that person — which John Locke would describe as pre-political rights that exist independently of any government — are the same as yours and mine, these so-called "legals". These two common counterarguments is that "illegals" make host countries dangerous to live in. Empirically, however, the evidence does not support a relationship between immigration and violent crime in Europe. And in the US, research finds that immigrants, including undocumented ones, generally commit crimes at lower rates than US-born people.

Why have we come to treat migration as an aberration, and not as a force that has shaped the course of history and society? People have been moving for thousands of years, transforming the linguistic and cultural landscapes of entire continents, long before the modern nation-state started insisting that everyone belongs somewhere and therefore requires permission to enter somewhere else. Migration is an ancient human phenomenon, but the discourse around it today is confined within a remarkably narrow and young framework of borders. The irony is that for much of modern history, it was the Europeans who were moving. Their mobility was framed as exploration, opportunity or empire-building. Even as colonial expansion wiped out indigenous peoples across the world. And as we go to gloss over the fact that European colonialism, disease, wars, and financial and foreign-policy decisions created many of the conditions from which 21st-century migration emerges? Syrians, Iraqis, Palestinians and Libyans, among others, did not simply appear at Europe's borders. Their journeys cannot be separated entirely from the history of Western intervention and extraction.

The language we use to describe migration shapes how we see migrants. Talking about borders cannot mean switching off our ability to see the human on the other side. So I keep returning to El Azizi. Our response to her death cannot begin and end with whether she was legally entitled to cross a line on a map.

The writer is copy editor, The Indian Express. saptarshi.basak@expressindia.com

40 YEARS AGO

AUGUST 22, 1986



Revised pay scales

ABOUT 5 million central government employees will draw their salaries from October 1986 under the revised schedule announced by the Finance Minister. The ministry has laid down an interim timetable to ensure that the government decision on the recommended cut-off for the Central Pay Commission is implemented by the end of October. The commission report, presented to the government on June 30, while welcomed by a large section of the central staff, was assailed for what was termed injustice to certain jobs

and scales. The Pay Commission received a large number of representations from employees' organisations pointing out the problems they would face.

Talks on security belt bill

THE UNION Home Minister, Buta Singh, held consultations with the Gujarat Chief Minister, Amarsinh Chaudhary, and the Jammu and Kashmir Governor, Jagmohan, over the proposed security-belt bill. He is expected to hold talks on the subject with the Chief Minister of Punjab, Surjit Singh Barnala, and the Rajasthan Chief Minister, Hari Dev Joshi.

Laldengaswornin

LALDENG, who had once spurned and disowned the Constitution of India, assumed the office of the Chief Minister of Mizoram swearing allegiance to it. The Mizo National Front chief now heads a nine-member MNF-Congress (I) coalition for six months.

Bihar House gherao plan flops

THE "GHERAO" at the Bihar Legislative Assembly planned at Patna ended in a fiasco. The protest was to be against the police firing at Arwal in which 19 persons were killed.



The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, AUGUST 22, 2026

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY
Today's China could learn from Jiang and Zhu.
—Financial Times

SIR's exclusion of citizens is made possible by complicity of institutions



SUHASH PALSHIKAR

THE ONGOING special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is proving to be a textbook example of how the Indian state keeps destabilising citizens' lives. Earlier this week, this newspaper reported that tribunals in West Bengal are struggling to tackle cases arising out of the SIR ('No full stops in Bengal SIR, Those "excluded" now in dark about what next', IE, 17 August). There are also reports of growing numbers of 'absent,' 'shifted,' 'dead' and 'duplicate' citizens from each state where the exercise is going on. While the ECI may face the brunt of criticism and media attention on this count, it is important to remember that the Supreme Court has produced this impasse.

The Court's ruling in the SIR case in May 2026 is a reminder that the judiciary can, at times, become an enabler of state practices that harm citizens. *Adler & Others vs ECI & Others* offers a troubling roadmap for such an outcome. A refusal to position the judiciary as an effective arbiter between the power of the state and the rights of citizens. As we mourn the consequences for those affected by the SIR, we should not lose sight of the significance of the ruling itself. It may well prove to be a landmark judgment — not because it strengthened citizens' rights, but because it demonstrated how the judiciary can enable the state at the expense of the citizen.

The ruling not only upholds the ECI's power to conduct the SIR; it also records the Court's satisfaction with the procedure adopted by the Commission, stating that the deletions are within the parameters of that procedure. In effect, the judgment places considerable trust in the poll body.

A magnanimous reading of the verdict could be that the Court was confronted with two competing approaches. One



ILLUSTRATION: C SAKSHI KUMAR

would have been to adopt a posture of healthy suspicion on behalf of citizens — a scepticism towards claims of authority by the ECI, coupled with a recognition that judicial vigilance is necessary to maintain a balance between the state's asserted powers and reasonable fears about the protection of citizens' rights. The alternative was to reposit trust in another constitutional authority, such as the ECI, on the assumption that constitutional institutions are themselves sufficiently committed to protecting citizens' rights, making intensive judicial scrutiny less necessary. The Court chose the latter approach.

In doing so, it overlooked a crucial possibility. An authority may undermine citizens' rights not through any explicit intention to do so, but through unreasonable practices. This is where the error in the SIR ruling resonates with a broader contemporary judicial tendency — one that increasingly privileges 'authority' vis-à-vis citizens. The other error lies in the Court's failure to anchor its judgment in the foundational principle

The Court has neither engaged with the conceptual question of exclusion nor adequately considered the empirical possibility that the SIR may disproportionately affect vulnerable citizens

underlying the controversy — representation. The logic of representation does not appear to have sufficiently informed the Court's interpretation of the ECI's authority. As democracy has evolved and the idea of citizenship has expanded, full inclusion has emerged as one of its central requirements. This not only means that citizenship should not be denied or diminished on grounds such as sex, religion, race, caste or class, but also that political representation is not meaningful if citizens are effectively disarmed from participating in elections as voters.

Leaving eligible electors out of elections inevitably produces flawed representation. Having accepted that the ECI has the power to prepare electoral rolls, and, therefore, to examine whether a person is genuinely entitled to be included on them, the Court has failed to ensure that the Commission's power of scrutiny does not result in the exclusion or harassment of eligible voters.

In a democratic election, the ECI's first responsibility must be to include, not to exclude. How is that principle to be protected? While it

is unfortunate that the ECI does not appear to have been seized of the question of inclusion, the Court's failure to sufficiently engage with it is also troubling.

As a general rule, the state's axe of exclusion operates randomly. However, both in the abstract and as an empirical reality, who are most likely to be adversely affected by the insistence on a documentation regime as evidence of citizenship? It has been repeatedly pointed out that certain social sections — vast numbers of women, the poor and the marginalised — are particularly vulnerable to being trapped by such regimes. The SIR, therefore, risks becoming a hatchet rather than a purifying procedure. The Court has neither engaged with the conceptual question of exclusion nor adequately considered the empirical possibility that the SIR may disproportionately affect vulnerable citizens and, in doing so, undermine democratic representation.

This approach leaves citizens vulnerable to consequences beyond the loss of their voting rights. The SIR verdict actually directs the ECI to report to the Home Ministry the names of persons whose names have been deleted, for further adjudication of their claims. Thus, the judgment not only permits exclusion from democratic representation; it also allows the ECI and the government to potentially weaponise the SIR exercise, pushing individuals into a zone of doubt, suspicion and harassment. It is striking that a judgment so cautious about the judiciary entering the ECI's domain has, obliquely, enabled the Commission to transcend its own domain and become enmeshed with executive authority.

As the SIR leaves a growing number of voters in limbo, one cannot but rue the judiciary's role.

When the exercise is complete, it may have created a multitude of SADs — Shifted, Absent, Duplicate — who are then pushed to the margins of formal existence, as their passports or claims to various welfare schemes may also be cast into doubt. From SIR to SAD is a slippery slope that the judiciary has facilitated, perhaps unintentionally.

The author, based in Pune, taught Political Science

Dimagi Naxal frames the mind as enemy territory



PAWAN KHERA

NAXALISM HAS historically referred to an armed insurgency — an organised political movement that used violence against the Indian state. So what exactly does Narendra Modi mean when he uses the phrase "dimagi Naxal"? The traditional Naxal lived in the forests, carried agun, and challenged the state through violence. The Prime Minister now appears to have relocated the idea of Naxalism from the forest to the ordinary spaces of democratic life.

AS RIMP and former UP DGP Brij Lal puts it, "dimagi Naxals" are people who use their brains — professors, teachers, intellectuals, activists, poets and writers.

By that definition, the defining characteristic of a Naxal is no longer the gun, but the uncomfortable question. And by that logic, everyone who isn't an *andbhakar* is a "dimagi Naxal".

The state has a legitimate duty to confront armed violence, protect civilians and enforce the law. But what exactly are these citizens doing to be singled out, on Independence Day, as an internal enemy?

Thoughtcrimes is a term famously associated with George Orwell's novel *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, where the authoritarian state treats independent or politically unacceptable thinking as a crime. In broader political usage, it is a metaphor for a society or government treating dissenting ideas as inherently dangerous or punishable. And if the defining characteristic of a "dimagi Naxal" is that they use their brains to fearlessly carry guns, then perhaps the offence is the thought itself — and the willingness to turn that thought into an uncomfortable question for those in power. The question becomes the crime. The person asking it becomes a threat.

Perhaps the "dimagi Naxal" is simply someone who looks at the vast sums of money and state capacity devoted to constructing the image of a leader, and asks: If the great man is so extraordinary, why does he need Rs 1.5 crore a day to maintain that image? Or: Is image-building still part of the job — or has it become the entire job?

Perhaps the "dimagi Naxal" watches Modi embrace Donald Trump, Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping, and asks whether spectacle should be mistaken for statesmanship. Perhaps they read the growing body of commentary on Modi's India and see not ideology, but an argument about the country India might have been — richer, freer, more equal and less corrupt. Perhaps they pay attention to the growing reports of corruption in sacred temples and watch the PM drag his feet when it comes to answering for such theft. And perhaps the *glorapatti* — the cardinal sin — of the "dimagi Naxal" is simply refusing to applaud on command. The crime is not rebellion, but independent judgment.

For years, Modi's political persona has been built around a series of extraordinary claims: Master strategist, scholar, civilisational thinker, decisive statesman, saviour, a man of exceptional destiny. But political mythology eventually encounters reality. "Unseerous diplomacy", "Image over substance", "Can't take a joke", "Hollow rhetoric". These may begin as political attacks. But when they acquire the force of public perception, they become harder to dismiss. And perhaps this is Modi's vulnerability. He has lived inside an echo chamber of admiration. It is difficult for a political leader accustomed to controlling the narrative to discover that the audience is no longer accepting the script. He thrives on choreographed reels, and now watches the youth of India mock him. He mocked the "shehzada" — and now watches Rahul Gandhi generate attention and enthusiasm organically.

"Dimagi Naxal" is the rhetorical response of a political establishment confronted by citizens whose respect cannot be manufactured through propaganda. A confident leader says: "Here is my record. Judge it." An insecure leader asks: "Why are you judging me at all?"

This is ultimately the tragicomedy of the "dimagi Naxal". A PM who has built his political identity around intelligence, decisiveness and exceptionalism now appears threatened by the most ordinary exercise of intelligence: Thinking independently. The dissenting mind is presented as a contaminant. The question becomes suspicious. The critic becomes pathological. The citizen becomes the problem.

Yet democracy was never designed to produce unanimous applause. A healthy republic needs universities that question, journalists who investigate, courts that scrutinise, civil society that challenges, opposition parties that disagree and citizens who refuse to accept political mythology as fact. The answer to an uncomfortable question cannot be to criminalise the questioner. The real threat to democracy is not the mind that asks questions. It is the political power that begins to fear them.

And perhaps that is what "dimagi Naxal" ultimately reveals. Not the dangerous mind of the citizen, but the growing insecurity of a government that has begun to realise that its days are numbered.

The writer is chairman, media and publicity department, All India Congress Committee

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Washington on J&K

THE CANDID support of US Ambassador Sergio Gorr for India on Jammu and Kashmir is significant (On J&K, US envoy says it like it is', IE, August 21). Given his status as US President Donald Trump's special envoy for South and Central Asian affairs, his words also send a message to China in respect of its support for Pakistan. After the removal of Article 370, the US termed it a matter between India and Pakistan. Seven years later, it now sees J&K as a settled matter. However, India should not lower its guard vis-à-vis Pakistan, as the present US regime is known for its frequent U-turns.

YG Chouksey, Pune

No quieting the youth

THE ARTICLE beautifully explains that the end of the 36-day student protest at Jantar Mantar is only a temporary pause ('This is not the end. They will be back', IE, August 21). Even without a single big leader, this movement successfully brought the government under pressure. The NEET exam leak was just a trigger; the real problems are a lack of jobs, corruption, and a failing exam system. The government must fix these core issues instead of waiting for protests to die down.

Thwayia A.P. Kannur

Brand nostalgia

ALMOST EVERY brand the writer mentions as having faded into posterity is one my generation has known and lived with ('Why some brands fade away, why others don't', IE, August 21). I particularly remember Gold Spot, our childhood favourite orange soft drink. That sweet, syrupy drink was an occasional treat, and I still remember collecting the crowns for the stickers tucked inside. I sorely miss Binaca toothpaste too — the greenish-white, sweet-smelling paste that was associated with *Binaca Geetmala*, the weekly film-song programme hosted by the charismatic Ameen Sayani. Liril, however, is still part of every morning; its familiar fragrance transports me instantly to another time.

Nawal Thant, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar,



ABHINAV PRAKASH

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's Independence Day address did what Indian political discourse has avoided for four decades. The country measured its war against Naxalism in body counts, arms recoveries and the district maps that turned green from red. What it rarely confronted was the architecture of ideas behind the insurgency. By calling out the *dimagi Naxal* (intellectual Naxal), Modi has forced a final battle upon the deadliest threat to have plagued India.

Naxalism was always an ideology before it was a militia. Charu Majumdar, the ideologue of Naxalbari, did not pick up a rifle out of personal deprivation; he theorised, organised and incited others toward armed "revolution". Naxal leadership across generations has drawn from comfortable, often landed or urban intellectual backgrounds. Naxals seek to overthrow the Republic of India along with its "bourgeois constitution" and establish a communist state in which the class enemies will be liquidated by an armed revolution. These underground Naxals, their overground members and sympathisers believe India is an artificial, illegitimate entity that is denying the right of "self-determination" to different "nationalities" and is working at the behest of international capital.

After Operation Green Hunt in 2009, Maoists decided to expand aggressively in urban centres and

If Naxals succeed, there will be no freedom

The Modi government's counter-Naxal doctrine has rested on a triad of security, rehabilitation, and development. Because it worked on the ground, the Naxal intellectual ecosystem shifted its attack to development itself

hide in plain sight by posing as human rights activists, university professors, journalists and even corporate employees. They aim to act as couriers and provide safe houses for cadres of banned outfits, to stall any action against the terror groups, wage an ideological war on the Indian state and undermine it by promoting anarchy. They package their propaganda in acceptable terminology like human rights, Dalit assertion, farmer issues and individual rights. Their aim is ostensibly justice for the marginalised and freedom from hunger and poverty. But they don't always publicly state that their theoretical framework associates freedom from hunger and poverty with justice with the balkanisation of India. This is a messianic cult masquerading as secular ideology that seeks nothing but death and destruction in search of a promised utopia.

The Narendra Modi government's counter-Naxal doctrine has rested on a triad of security, rehabilitation, and development. Because it worked on the ground, the Naxal intellectual ecosystem shifted its attack to development itself

ing. You are recovering from a major surgery while your baby fights his own battle a few corridors away. Every visit to the NICU is a negotiation between hope and fear. It makes NICU motherhood especially difficult that it is rarely understood. In a society that places the burden of a healthy pregnancy almost entirely on women, a premature birth intensifies that scrutiny. Did she travel? Did she not rest enough? The mother's body becomes the site of investigation.

The NICU is unlike any other place. Your days are measured not by feeding schedules or sleepless nights but by oxygen saturation levels, heart-rate monitors and the beeping of machines

Unlike the growing conversation around postpartum depression, the emotional realities of NICU motherhood remain largely invisible. I found strange solidarities during my six weeks. Nurses, guards, staff and most importantly, other mothers. As I sat nursing my baby, mothers would come in, and sit with their babies. I heard them quietly sobbing as nurses urged them — and me — to stay positive and remember that our babies could sense our emotions. So we just looked at each other, mothers dressed in hospital gowns, as we suppressed our tears. We exchanged brief conversations in waiting rooms, celebrated small milestones together, and silently mourned each other's setbacks. It made visible the scale of what we were going through. Premature births are on the rise in India. While the nutritional health of mothers and

the changing pattern of pregnancies contribute to this, a significant rise has been due to environmental factors. In the past five years, Delhi has seen a 21 per cent rise in preterm births. Another study by IIT Delhi in collaboration with international universities analysed data from the National Family Health Survey between 2015 and 2020 to establish that prolonged exposure to heat significantly increased the chances of preterm births and low birth weights. Perhaps we need to prepare for this new reality not only by learning how to care for fragile babies, but also by understanding what it means for the women who sit beside them, learning to become mothers in an unfamiliar world.

The writer is assistant professor, Jindal School of Design and Architecture, OP Jindal Global University



EKTA CHAUHAN

ADAY after I submitted an article pitch on the rise of caesarean sections and premature births in India, I found myself lying in a hospital bed 28 weeks pregnant, tethered to monitors as doctors rushed in and out. I had come in for a routine prenatal check-up. Within hours, I was admitted. Before I could grasp what was happening, my son arrived, two months early through an emergency C-section, splitting my life into a clear before and after.

In India, motherhood continues to be narrated through the language of labour pain, sacrifice and endurance. What nobody had prepared me for was that my initiation

The birth story no one prepared me for

INDIA HAD IMPOSED RESTRICTIONS ON INVESTMENTS FROM CHINA THROUGH PN3 IN APRIL 2020

FDI policy rejig for border nations spur Rs 5k cr investment: DPIIT

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, August 21

A REJIG in India's foreign direct investment (FDI) policy earlier this year has attracted offshore investment proposals worth Rs 4,895.65 crore till August 20, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry said on Friday. In March, the government had allowed foreign entities with non-controlling beneficial ownership from land bordering countries of up to 10% to invest in India.

"A total of 29 FDI investments have been reported under the revised framework up to August 20, 2026, involving proposed FDI of Rs 4,895.65 crore. These investments span a range of sectors, including information technology, artificial intelligence, information & communication, manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, data centres and transport services, among others," the Commerce and Industry Ministry said on Friday.

The ministry said that the 29 investments have been "reported by investors/entities" based in jurisdictions including

Mauritius, the United States, the Republic of Korea, Japan, Singapore, Luxembourg and the Cayman Islands. Earlier, foreign investors with beneficial ownership from land-bordering countries (LBCs) of India were required to obtain prior government approval under Press Note 3 (PN3) of 2020, even where such LBC ownership was very small.

The government also approved a 60-day deadline for clearing investment proposals from LBCs, including China, for capital goods, electronic components, polysilicon and ingot-wafer for solar cells.

Under the revised investment norms, the majority shareholding and control of the investee entity will be with resident Indian citizen(s) and/or resident Indian citizen(s) owned and controlled by resident Indian citizen(s), at all times, an official release of the Cabinet decision had said.

India has imposed restrictions on investments from China through PN3 in April 2020, making government approval mandatory for invest-



The Centre had approved a 60-day deadline for clearing investment proposals from land bordering countries. REUTERS

ments from countries sharing a land border with India.

The move was aimed at preventing opportunistic takeovers during the Covid-19 pandemic and had remained in force amid heightened national security concerns following the Galwan clash last year.

The PN3 was primarily meant for Chinese investors, as entities can invest only under the

government route, while investments from other bordering countries such as Nepal, Myanmar, Bhutan, and Afghanistan are very small as a share of India's total foreign investment inflows.

In one of the first major approvals to Chinese investment in a strategic sector, the Centre in July had cleared a joint venture between Dixon Technologies (India) Limited and Vivo

Mobile India Limited (VMI) for manufacturing electronic devices and smartphones in the country, a BSE (Bombay Stock Exchange) filing showed.

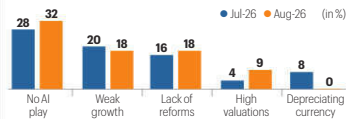
The finance ministry in July had also allowed four Chinese power equipment manufacturing companies with factories in India to participate in government tenders for critical power projects. The four firms — TBEA Energy, Nanjing Electric India, New Northeast Electric India and Taikali Electric (India) — have been exempted from the provisions of the public procurement rules, which require

entities from countries sharing a land border with India to register with the relevant Indian authority to be eligible to bid in the procurement of goods, services or works.

All four firms manufacture key power sector equipment such as transformers, wires, high-voltage switchgear and gas-insulated switchgear, which are used in transmission lines. On its website, New Northeast Electric India shows at least 11 transmission line projects across India.

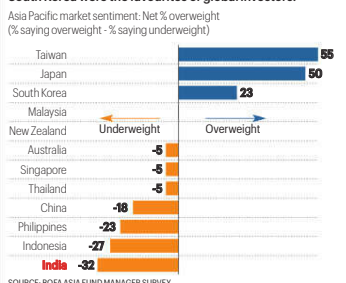
• Money is where the AI is

Global fund managers remain cautious on Indian equities due to lack of direct AI exposure and macro growth concerns, according to the BofA August 2026 Fund Manager Survey. Fund managers' key concerns for Indian market:



SOURCE: BOFA ASIA FUND MANAGER SURVEY. NOTE: VOTES FOR 'DON'T KNOW' ARE NOT SHOWN ABOVE

Meanwhile, due to their exposure to the AI and semiconductor technology sectors, Taiwan and Japan and South Korea were the favourites of global investors.



SOURCE: BOFA ASIA FUND MANAGER SURVEY

Indigenous N-reactors top pick for companies in nuclear power expansion

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 21

INDIGENOUS PRESSURISED heavy water reactors (PHWRs) are emerging as the preferred pick for new entrants into India's civil nuclear power sector due to the established supply chain and good ecosystem, as the country opens the tightly regulated strategic sector to private players.

The country has an ambitious target of scaling up the domestic civil nuclear capacity to 100 gigawatt-electric (GWe) by 2047.

At a panel discussion at the BloombergNEF Summit in New Delhi, representatives from NTPC, Adani Atomic Energy and Jindal Steel said that existing 700 megawatt-electric (MWe) PHWR technology could be a good start to scale up the capacity in initial phase given the availability of established design standards, a mature domestic supply chain and an existing ecosystem of vendors and expertise.

NTPC's capacity target is 30 GWe while Adani group's target is 10 GWe and that of Jindal Steel is 18 GWe in coming years.

According to them, foreign reactor technologies and small modular reactors (SMRs) could play a role at a later stage as the sector matures.

The discussion took place nearly a week after India released draft rules of SHANTI Act, laying out the regulatory

• NUCLEAR PUSH

INDIA HAS an ambitious target of scaling up the domestic civil nuclear capacity to 100 gigawatt-electric by 2047

THE COUNTRY has just released draft rules of SHANTI Act, laying out the regulatory framework for a broader nuclear power ecosystem, including private participation, captive generation, licensing, safety oversight and nuclear liability

framework for a broader nuclear power ecosystem, including private participation, captive generation, licensing, safety oversight and nuclear liability.

'Established ecosystem of PHWRs'

Vivek Sharma, Business Head of Adani Atomic Energy, said the major challenges facing the sector are the availability of a robust supply chain and the lack of standardised reactor designs.

"We have an advantage in India that we have 700 MWe design, which is standard, approved, operational, and has regulatory blessings. And most importantly relative supply chain in India. It's almost indigenized, 90-95%," Sharma said.

He said India could leverage this established ecosystem by deploying 700 MWe PHWRs in fleet mode, followed by Press-

urised Water Reactors (PWRs). However, he said that PHWRs alone would not be sufficient to achieve the country's target of 100 GWe of nuclear capacity by 2047.

"So we need to have other technologies, including PWR, as well as at some point of time SMR. But in both cases, the key will be that they need to come to India and start looking at local items as much as possible. Because the cost will matter a lot in India and for making any commercial sense, the consumer has to buy, it has to commit a price which is acceptable," he added.

According to Sharma, global reactor technologies, including PWRs and SMRs, would need to maximise localisation in India to remain commercially viable, given the importance of cost in determining the competitiveness and affordability of nuclear power.

Naveen Ahlawat, President and Head of Sustainability and Decarbonisation at Jindal Steel Limited, also said the company plans to go with 700 MWe PHWRs in the initial phase, given the technology's established supply chain and ecosystem.

Other technologies could be considered in subsequent phases as greater clarity emerges around supply chains, regulatory approvals and standardisation, he said.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Apple set to expand beyond iPhones in India: Vaishnav

Ojasvi Gupta
New Delhi, August 21

APPLE AND Google are set to deepen their manufacturing presence in India, with Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnav on Friday signalling that Apple could make products beyond iPhones in the country and that the country could capture a significant share of Google's export-oriented production currently based in China.

The comments come as the government seeks to move domestic electronics manufacturing ecosystem beyond smartphone assembly and position the country as an alternative production base for global technology companies. Asked whether Apple could manufacture products such as iPads and Macs in India, Vaishnav said "yes", indicating that the government expects the company to widen its manufacturing footprint beyond iPhones.

He did not specify which products Apple could manufacture in India. "We have multiple advantages. One advantage is of course the policy

certainty. Second advantage is the design capabilities," Vaishnav said. He also pointed to the design talent available across the country's global capability centres, technology centres and engineering centres.

Apple has steadily expanded iPhone production in India, with Foxconn and Tata Electronics now forming the core of its local manufacturing network. India is expected to account for about 26% of global iPhone production in 2026, according to Counterpoint Research estimates. India has increasingly emerged as an export base for Apple as the company diversifies production away from China.

A move into a wider range of products would mark a further step in that strategy and deepen the electronics ecosystem around Apple in India. It would also increase the opportunity for Indian suppliers to participate in the company's global supply chain, where domestic value addition remains an important area of policy focus.

Vaishnav said the value-addition level in India has already moved beyond 25-28% FE

Rs 62.5k cr mobile manufacture plan notified, turnover eligibility Rs 10k cr

New Delhi: Mobile phone companies, including electronics contract manufacturers, having a turnover of Rs 10,000 crore in FY26 will be eligible for benefits under the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme, the government said on Friday.

According to the guidelines of the Rs 62,500-crore Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS) issued on Friday, mobile phone companies, including electronics manufacturing services firms with 5% Indian ownership, having a turnover of Rs 1,000 crore in FY26 will also be eligible for participation in the scheme.

The scheme has been divided in two parts — incentivising mobile phone manufacturing and supporting Indian mobile phone brands. PTI

'GSTAT appeals fall well short of expectations'

New Delhi: Flagging concerns over less-than-anticipated cases filed with the appellate tribunal, GST Appellate Tribunal (GSTAT) President Justice (Retd.) Sanjay Kumar Mishra on Friday said only about one-third of the expected 2.5 lakh cases have been filed under this mechanism.

Speaking at the National Tax Summit organised by the Bengal Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Mishra said only 74,758 cases have been filed before the GSTAT since September last year, which shows a "lukewarm" response instead of

an expected "flood of cases". "When I saw the number of cases that have been filed (before the GSTAT) and the number of notices generated, I was a bit disheartened...I was expecting something around 2-2.5 lakh cases. I don't know why (the number of cases filed is less). It may be that businesses have closed down, maybe they were scared of the tax credit claims," Mishra said.

Around 35 lakh cases were filed before the first appellate authority that indicated the number of second appeals that could be filed before the

GSTAT, but since the cases were filed in physical mode, there is no conclusive data available on the number of cases disposed of by the first appellate authority. The GSTAT is the second appellate authority and provides a unified platform for resolving conflicts between taxpayers and tax authorities, while the first appellate authority is a Commissioner (Appeals) level officer whom a taxpayer can approach to appeal against an order or decision issued by a junior officer. ENS

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Centre, states to bring uniform norms for GST registration

New Delhi: The Centre and state tax officers are working on guidelines to bring uniformity in documents that are to be submitted for faster processing of GST registration application of businesses who pass on tax credit of over Rs 25 lakh a month, senior officials said on Friday.

Once agreed to by all states and the Centre, the proposal will be placed before the GST Council, chaired by Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and comprising ministers from all states and UTs.

Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs member GST Sanjay Mangal also said tax officers are also discussing automation in the process of cancellation of GST registration and streamlining the grounds on which a GST officer can cancel registration of a business.

Mangal said currently there is a "non-uniformity" in the procedure followed by the central GST formation and various state formations in granting registration under GST to large businesses. PTI

Around 42 gigawatts (GW) of renewable energy capacity is currently without PPAs.

"And if necessary, some changes in the profile could also be experimented within the rates discovered," he said.

Developers, he added, are increasingly adding battery energy storage systems (BESS) to vanilla solar projects to make them more attractive to DISCOMs.

Responding to a question on the large quantum of renewable capacity awaiting power purchase agreement (PPA), Sarangi said Renewable Energy Implementing Agencies (REIAs) have been asked to explore ways to facilitate procurement of this capacity by distribution utilities (DISCOMs).

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• BRIEFLY

Private sector growth rises to 54.6 in Aug: PMI

Bengaluru: HSBC's flash India Composite Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI), compiled by S&P Global, rose to 54.6 in August from July's 52-month low of 54.3, higher than a Reuters poll median estimate of 54.3. While the reading stayed above the 50 mark separating growth from contraction, it remained below the recent average of around 60. The latest reading showed a faster expansion in overall private sector activity. REUTERS

Forex reserves swell \$9.9 billion to \$716.9 billion

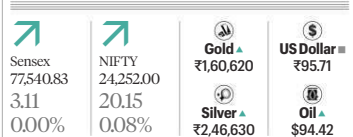
New Delhi: India's forex reserves jumped \$9,905 billion to \$716.907 billion during the week ended August 14, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Friday. In the

previous reporting week ended August 7, the overall kitty had jumped \$14.136 billion to \$707.002 billion. Reserves had reached an all-time high of \$728.494 billion in the week ended February 27 this year, before the onset of the Iran war, which led to several weeks of decline. PTI

'India eyes \$1.2 bn push for building equipment'

New Delhi: India is set to approve a \$1.2-billion incentive scheme for the making of high-value, technologically sophisticated construction and infrastructure equipment, two government sources said, in a bid to reduce dependence on China. The scheme, which is expected to be finalised soon, aims to draw \$1.8 billion in fresh investment by offering incentives over seven years to domestic manufacturers of equipment, one of the two sources said. REUTERS

• MARKETS



NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA. CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF AUGUST 20, 2026

• FALL IN INTERNATIONAL PASSENGER TRAFFIC DRIVEN BY INDIAN AIRLINES, WHILE OVERSEAS CARRIERS SAW A RISE IN FLYER NUMBERS ON FLIGHTS TO AND FROM INDIA

Pakistan factor: Why West Asia war hurt Indian airlines more than foreign ones

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 21

THE WEST Asian conflict, which resulted in major airspace disruptions in the Gulf region, led to a 9% year-on-year (y-o-y) decline in international air passenger traffic to and from India in the first quarter of the current financial year. While the fall in overall volumes was expected, notably, it was entirely driven by Indian airlines as they collectively lost a significant share of international passenger traffic. Overseas carriers, on the other hand, cumulatively made large market share gains, with their combined passenger numbers even higher than the year-ago period.

The odds were stacked against Indian airlines owing to a combination of factors. These included the heavy curtailment of flights to the United Arab Emirates and other West Asian markets — the biggest destinations for Indian airlines — and Indian carriers being forced to cut flights to destinations even beyond West Asia owing to the war-related financial headwinds and the ban on them from flying over Pakistan since late April of 2025. While the West Asia conflict-related challenges, like surging jet fuel prices, were also faced by overseas carriers, many of them had one key competitive advantage — availability of the Pakistani airspace.

Data on international air passengers

As per an analysis of the latest international passenger traffic data released by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), total international air passenger volume (to and from India) fell by 9.1% y-o-y in April-June to 1.72 crore. Indian carriers' combined international passenger numbers declined by 26.6% to 64.2 lakh, while foreign airlines expanded their cumulative passenger base by 6% to 1.08 crore from 1.02 crore a year ago. Consequently, foreign carriers expanded their market share to 62.7% from 53.8%, while domestic carriers

• HITTING TURBULENCE

	Passengers*			Market Share(%)	
	APR-JUN 2026	APR-JUN 2025	CHANGE (%)	APR-JUN 2026	APR-JUN 2025
INDIAN AIRLINES	6414896	8734038	-26.6	37.3	46.2
FOREIGN AIRLINES	10785244	10178560	6.0	62.7	53.8
TOTAL	17200140	18912598	-9.1		

SOURCE: DGCA, *based on air passengers carried by commercial airlines to and from India

dropped to 37.3% from 46.2%.

With the West Asia war leading to airspace closures in the region, Air India and IndiGo were forced to curtail their west-bound network as the unavailability of Pakistani

airspace made it financially and operationally unviable to maintain some flight services. Even before the West Asia war began late February, the two leading Indian carriers were reeling under pressure as the

Pakistani airspace closure forced them to take longer routes, and even introduce re-fuelling halts, on some of their West-bound routes from their major hub Delhi. Some routes also had to be suspended.

This provided an opportunity to overseas airlines, which became sweeter with the West Asia conflict. Once the war started, some carriers, including European and other regions to the West of India increased flight operations to and from the country by deploying aircraft capacity that became spare owing to the curtailment in flights to West Asia.

Indian airlines' loss is foreign carriers' gain

IndiGo remained the largest Indian carrier for international routes but saw a 15.4% decline to 33.4 lakh international flyers in April-June. Its international market share slipped to 19.4% from 20.9%. Air India saw a 27.2% drop, falling to 19.3 lakh passengers, with the airline's international market share contracting to 11.2% from 14% a year ago. Air India Express, whose network is highly concentrated in West Asia, saw its international passenger footprint halve to 8.34 lakh. Its market share in the June quarter was 4.8%, sharply

down from 8.9% a year ago. In all, the Air India group's international passenger traffic in the first quarter declined by 36.3% y-o-y to 27.6 lakh. SpiceJet, which has been struggling financially as well, saw the sharpest percentage decline at 56%, falling to 1.38 lakh flyers on its international flights, the analysis shows. The embattled carrier's international market share contracted to 0.8% from 1.7%.

The only Indian airline that registered higher international passenger numbers was Akasa Air, which has been growing its international network on a low base through its expanding fleet. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

8 killed as charter plane crashes near remote Alaska radar site

Associated Press
Bangkok, August 21

A CHARTER aircraft carrying eight people crashed at a remote radar site in western Alaska on Thursday, killing all on board, the US military said.

The crash happened at Cape Newenham Long Range Radar Site Airport, approximately 725 kms west of Anchorage, Alaska.

"This is a devastating loss for our military family and the communities we serve," US Air Force Lt. Gen. Robert Davis, commander of Alaskan Command, the Alaskan North American Aerospace Defence Command Region and Eleventh Air Force, said in a statement.

The radar site is managed by the Pacific Air Forces Regional Support Center. It's part of a network of remote radar sites that tracks aircraft operating in Alaska's airspace and along its borders, the statement from Alaskan Command said.

The statement did not provide details on the specific work the individuals were doing. It referred to the plane involved as a "civilian-contracted aircraft."

Clint Johnson, the National Transportation Safety Board's Alaska region chief, said earlier Thursday evening that two pilots and six passengers were on board. The plane had taken off from Anchorage and was headed to the crash site early Thursday afternoon.

TEHRAN MUST PLAN TO OVERCOME 'UNJUST' U.S. SANCTIONS, SAYS GHALIBAF

Iran vows 'devastating' response as US threatens to choke economy

Bessent says details of economic curbs to come on Monday

Reuters
Dubai, Washington, August 21

IRAN SAID on Friday that its response to any new US threats would be "devastating" after Washington pledged to impose the toughest financial penalties in history with the aim of toppling the Iranian leadership.

US Treasury chief Scott Bessent said he would give details on Monday of the planned sanctions, which follow a warning from President Donald Trump of economic consequences against any country providing "any type of lifeline to Iran."

The chief of staff of Iran's Armed Forces, Major General Ali Abdollahi, said the Islamic Republic's reaction would be broad and decisive.

"With preparedness across land, sea, air, defence and cyber-space, Iran's armed forces will respond to the enemy's new threats with crushing, punishing and devastating responses," Abdollahi was quoted as saying by Iranian media.

Iran's parliament speaker, Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf



Iran parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf (centre left) visits the grave of Abu Mahdi al-Muhandis, killed in a 2020 US drone strike, in Najaf, Iraq, on Friday. REUTERS

said Washington appeared to have concluded it could not prevail in its direct military confrontation. "We must make plans to deal with the unjust sanctions so that we can overcome them," he said in neighbouring Iraq, accusing the US and Israel of resorting to what he said was economic and "cognitive" warfare.

But, speaking to Iranian and Iraqi businesspeople late on Thursday, Ghalibaf acknowledged the strain on Iran's economy. "No matter how much military power we have, we won't survive if people are hungry and we don't have financial turnover, economic growth and

national production," Ghalibaf said, according to official news agency IRNA.

Oil prices edged lower on Friday but were on track for a second weekly gain after rising on Thursday following the new US sanctions threat. "I'm not sure why oil has popped up on this," Bessent told CNBC. "If we are doing the maximum economic pressure, that means that likely there will not be a large-scale kinetic restart," he said, using a term referring to military force.

Just seven commodity ships sailed along the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday, half the previous day's tally, data from ship tracker

NATO allies discuss role in securing navigation in Strait

Brussels: NATO's top commander convened a videoconference earlier this week to facilitate possible contributions to support freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, his spokesperson told Reuters, adding that this is not a NATO mission.

"Supreme Headquarters Allied Powers Europe hosted a meeting of interested allies at the chief of defence level on Wednesday, 19 August 26, in order to facilitate their possible contributions to support freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz," a spokesperson for the alliance's top commander US Air

Force General Alexus Grynkewich said on Friday.

"To be clear, this is not a NATO mission. But given NATO's unique strengths in its ability to bring together allies and understand the capabilities they bring to bear, it makes sense for NATO to facilitate in this way," the spokesperson added.

NATO allies have sought to avoid direct involvement in the Iran conflict, instead focusing on plans outside the alliance to reopen the strait, which before February carried about a fifth of all traded oil.

REUTERS

Kpler showed, compared with more than 130 a day before the war. Bessent told CNBC he would "talk about exactly what we're going to do" on Iran at a press conference on Monday.

"We are going to collapse this regime. It is time for our allies and the rest of the world to make a decision," he said, describing a naval blockade reimposed on Iran in July and the "toughest sanctions in history" as a "one-two punch".

Iran's Foreign Minister

Abbas Araghchi was defiant in a post on X that referenced previous US efforts to apply economic pressure on Iran and Trump's comments.

"14 years ago: 'Most crippling sanctions in history'. Failed. 8 years ago: 'Maximum pressure'. Failed. 5 months ago: 'Unconditional surrender'. Failed. Today: 'Most crushing economic operation ever'. Bound to fail. We have seen this movie before. Same bull. Different bulls," he posted.

Imran taken back to Rawalpindi jail after check-up, Pak govt says medically fit

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, August 21

FORMER PRIME minister Imran Khan was shifted back to Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi on Friday morning after undergoing a medical examination at the state-run Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences, where doctors from Al-Shifa hospital were also present, the government said.

Earlier in the day, Khan's international media spokesperson Zulfi Bukhari had said that the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) founder was shifted to privately-owned Shifa International Hospital following a SC order.

The Supreme Court on August 18 directed that Khan, 73, be taken to the hospital within two days following a medical report submitted before it which said he was suffering from "level three plus" anxiety.

Information minister Attaullah Tarar blamed PTI workers for the failure to take Khan to the Shifa hospital.

In a social media post, the minister said that "in view of the security situation created by PTI workers on the way to and outside Al-Shifa hospital", Khan was taken to PIMS and according to the medical examination, he was found to be "healthy".

"The medical examination was conducted at PIMS Hospital, where doctors from Al-Shifa Hospital were present," he said.

Tarar said the government will continue to provide medical



Former PM Imran Khan during a press conference in Lahore on June 3, 2023. FILE

assistance to Khan. Khan has been provided with medical facilities before as well, and even now, it will be provided whenever he needs them, he said.

In an earlier post, Tarar had said, "In the light of the Supreme Court's order, the prisoner was taken to the hospital under appropriate security arrangements during the night between August 20 and 21." He, however, did not name Khan nor Shifa International Hospital in the post.

"A team of qualified doctors, including an ophthalmologist, a cardiologist, and a physician, conducted a detailed examination of him and declared him medically fit. His sister, Uzma Khan, was present during the examination," Tarar had said.

After the completion of the entire medical process, he was shifted back to Adiala Jail "at approximately 5 am," the minister said, without naming the deposed prime minister.

Trump seeks new meeting with Kim; N Korea says not so fast

Reuters
Seoul, Washington, August 21

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump says he wants to meet North Korean leader Kim Jong Un later this year. But his overtures have drawn a frosty response from Pyongyang, suggesting it will set tough conditions to hold such a meeting even if the two men have a "good relationship."

Earlier this week, Trump abruptly scaled back joint US military exercises with South Korea, saying they were "hostile" to North Korea. On Wednesday, he said he expects to meet Kim later this year.

Trump is eager to restart talks with North Korea and secure a win on the international stage, according to a person briefed on discussions between US and South Korean officials.

There is no immediate prospect of an end to the nearly six-month war on Iran, and Trump's reaching out to North Korea comes despite Pyongyang sending troops to support Russia in its war on Ukraine.

South Korea has been privately receptive to Trump's strategy, although officials in Seoul still have doubts about reducing joint military exercises with the

E. EXPLAINED

Why North Korea is resisting Trump

Trump wants to revive talks with Kim, but North Korea is signalling that a summit will come with tough conditions. Pyongyang wants Washington to drop policies it considers hostile and appears unwilling to compromise on its nuclear weapons programme or security interests.

United States, the source said.

Trump may travel to the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen later this year, creating an opportunity for a meeting in the region if North Korea proves receptive to renewed engagement, according to the source.

"The United States remains open to dialogue with North Korea without preconditions," said a US State Department spokesperson. "The president and Kim Jong Un will meet again at the appropriate time."

The White House declined to comment. South Korea's presidential office did not respond to

a request for comment, but its foreign ministry referred to an earlier statement expressing hope that Trump's comments lead to meaningful dialogue with Pyongyang.

North Korea's response so far, however, while praising Kim and Trump's "excellent personal relationship," makes clear it views their personal rapport as separate from any engagement with US, said Lim Eun-chul, a professor at Kyungnam University's Institute for Far Eastern Studies.

"Personal ties will never be allowed to compromise national security interests to strengthen military capabilities," Lim said.

Turkey to seek Interpol notice for Netanyahu in Gaza flotilla case

Reuters
Istanbul, August 21

TURKEY SAID on Friday it would seek an Interpol red notice for the arrest of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu as part of a domestic criminal case linked to an attack on activists seeking to deliver humanitarian aid to Gaza.

NATO member Turkey has been one of the fiercest critics of Israel's assault on Gaza and has previously issued domestic arrest warrants for Netanyahu over the war there.

It has repeatedly called for international measures against Israel over what Ankara calls its violations of human rights and international law. Israel denies those charges.

In a post on X, Turkish Justice Minister Akin Gurlek said arrest warrants had been issued for Netanyahu and another suspect on charges that included genocide, crimes against humanity and torture as part of a case against 35 people over the Israeli interception in international waters.

"In line with the arrest warrants issued against Benjamin Netanyahu... our justice ministry has requested the interior ministry (Interpol) red notices for them so that they may be sought internationally," Gurlek said.



Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu

2 organisers of Hong Kong's Tiananmen vigils convicted in national security case

Associated Press
Hong Kong, August 21

TWO FORMER organizers of Hong Kong's annual vigils in remembrance of the 1989 Tiananmen Square crackdown were convicted Friday for what the government-approved judges ruled was inciting others to overthrow China's communist leadership.

Lee Cheuk-yan and Chow Hang-tung, former leaders of the Hong Kong Alliance in Support of Patriotic Democratic Movements of China, were charged in 2021 with inciting subversion under a China-imposed national security law that has effectively crushed the city's previously thriving pro-democracy movement. They face a maximum prison term of 10 years. The alliance was also found guilty.

The three judges ruled that the alliance's call to "end one-party dictatorship" aimed to end the ruling Communist Party's leadership status under the constitution, and that the "end" in the phrase carried the meaning of "overthrowing" and "undermining."

In the verdict, they wrote that the defendants persisted in the call after the law's introduction, neglecting that it was in breach of the constitution, which states the party's leadership is a defining feature of socialism with Chinese characteristics. That falls within "other unlawful means" under the security law, the judges said.

The defendants "intentionally encouraged" supporters of the alliance to wait for the right time to carry out the goal to "end one-party dictatorship" by unlawful means, they said.

14 killed, 120 injured in Russian strike on Ukraine shopping centre

Associated Press
Kyiv, August 21

RUSSIAN DRONES struck a shopping centre in the city of Kryvyi Rih in central Ukraine on Friday, killing 14 people and wounding scores of others, authorities said.

The city is the hometown of President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, who described the attack as a double-tap strike, in which an initial wave of drones hit the area, followed by a second wave as rescue workers responded.

"Attacks like these are nothing less than terrorist acts," Zelenskyy wrote on social media. In a video address several hours later, he also said that Ukraine would respond to the shopping mall attack.

Local administration head Oleksandr Vilkul put the death toll at 14, adding that 121 people were injured, including 22



Firefighters at the site of the Russian drone strike in Kharkiv region, Ukraine, on Friday. REUTERS

children. He said the rescue operation was ongoing.

Kryvyi Rih has been hit multiple times during the more than 4-year-old war, with one of the deadliest occurring in April 2025, when 20 people, including nine children, were killed.

Friday's attack came just 24 hours after Russia pounded the Ukrainian capital of Kyiv with

scores of missiles and drones in a nighttime aerial attack that killed at least 16 people.

Moscow's forces have in recent months intensified their ballistic missile attacks on Kyiv, exploiting Ukraine's chronic shortage of US-made Patriot air defense interceptors, the sole weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down the missiles.

• CLÉMENT VANDENKERCKHOVE, BORN TO BELGIUM'S PRINCE LAURENT BEFORE HIS MARRIAGE, IS NOW A PRINCE FOLLOWING HIS FATHER'S FORMAL RECOGNITION, THOUGH HE IS NOT EXPECTED TO UNDERTAKE ROYAL DUTIES

A prince at 26: Once-secret son of Belgium's royal family gains a title and recognition

John Yoon & Alexandra E Petri
August 21

PRINCE LAURENT of Belgium has formally recognized an adult son who was born before he was married and whom he had not acknowledged publicly until last year.

The prince established legal ties to his son, Clément Vandenberghe, 26, before a civil registrar in February. Soir Mag, a weekly magazine in Belgium, reported on Wednesday.

The legal recognition formally brings the long-private relationship into the Belgian royal family.

present and signed the documents, the magazine reported.

The move made Vandenberghe a prince, though he is not expected to have any royal duties.

Belgium's Royal Palace confirmed to *The New York Times* that Prince Laurent had legally acknowledged his paternity of Vandenberghe but did not comment further, saying it was a private matter.

Vandenberghe is the child of Prince Laurent and Iris Vandenberghe, better known as Wendy Van Wanten, a Belgian model, singer and actress. Prince Laurent, the younger brother of Belgium's monarch, King Philippe, has

three other children with his wife, Princess Claire of Belgium, whom he married in 2003.

Under the terms of a 2015 royal decree, Vandenberghe is granted the title of prince but he will not be in line for the throne or have royal duties, according to Christian Behrendt, a professor of constitutional law at University of Liège in Belgium.

People can enter the line of succession only if they are born in a marriage that is approved by a government decree, Professor Behrendt said.

Prince Laurent said in a statement last September that Vandenberghe was his biological son.



Prince Laurent (left) and his son Clément Vandenberghe. NYT

The announcement was "based on a sense of understanding and respect for those



involved," he said at the time. Vandenberghe could not be reached for comment.

In June, Vandenberghe posted a picture of himself with Prince Laurent and another with Frans Vancoppenolle, his mother's longtime partner, in an Instagram post celebrating Father's Day.

"Today I'm celebrating two fathers who, each in their own way, play an important role in my life," he wrote. "Thank you for everything."

The acknowledgment of a child whose paternity he had long kept a secret generated new scrutiny of Prince Laurent, who has been nicknamed the "prince maudit"—cursed prince—over a series of media spectacles and diplomatic stunts.

In 2023, he sued the Belgian

state in an effort to gain social security benefits, arguing that being a royal was akin to being self-employed. (At the time, he was receiving a stipend of 400,000 euros a year, though his lawyer said that three-quarters of that went to staff and other expenses.)

A court partly agreed with him, recommending two years later that Belgian lawmakers consider granting him a state pension even as it dismissed his argument that his royal duties counted as work.

Before that, he risked losing his stipend after ignoring government advice and making a trip to the Democratic Republic of Congo in 2011 without diplo-

matic oversight.

In 2018, Belgium's Parliament voted to reduce his annual endowment as punishment for attending an event at the Chinese Embassy in uniform without government authorization.

Prince Laurent's father, King Albert II, the former Belgian monarch, was also at the center of a paternity case.

In 2020, after a long legal battle, the court conceded that DNA tests showed he was the biological father of Delphine Boël, an artist who said she was his daughter from an extramarital affair. She went on to become Princess Delphine of Belgium. NYT



The Big Picture

SATURDAY, AUGUST 22, 2026

13

MEERUT

STARTED IN
2026
LENGTH
23 KM
AVERAGE DAILY
RIDERSHIP
1 LAKH*
Includes RRTS
ridership

The silver bullet

Why everyone loves a Metro

India's Metro network has grown four times over the last decade — from around 250 km to more than 1,100 km across 26 megacities and Tier 2 cities. RISHIKA SINGH & DEVANSH MITTAL on why, despite poor ridership and high ticket fares, every city aspires for a spot on the Metro map



DELHI

STARTED IN 2002 | LENGTH 416 KM | AVERAGE DAILY RIDERSHIP 64 LAKH



MUMBAI

STARTED IN 2014 | LENGTH 101 KM | AVERAGE DAILY RIDERSHIP 8 LAKH

• METRO IN OTHER CITIES

AGRA	2024	6 KM
AHMEDABAD	2019	68 KM
BHOPAL	2025	6 KM
CHENNAI	2015	54 KM
HYDERABAD	2017	69 KM
INDORE	2025	6 KM
KANPUR	2021	16 KM
KOCHI	2017	28 KM
LUCKNOW	2017	23 KM
NAGPUR	2019	38 KM
NAVI MUMBAI	2023	11 KM
NOIDA	2019	29 KM
PATNA	2025	6 KM
PUNE	2022	31 KM
GURGAON	2013	12 KM
KOLKATA	1984	73 KM

*Approximate figures

that serving the same demand with buses would require 715 buses an hour in one direction — roughly one every five seconds.

The government statement pointed out that despite a relatively young network — more than three-fourths of India's current network was conceived, constructed and operationalised less than 10 years ago — daily ridership across the country has already crossed the 1-crore mark, and is expected to exceed 1.25 crore in a year or two. "Metro Man" Elattuvalapil Sreedharan, the first Managing Director of DMRC, says India should adopt the model that developed countries have: start planning for a Metro when a city's population crosses 10 lakh, and have a Metro system in place by the time the population reaches 20 lakh. "Metros in Patna, Jaipur, Bhopal and Lucknow are fully justified," says Sreedharan, who is credited with planning and advising many Metro systems in the country.

Few things spell change and development better than the sight of a Metro gliding past rough and chaotic roads. Inside the coaches, the elements have little chance to disrupt, and the problems that regularly afflict public systems in India — irregularity, delays, unreliability — feel distant. Talking about how Metro projects have become prestige projects for politicians and cities, Harsh Dingra, a rail and Metro consultant and former Chief Country Representative, Bombardier Transportation India, says, "Local administrations and politicians desperately want a Metro network in their constituency to show development."

The Indian Express found that in five of the last six state elections (West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Assam, Bihar and Delhi), at least one major political party promised Metro projects, their expansion, or fare concessions in its manifesto. For instance, the DMK noted that it "was the Kazhagam government that brought the Metro Rail service to Chennai". In Bihar, the BJP promised Metro trains in Muzaffarpur, Gaya, Bhagalpur and Darbhanga.

The empty coaches

Yet, critics of the Metro point to the poor ridership and the high capital cost to say Indian cities need to think beyond the Metro. A Metro corridor typically costs Rs 200-300 crore per km if elevated and Rs 500-1,000 crore if underground.

According to a 2023 analysis by IIT Delhi professors Goutam Tiwari and Deepthy Jain, most Metro systems have been meeting just 25-35% of their projected ridership. Delhi (47%) and Kolkata (38%) fared relatively better.

Take Bengaluru's 96-km-long Namma Metro that began operations in 2011. It was projected to have a daily ridership of 18.54



BENGALURU

2011 | 96 KM | 9 LAKH



JAIPUR

2015 | 12 KM | 50,000

lakh by 2020-21, the Standing Committee on Housing and Urban Affairs noted in a 2022 report, but even now, in 2026, the Metro only has a ridership of just around 10 lakh.

Research by Tiwari, an Emeritus Professor at the Transportation Research and Injury Prevention Centre of IIT-Delhi, argues that the Metro is an efficient mode of transportation only for commuters beyond 10 km. Her research shows that most city commuters are shorter than 5 km, for which passengers prefer other modes of transport since they have to factor in the time it takes to reach the Metro, the stops it makes en route, and last-mile connectivity. Even in a mega city like Delhi, the research shows, only 15% of the trips are longer than 10 km and 7% over 20 km.

Manvika Shivhare, a 29-year-old lawyer based in Lucknow, says most people she knows never use the 23-km-long city Metro to get round the city, preferring to travel in an auto or two-wheeler instead. "The Metro is useful for going to the Airport, for which it would cost Rs 70, while the auto would take Rs 400. But none of us uses the Metro for our daily commutes, since Lucknow is such a small city,"

Sreedharan says high fares are the main

reason behind low ridership in most Metros. "Metros are obliged to keep fare rates high mainly to make both ends meet," he says, a consequence, he believes, of the 2017 Metro Rail Policy, which places greater emphasis on the financial viability of Metro projects.

Responding to a question on poor ridership, a spokesperson of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs said, "Ridership projections for Metro systems take into account several factors, including the city's Master Plan and its future development potential. Ridership is also significantly influenced by the density and extent of the Metro network. Delhi-NCR has the largest Metro network in the country... It may also be noted that ridership on many lines of DMRC has exceeded the projections made in their DPRs [Detailed Project Report, the blueprint that lays out the project's design, costs, ridership and financial viability]."

Poor planning, execution

Investment banker Krish Sanghvi, 23, says that in Ahmedabad, the Metro does not serve SG Highway, the commercial hub of the city that's home to offices and malls, or the university area.

In 2022, a CAG report noted about the Nagpur Metro, "The location of New Airport station was not ideal from the viewpoint of ridership due to sparse population in and around the station and also from the accessibility point of view. The average ridership for a period of 18 months from date of commercial operation (March 2019) of the station was only 47 passengers per day as against the ridership of 5,474 per day envisaged in the DPR."

Experts also point out that our cities and transport systems are structured in ways that do little to encourage people to switch to public transport — from low or non-existent parking charges that make driving more attractive to poor footpaths.

Radhika Shenoy, 28, who works in Secunderabad, points out that last-mile connectivity is a major challenge. "Neither my house nor my office is close to a Metro station. So, taking public transport becomes more expensive than using my own scooter or hiring a cab," she says.

Others say the problem lies in the very process of deciding whether a city needs a Metro. It typically begins with a state government deciding it wants one, an idea that tends to crystallise quickly, often before any formal study has been done, says a consultant who asked to remain anonymous.

"The 2017 Metro Policy requires evaluating cheaper transport options like buses, bus rapid transit and trams, before committing

to a Metro, since it's the costliest mode to build. But state governments typically create a Metro authority and asks it — the same body that stands to run the project — to assess whether the city should build a Metro or not," the consultant says.

Take, for instance, the Jaipur Metro. In 2017, just two years after Jaipur Metro operations began, a CAG report pointed out that Jaipur city, with a population of 2.3 million, was not eligible for a Metro rail project.

It went on to give a damning assessment. "Due to defective planning and hasty decision making, a financially unviable Metro system was introduced in Jaipur city."

The Jaipur Metro saw an average daily ridership of 51,000 in its inaugural month of June 2015. As of June 2026, this figure stood at 53,000, and the Union Cabinet approved the second phase in April for Rs 13,037 crore.

The 28-km-long Kochi Metro, going by its DPR, should have had a daily ridership of 5.39 lakh by now, but averages around a lakh.

Loknath Behera, Managing Director of Kochi Metro Rail, which started operations in 2017, says the ridership projections in the initial DPR for Phase-I were later revised to 1.5 lakh per day, a target they hope to meet in the next 10 months.

Queries sent by *The Indian Express* to representatives of the Metro systems in Delhi, Lucknow, Ahmedabad, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Nagpur, Jaipur and Chennai went unanswered.

Critics say the problem of ridership often begins with the DPR. Praveen Goyal, a Metro consultant, says DPR projections typically build in assumptions — last-mile feeder networks and integration of various modes of transport — that rarely materialise on the ground. "Ridership models assume enabling infrastructure that governments and urban local bodies have not delivered," Goyal says.

Globally, too, large infrastructure projects often overestimate initial projections and underestimate costs, but these shortcomings are often overlooked in the name of the "greater public good." Like the 2017 Metro policy says, "As per global practice, urban transport projects, including urban rail, are treated as public projects which deliver public good. Therefore, appraisal of metro rail projects should entail economic and social cost benefit analysis."

'Build now or you miss the bus'

Proponents of Metro networks argue that no other mode can match a Metro's capacity on the busiest urban corridors.

"Tokyo was not built in a day, neither was Hong Kong, nor was Paris," says Sandip Chakrabarti, who co-heads the Centre for Transportation and Logistics at IIM Ahmedabad, arguing that big-infrastructure investments have to start well ahead of time.

"If we don't start building Metros in our smaller cities now, they will be in the same situation that our bigger cities are in today and we would have missed the bus."

He points out that it is easier and cheaper to build Metro systems in smaller cities early on, before they grow and get congested. "For instance, it is difficult for the Mumbai Metro to perform well because the

city has not been planned in a way to feed the Metro," says Chakrabarti.

Tiwari says the problem is not that governments promote the Metro, but that they do so at the cost of other public transport. "It's not that we have to oppose the Metro, but we have to be very clear

that the city will have to depend on a very good, reliable road-based system," she says. Anna Nagar, a slum built on a drain in central Delhi's TPO area, sits in the shadow of the Blue Line of the Delhi Metro. Every few seconds, a train roars above Zubaida Khatoun's head, drowning her voice as she talks about her daily Metro routine. "I would not have been able to get to work in Noida if not for the Metro," says the 21-year-old who is interning as an OT technician at a maternity hospital, 17 km from her home.

"The bus is cheaper, but then I have to go and stand at the bus stop at 6 am to be able to reach the hospital at 9 am. I reach in 45 minutes if I take the train. And I can even come home after 9 pm because the Metro feels so safe," she says.



FOR AN INTERACTIVE MAP OF YOUR CITY METRO NETWORK, SCAN THE QR CODE

Inside the coaches, the elements have little chance to disrupt, and the problems that afflict public systems in India — irregularity and delays — feel distant



If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

POLICY

CMs going abroad: The rules around political clearance

Shyamal Yadav
New Delhi, August 21

TELANGANA Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy's visit to the US has been cancelled after the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) denied "clearance from political angle", his office said on Friday. For a foreign trip, public servants need something called "political clearance" from the External Affairs Ministry.

What is political clearance?

Political clearance is granted by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). This is required not only for public servants but any government servant for a foreign trip. The MEA gets hundreds of requests for political clearance every month from ministries, secretaries, bureaucrats and other officials.

The decision to grant or deny clearance is based on multiple factors, such as the nature of the event, the level of participation from other countries, the kind of invitation that has been extended, and also India's relations with the host country. The system is meant to ensure that official foreign visits do not have diplomatic or foreign-policy implications that have not been assessed by the government.

Since 2016, political clearance applications can be made on the MEA website epolclearance.gov.in. These

are processed and clearance is issued after coordination among various ministry divisions.

RULES FOR OTHERS

For Union ministers, after getting political clearance from the MEA, additional clearance is needed from the PM, whether the trip is official or personal.

● Lok Sabha MP's need clearance from the Speaker, and Rajya Sabha members from the Chairperson.

Cabinet Secretariat circular on May 6, 2015, "... prior political clearance and FCRA (Foreign Contribution Regulation Act) clearance are mandatory."

CMs, ministers of state governments and other state officials also need clearance from the Department of Economic Affairs, and must send a copy of the application to the MEA Secretary. The DEA and the ministry concerned will entertain an application only if MEA's political clearance is attached with the request.

How common is denial of CMs' requests?

Political clearance being denied is nothing new. In 2022, Arvind Kejriwal, who was then the Delhi chief minister, had to cancel his Singapore visit after not receiving clearance. In October 2019, the Centre had not given him approval to attend another conference abroad.

During the previous UPA regime, the MEA had denied political clearance to trips by then chief ministers Tarun Gogoi (Assam, Congress) to the US and Israel, and Arjun Munda (Jharkhand, BJP) to Thailand. Gogoi had wanted to visit New York for a "high level meeting" on April 2, 2012; a note from the Ministry said: "... direct correspondence by a diplomatic Mission with a State Government being inappropriate". About his proposed trip to Israel for an event on water and environment technology, the Ministry had said: "Concerned agencies would be hard put to provide special consideration for CM, Assam, both from the substantive and protocol angles."

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LEGAL

How to define "industry": Inside SC's split verdict



VINEET BHALLA

IN A landmark judgment that brings the curtains down on a legal debate spanning multiple decades, a nine-judge Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court delivered a fractured verdict on what constitutes an "industry" under Indian labour law.

While the judgment comprises of five separate opinions that differ sharply on the interpretation of the law, they agreed on the practical position for pending proceedings: pending cases under the repealed Industrial Disputes Act, 1947, involving the definition of "industry", will continue to be decided under the 1978 "triple test" laid down by a seven-judge SC bench in *Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board vs A Rajappa*. The new Industrial Relations Code, 2020, will have to be interpreted independently under its own text and scheme.

History of dispute

The dispute centres on Section 2(j) of the erstwhile Industrial Disputes Act, 1947, which defined an "industry". Its broad wording led to decades of judicial debate over whether workplaces like hospitals, universities, charitable institutions and government departments came within its ambit — and whether those employees were entitled to statutory protections under the Act.

In 1978, a seven-judge bench in *Bangalore Water Supply* adopted an expansive interpretation. Justice V R Krishna Iyer's leading opinion laid down the "triple test": an undertaking would qualify as an industry if there was systematic activity, organised through cooperation between employer and employee, for the production or distribution of goods or services calculated to satisfy human wants and wishes.

The court held that the absence of a profit motive was irrelevant. It also developed a "dominant nature" test for establishments carrying on several activities and recognised a narrow exception for genuinely sovereign functions.

The judgment was not unanimous. The effective vote was 4-3 (two concurring opinions). The dissenting judges favoured an additional requirement that the activity

HOW THE ISSUE DIVIDED THE CONSTITUTION BENCH



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant

Justice Satish Chandra Sharma

Justice Alok Aradhe

Justice Vipul M Pancholi

Justice Dipankar Datta

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

"... this Court has repeatedly been required to navigate competing currents of thought in its search for a principled and workable understanding of Section 2(j)... it is our earnest hope that the present adjudication serves as a reliable beacon for courts and tribunals at various levels, bringing a greater measure of coherence, certainty, and finally to a question that has engaged judicial attention for decades."

Justice P S Narasimha

Justice B V Nagarathna

Justice Dipankar Datta

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

Justice Joymalya Bagchi

"A statute that creates Conciliation Officers, Labour Courts and Industrial Tribunals and hands them... power... needs to say, 'who falls within its reach.'"

"... a narrowly tailored definition of 'industry' would not assist in maintaining industrial peace, protection of workmen and employers..."

"... interpretation which yields to no manifest error, needs to be retained... the economic & technological changes since it was decided have weakened rather than strengthened the case for revisiting it."

be carried on along commercial lines.

The expansive interpretation came under pressure. Parliament passed the Industrial Disputes (Amendment) Act in 1982, seeking to exclude, among other categories, hospitals, educational and research institutions, charitable and philanthropic bodies and certain government activities. But the amended definition was never notified — it never acquired legal effect.

Meanwhile, the SC's own decisions diverged over issues such as government welfare activities and sovereign functions. In 1996, a three-judge bench held that the Social Forestry Department could be an industry, while a later two-judge bench took a narrower view in relation to a forest department.

In 2005, a five-judge bench in *State of UP vs Jai Bir Singh* expressed reservations about *Bangalore Water Supply* and referred the matter to a larger bench. In 2017, a seven-judge bench directed that it be placed before the present nine-judge bench.

Validity of reference

CJI Surya Kant, writing for himself and Justices Satish Chandra Sharma, Alok Aradhe and Vipul M Pancholi, upheld the validity of the reference. Justice P S Narasimha and Justice Joymalya Bagchi also agreed that the reference could validly be considered by the bench.

Balancing act

The ruling resolves the immediate problem created by the repeal of the Industrial Disputes Act without creating a new category of law for pending cases.

By retaining the 1978 test for those proceedings, the court has avoided reopening their legal basis. But it declined to carry that jurisprudence forward as the governing interpretation of the new labour code.

The expansive definition from 1978 will continue to apply to pending cases. It will have no bearing on the new Industrial Relations Code

core sovereign functions. But this was not made the governing test for pending cases which, he held, would continue to be governed by the extant triple test.

Justice Nagarathna defended the 1978 approach, as did Justices Datta and Bagchi. They stressed the social-welfare purpose of labour legislation and argued that introducing a commercial requirement could deprive workers in institutions such as hospitals and schools of statutory protection merely because their employers were not profit-making entities. Justice Bagchi described the triple test as possessing a "rare felicity in judicial interpretation", while Justice Nagarathna emphasised the importance of the test in protecting workers amid privatisation and changing economic conditions.

Justice Narasimha adopted a different approach. He wrote that the debate over modifying the triple test had become "unnecessary" because the Industrial Disputes Act had been repealed.

Pending cases

This is where the judges found common ground despite their differences.

The court declined to retrospectively replace the 1978 test with the newly formulated, narrower test. Pending proceedings under the old Industrial Disputes Act involving Section 2(j) will therefore continue to be decided in accordance with *Bangalore Water Supply*.

All the opinions also made it clear that the judgment does not have any bearing on the interpretation of the new Industrial Relations Code. The Code defines "industry" as any systematic activity involving cooperation between an employer and workers to produce or supply goods and services, regardless of capital investment or profit motive. Unlike the old law, the Code excludes charitable and philanthropic institutions, domestic services, and sovereign government functions from this definition. The SC has made clear that its provisions must be interpreted independently.

Sovereign functions

The ruling also dealt with the question of when government activities can be excluded as "sovereign functions". The broad principle emerging from the opinions is that an activity does not become sovereign just because it is performed by the State or is connected with a welfare objective. The exclusion is limited to core governmental functions. This is consistent with the approach in *Bangalore Water Supply*.

EDUCATION

How JNU's admission model gives marginalised students a leg-up

Sophia Mathew
New Delhi, August 21

A hallmark of Jawaharlal Nehru University's (JNU) admissions process is the decades-old "deprivation points" model. The system, unique to the varsity, aims to give a leg up in admissions to marginalised candidates — such as those from backward regions, women and transgender persons.

It has also sparked controversy from time to time since its introduction in the 1970s. In the most recent instance, an aspirant seeking admission to a JNU postgraduate course moved the Delhi High Court against the model. A division bench of the court allowed the university to continue following the system, subject to the final outcome of the candidate's plea that's being heard by a single judge.

What is the deprivation points model?

In the JNU admissions process, applicants to various undergraduate and postgraduate courses can be awarded a maximum of 12 points. These are known as deprivation points. The points are added to the candidate's entrance test score before

the final merit is determined.

One of the factors determining the points is the district the candidate comes from. For the current admissions cycle, the university has classified districts into Quartile 1 (backward) and Quartile 2 (relatively less backward) based on four indicators using Census data — percentage of female illiteracy, percentage of agricultural workers, percentage of rural population and percentage of households with no toilet within the premises.

For undergraduate admissions, a candidate can get six points for a Quartile 1 district and four points for a Quartile 2 district. For postgraduate admissions, the corresponding figures are three and two points respectively.

The system also provides five deprivation points to Kashmiri migrants. Female and transgender candidates are also eligible. They receive seven points if they fall within categories including SC, ST, OBC, PwD, Quartile 1 or Quartile 2, and five points if they are from the unreserved category and do not fall in either of the two district quartiles.

The points are awarded to undergraduate, postgraduate, certificate of proficiency and advanced diploma of proficiency programme. PhD programmes were excluded

The system, over the years

● The number of points and the criteria used to identify deprivation have changed over time.

● The system was withdrawn in the 1980s and restored in a modified form after student protests.

● In 2017, JNU discontinued deprivation points for MPhil and PhD admissions. But it continued for undergraduate and postgraduate admissions.

in 2017 after the varsity adopted the 2016 UGC admission guidelines.

Why was the system put in place?

The deprivation points system was introduced to ensure that the university did not merely draw students who had already benefited from greater educational opportunities. "When JNU was created by an Act of Parliament, it was not created for Delhi alone. It was supposed to draw talent from all across the country," said Professor Surajit Mazumdar, Professor of Economics at JNU's Centre for Economic Studies and Planning.

According to Mazumdar, the idea was that academic performance alone could not be treated as a complete measure of merit when students came from vastly different social, economic and regional circumstances. The model has helped address forms of disadvantage that reservation alone could not capture, he said.

In its initial form, districts were grouped according to objective indicators of development, with students from more deprived regions receiving additional weightage. The system was meant to "equalise" the conditions under which students competed for

admission. The system was withdrawn in 1984, but was restored from 1995-96 after pressure from the students' union.

Why is the model significant?

JNU's system is unique to any institute in the country, said Rituparna Patgiri, Assistant Professor of Humanities and Social Sciences at IIT-Guwahati. "I think the fundamental innovation that JNU tried to achieve through the deprivation points is not about which social category one belongs to, but the kind of structural deprivation and inequalities which shape educational opportunities," said Patgiri. "Our understanding of merit becomes more complicated when we consider how geography and region impact socio-historical formation."

Around one-third of the world's countries utilise affirmative action or targeted quotas — including those based on geographic or development indicators — to improve educational access, said the 2026 UNESCO Global Education Monitoring Report. It said India, alongside Brazil, China, Israel and Sri Lanka, has seen "increased enrolment" among under-represented groups "due to targeted measures."

GOVERNANCE

Routine data or citizenship check? Why Census questionnaire sparked concern

Deepthiman Tiwary
New Delhi, August 21

THE QUESTIONNAIRE for the population enumeration phase of Census 2027 has triggered a political controversy, with the Congress alleging that the inclusion of detailed questions about respondents and their parents could facilitate surveillance and serve a "disorderly nefarious purpose". The Left has raised similar concerns.

The controversy follows an August 15 report in *The Indian Express* that several new or modified questions in the Census questionnaire were also part of the National Population Register (NPR) schedule notified in 2020, when the NPR had become contentious amid protests over the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and fears of a nationwide National Register of Citizens (NRC).

New Census questions, NPR link

The questionnaire has 40 questions, 14 of them new or modified compared with the 2011 Census. Eight of these — national-

ity as declared, father's and mother's parents, mobile number, Aadhaar, voter ID, passport and driving licence — were also included in the NPR schedule prepared for the 2020 exercise.

The NPR schedule sought the date and place of birth of a person's father and mother, including the district and State and, if they were born outside India, the country. These questions had been at the centre of the political opposition to NPR.

The controversy

There are two distinct concerns: privacy and the political context in which the NPR was revived.

On privacy, the argument is that Census data has traditionally been collected for population statistics and planning, while the new questionnaire seeks a much wider range of personal information, including details that can identify or link individuals to other government databases. The question is therefore not simply how much data the government collects, but how it is stored, protected and used.



Census officials in Delhi. PRAFULLA KISHAN

The second concern relates to citizenship. The NPR is a register of the country's "usual residents", not a citizenship register. A usual resident is someone who has lived in a local area for at least six months or intends to stay there for the next six months;

this can include a foreigner meeting the residence criterion.

The NPR is, however, linked in law to the process for preparing the National Register of Indian Citizens. The Citizenship (Registration of Citizens and Issue of National Identity Cards) Rules, 2003, provide for preparation of a Population Register and its verification for preparation of the citizens' register. The rules also provide for individuals whose citizenship is considered doubtful to be marked for further inquiry.

This legal connection became politically explosive in 2019-20. The NPR was being revived soon after the CAA was passed and against the backdrop of the NRC in Assam, which had excluded around 19 lakh people. Also, Union Home Minister Amit Shah repeatedly spoke of a nationwide NRC and asked people to understand the "chronology" in which the CAA would be followed by the NRC.

NPR itself was not new. It had first been prepared in 2010 along with the housing phase of the 2011 Census and was updated through a door-to-door exercise in 2015.

But this political context fundamentally changed how a previously uncontroversial exercise came to be perceived as one being associated with the possibility of citizenship being questioned.

What government said in 2020

The government sought to reassure people that the controversial questions on parents' date and place of birth were optional. The government also maintained that NPR was primarily a database of residents intended to improve policy formulation and delivery of welfare schemes. Shah argued that knowing the demographic composition of an area would help governments plan services and identify beneficiaries.

There was, however, a contradiction that contributed to the mistrust. In December 2019, Shah said NPR data would never be used for an NRC and that the two exercises were governed by different laws. But earlier government statements in Parliament and the Citizenship Rules themselves had explicitly linked the Population Register to preparation of the citizens' register.

Government's need for data

There is a legitimate administrative rationale for collecting detailed demographic data. The government has argued that a comprehensive database of residents can help it formulate policies, plan public services, identify beneficiaries and improve national security. Information drawn from different government databases can also help reduce the duplication and discrepancies in records and cut paperwork for citizens.

The NPR was also envisaged as a way of bringing together basic demographic information with details such as mobile numbers and identity documents. Officials said this could make government services more efficient. These are not inherently unreasonable objectives. Nor are NPR and NRC, as eco-duplication in themselves, necessarily "nefarious". The problem in 2019-20 was the timing, as the NPR was revived amid denied public trust and government assurances failing to restore that trust. It explains why questions that might otherwise seem routine are being viewed through the prism of citizenship and surveillance.



Love in the Time of Abstinence

Shalini Langer

IN *One Night Only*, Allie (Monica Barbaro) says it's the "build-up" that is the best part of sex for her. Owen (Callum Turner) says it's the "after". Quite like those predictable responses, the latest film by Will Gluck (with other bawdy modern romances behind him, such as *Anyone But You*, *Friends with Benefits*, *Easy A*) is a nice-enough rom-com that pretends very hard to be somewhat radical.

And while it is beating about the bush, the film's "build-up" — despite all the kissing and petting and lovemaking going on around the two leads — is hardly a turn-on. While the "after" is not the movie's concern.

But, in the middle, *One Night Only* truly sparkles, thanks largely to the charisma of Barbaro and Turner, and not by a small measure due to the shiny tssy-bitsy thing

that Allie wears for a majority of the film. Rarely has a halter neck been called upon to hold up so much, and rarely has it been wielded this effortlessly.

The premise is that a "post-Obama" US government (that is as close to a political statement as the film gets) "outlawed" premarital sex three years ago, allowing single people to have sex only one night of the year. All the adults are branded on their wrists with marks which light up as red and green depending on whether you are conforming or breaking the rules.

The young people may abuse the "mandate", so to speak, every so often, but clearly no one — including police, who are called upon to enforce the celibacy rule — believes in rebelling against it.

Owen and Allie cross each other's paths on this once-in-a-year night, when amorous men and women can barely keep their

ONE NIGHT ONLY

★★★

DIRECTOR: Will Gluck

CAST: Monica Barbaro, Callum Turner, Maya Hawke, King Princess, Molly Ringwald, Pete Davidson, Bobby Cannavale, Nicholas Braun

hands off each other — be it in the Metro, restaurants, streets, cars, or open windows of their homes — except the two of them.

Owen has a girlfriend (Maya Hawke), who tells him on this day that she wants to "experiment" for this night, and says he is too "super-programmed" (the buttoned-down Polo T-shirt he wears is the only real example of it, though). Allie would rather have a meaningful connection than a meaningless romp in the hay, though it doesn't require her much persuasion to wear the aforementioned dress to try her luck in any case.

Why the singles are not using the rest of the 364 days to prepare for this big night is not clear. But, if you go down that path, then little about this "mandate", or the uncomplaining obedience of it by a population, is.

Meanwhile, Owen and Allie keep run-

ning into each other across New York, even as they are going down different romantic paths, and several known faces drop in as cameos. Luckily for *One Night Only*, sparks indeed fly and the film does become an equal parts comedy as the desperate search for consummation — and in a hilarious sequence, for a condom — leads the two into several sticky situations.

So is *One Night Only* a cautionary tale about sexual prudism, or about sexual liberation? What is all that sex on one side, and that easy resolve not to have it for a year, meant to add up to? A President-like figure pops up once, cites how "teen pregnancies are down to zero" as are sexually transmitted diseases. He also suggests the one-day's concession is a "compromise", for the US to show the world "that it is different".

At least Trump won't be auditioning for this one.



Just Thrills, Little Else

Alaka Sahani

THE TITLE of the movie *Mutiny* might be misleading for an action-packed revenge drama set on the high seas but it goes all out when it comes to delivering the thrill that a Jason Statham-starrer promises. The action star, who has kept this genre alive and kicking with theatrical outings like *The Beekeeper* (2024), returns on the big screen as a former Royal Marine, Cole Reed. He is serving as the bodyguard of a billionaire industrialist, who treats him as family. When the benevolent billionaire is ambushed and murdered in front of him, Reed becomes the suspect. Seeking revenge, Reed tries to find the people behind the killing as well as to prove his innocence.

Once he boards a container ship, the story follows a predictable trajectory with a string of action sequences. If that's something Statham's fans are expecting, then the formula-driven actioner will not disappoint them. Without any pretence or frills, the movie remains focussed on presenting one action sequence after another. Just like Statham's expressions, which rarely change, the movie, too, does not change its tone during the 95-minute runtime.

The narrative introduces some twists. While these might not make the audience sit up, they will keep the viewers interested. Statham does most of the heavy lifting as he shoots and stabs. He finds an ally in Angie Ellis (Annabelle Wallis), who joins him in beating the baddies. Wallis is convincing as an action star as she takes a bullet and fights fiercely alongside Statham. Together, they turn it into a good vs evil battle — something most thrill-seeking audiences are drawn to.

As most of the action takes place on a moving cargo ship, the deep sea becomes the backdrop for the Jean-François Richet directorial. Brendan Gallin's cinematography, David Rosenbloom's editing and Marcus Truemp's music maintain the momentum even when the narrative slows down. That helps since barring a few characters, most of them don't leave an impression. Even though Ellis longs to be united with her daughter, it is never fully explored.

However, if the reason for watching *Mutiny* is to be entertained as intense gun-fighting unfolds or speeding vehicles topple and crash, then it will be a satisfying viewing experience. After all, what is more reassuring than a good guy saving the day and punishing the baddies.

All Bark, No Bite

Shubhra Gupta

A GLOBAL cartel called 7 Dogs. A super-strong drug called Pink Lady. Good guys. Bad guys. And a billion-dollar budget. Make that billions. And there's your big Arabic blockbuster, studded with international stars and locations, its India release buoyed by the presence of Salman Khan and Sanjay Dutt.

I must confess that I went into the movie mostly to see what the two Bollywood superstars would do in a film like this one, whose plotline resembles countless films they've been part of. Clearly, the Belgian-Moroccan director duo of two of the 'Bad Boys' capers — as well as a couple of episodes in the enjoyable series *Ms Marvel* — are capable of mounting films on scale, creating kinetic spectacles with a high degree of entertainment. But with this one, top-lined by Saudi stars Karim Abdel Aziz and Ahmed Ezz, accompanied by the dapper Giancarlo Esposito, and the very international Monica Bellucci, the fun factor dips in a thin screenplay saddled with predictable patches.

Khalid (Ahmed Ezz) is an intrepid Interpol agent, about to hang up his boots for a sedate desk job and holy matrimony, not necessarily in that order. But he's pulled off his pile of files, leaving his anxious-to-be-bridal and know-it-all mother fighting over the wedding plans, for a new assignment to stop the 7 Dogs in its tracks, for which he is teamed up with the dubious Ghali (Karim Abdel Aziz), the latter being the only one who

**7 DOGS**

★

DIRECTOR: Adil El Arbi, Bilal Fallah

CAST: Karim Abdel Aziz, Ahmed Ezz, Monica Bellucci, Giancarlo Esposito, Salman Khan, Sanjay Dutt

can help infiltrate the gang.

The trouble with shooting everything on a set, however gigantic it may be — is that everything looks like a set, and computer graphics look like computer graphics. When the action spills over into the desert, the vistas are breathtaking; the rest, whether it's Shanghai or Mumbai, is as generic as it can be.

What is it with international productions thinking that narrow, over-crowded *gullies* represent Mumbai? In a shack, nestled in Salman Khan as a small-time informer called Johar: in a bigger shack, Sanjay Dutt holds court as flamboyant goon Ranijit. They're both big draws in the West Asia, Salman being the bigger one, but their parts are nothing but glorified cameos.

The second half lurches about, with Khalid and Aziz team-tagging through a series of seen-before sequences, involving vault-breaks, poker games, and desert shoot-outs. And the promise of a follow-up.

**INSIDIOUS: OUT OF THE FURTHER**

★★★

DIRECTOR: Jacob Chase

CAST: Amelia Eve, Island Austin, Lin Shaye, Sam Spruell, Brandon Perea, Maisie Richardson-Sellers, Charl Panton

that shows, though as mother and daughter, the pair of Amelia Eve (in the role of Gemma) and Island Austin (Maya) are pretty good.

Twenty years ago, when Gemma was a young girl herself played by an aggressive Charl Panton, she saw her mother deteriorate and die a horrible death. Now she is the mother to Maya, who is as precocious as Gemma had been at her age. Despite the advice of her friend Nick (Brandon Perea), Gemma continues to live in the same house where the terrors of her child-

STREAMING WATCHLIST



Blood Sacrifice

NETFLIX

NEW SWEDISH five-part crime thriller series, created by George Kay (Lupin, Hijack), introduces a tense and emotionally charged hunt for a killer

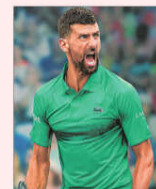
targeting the police. Jakob Oftebro stars as lead investigator Thomas, forced to work with his estranged father Alfred, a former detective played by Peter Andersson. As bodies mount and the attacks draw closer to home, father and son must put decades of resentment aside to stop a brutal killer before time runs out. The series is directed by Kristoffer Nyholm.



Here the Whole Time

NETFLIX

AN ADAPTATION of Vitor Martins's bestseller, features Miguel Lallo and Diego Lira in the leads. Felipe (Lallo), a teenager with a passion for pop culture, just wants to survive the summer break — staying away from the school bullies and binge-watching his favorite shows. But his plans go awry when his neighbor Caio (Lira), the popular guy at school and his old crush, moves in under the same roof for two weeks.



Novak Djokovic: The Wolf in Winter

PRIME VIDEO

THE FEATURE-LENGTH sports documentary offers an intimate, behind-the-scenes look at the life and career of 24-time Grand Slam champion Novak Djokovic. It traces

his remarkable journey from a childhood shaped by war in Serbia to becoming one of the most dominant and polarising figures in tennis history. Directed by Jason Hehir, the documentary also features Andre Agassi, Boris Becker, and Howard Bryant.



Clean Up Company

MX PLAYER

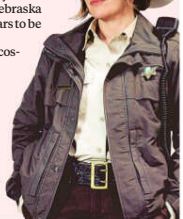
RAJU, SWAPAN, and Goldie stumble into an unusual way of making money when they are asked to dispose of a

gangster. What begins as a one-off job soon turns into a business of their own, but their new venture pulls them deeper into the dangerous world of Sarigunj, where gang rivalries, crime, and shifting loyalties are part of everyday life. Directed and written by Rohan Ghose and co-written by Konarak Mukherjee, *Clean Up Company* stars Amey Wagh, Vishal Jethwa, Ajitesh Gupta, Jisshu Sengupta, Saswata Chatterjee, and Ravi Kishan.

Lanterns

JIOHOTSTAR

THE SERIES follows veteran intergalactic cop Hal Jordan and rookie John Stewart as they investigate a murder in a small Nebraska town. What initially appears to be a simple local crime soon unravels into a sprawling cosmic mystery with consequences that could alter the fate of the entire universe. Kyle Chandler and Aaron Pierre star as Hal and John, joined by Kelly Macdonald, Garrett Dillahunt and Poorna Jagannathan.



ALAKA SAHANI

hood came to pass. Not only that, she has also kept all her mother's things in a basement with easy access.

A horror film would never get too far if better sense prevailed. And so it happens that Gemma realises that things from 20 years ago are repeating in her house; she is seeing people who clearly do not belong to this world and, like her mother, she is ignoring her daughter or snapping at her. She doesn't learn her lesson even when she finds herself trapped "Backrooms" style, between sofa seats.

A solution comes by way of Elise (Lin Shaye), as it does in the *Insidious* films, and it involves a lot of body swapping. Further trawling, courage, claws, more teeth, and — for some reason — a bagful of oranges.

Why use oranges to represent humans? Think further.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

IMZAMUDH KUMAR S/O MOHD VASIN, R/O HNO-4/25, STREET 18, 5/2, BHAGIRATH VIHAR, DELHI-110094 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME MOHD NIZAMUDDIN TO NIZAMUDDIN FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

04087372-1

NW. Nigirnam Kolera S/o W. Nigirnam Kolera, R/o Flat-on Second-Floor Left-79, B/1093, Ward No.-1, S.L. John Church Compound, Mehrauli, New Delhi-110093, do hereby declare that W. Nigirnam Kolera and W. Nigirnam Kolera are one and the same Person.

04087373-5

Parveen Kumar S/O Rajender Prasad, R/O VPO-Fatehpur Bilal, Faridabad-121004, Haryana have changed my name from Parveen Kumar to Parveen Kumar Garg for all purposes.

040873608-1

IKPRAVALIKA, W/O K. PRADEEP KUMAR RAO, R/O V-35, COLONY VILLAGE SIRJAM, KHEERKADA MANDI, VISAKHAPATNAM ANDHRA PRADESH 531028, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM K. PRAVALIKA TO KAMAKILA PRAVALIKA, VIDE AFFIDAVIT, DATED-20/08/2026, BEFORE NCT-DELHI.

040873734-8

Seema Prakash Jamdade D/o Prakash Jamdade, R/O Flat No.3, block-H, Associated Apartments, Delhi-110092, Patparganj, Delhi-110092 have changed my minor Daughter's name from Satvika Vinoh Kumar to Satvika Seema Jamdade D/o Seema Prakash Jamdade for all future purposes.

040873602-3

IShekhar Chandra S/O Shri Raj Ram, R/O B-137, New Ashok Nagar, Delhi-110096, inform that Shiekhar and Shiekhar Chandra, both names are same person.

040873756-2

IDHIRAJ KUMAR, S/O SURENDRA PRATAP MISHRA R/O A-17, QUTUB VIHAR, PART-2, PHOOLA DAIRY, PO-CHHAI, NARAINAGAR, NEW DELHI-110071, have changed my name to DHIRAJ MISHRA vide affidavit dated 19 AUG, 2026 at DELHI.

050259587-1

ISANTOSH JAIN S/O Ratan Lal Jain R/O House No-10, U-Block, Pitampura Delhi-110034, have changed my name to SANTOSH KUMAR.

040873733-1

IPromod Kumar, S/O Sh. Chand Prakash, R/O 3109, Sector-6, Pocket-4, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070, have changed my name for Permod Kumar for all future purposes.

040873733-10

IGanpat Singh, S/O Sh. Bh. Singh, R/O-136, KP-2, First Floor, Aaypee Vihar, Sector-131, Noida, G.G. Nagar, UP-201304 have changed my name to Ganpat Singh Bisht. Henceforth, I shall be known as Ganpat Singh Bisht for all purposes.

040873736-1

IMahesh S/O Chander R/O Badshahpur, Tenthar, Kherli Lala (220) Gurgaon Haryana-122103 have changed my name to Nareesh Kumar for all purposes.

040873735-7

IAbhinit Kumar S/o Om Prakash Singh R/O Suroor Nagar, Delhi, changed my name from Abhineth Kumar to Ritu Rani Choudhary for all purposes.

040873756-4

ISarita Choudhary, D/o Rajender Singh, declare that Sarita, Sarita Devi and Sarita Choudhary are one and the same person. My correct name is Sarita Choudhary, as per my Aadhaar Card and PAN Card. Henceforth, I shall be known as Sarita Choudhary for all purposes.

040873730-1

IREena W/o Pawan Kumar R/O H.No.536, Gali No-12, Ward No.19, Near Police Station, New Defence Colony, Muradnagar, Dist Ghaziabad, UP-201206 have changed my name from Reena to Reena Kashiya. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Reena Kashiya for all future purposes.

071055920-1

IKarpaga Valli/W/o Thirupathi Krishnan R/O A/165, Sarathi Nagar, District Madurai, PO Tirumalgar, Dist Madurai, Tamil Nadu-625014, That my name is wrongly mentioned as A KARPAGA VALLI instead of ARPAGAVALLI in my husband Army Service Record.

040873733-3

ISARAF RAJ, S/O LITAJ RAJ, RESIDENT OF WARD NO-22, HARDOCHANI ROAD NEAR BYPASS NABIPUR, GURDASPUR, PUNJAB-143521 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME SARAF RAJ TO RAJ KUMAR FOR ALL PURPOSES.

040873734-3

ITanya Sekhon, wife of Ratan Singh, resident of 151, Ground Floor Front, Ashoka Enclave 1, Sector-34, Amnagar, Faridabad-121003, have changed my name from "Tanya Sekhon" to "Tanya Singh Sekhon"

071055907-1

ISAWDESH KUMAR TYAGI S/O RAM KISHORE TYAGI R/O No. 148 Gali No-16 KAUSHIK ENCLAVE, BURARI DELHI-84 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAVINDRA KUMAR FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

050259587-1

IRAVINDRA SINGH, S/O Yogesh Singh, R/O Noida, Sector-15, Noida, G.G. Nagar, UP-201304, S/O Pratap Vihar Part-2, Kirari Suleman Nagar Delhi-110086, have changed my name to RAVINDRA KUMAR.

040873734-2

IMushbah Kumar Father of Shunehar Gupta R/O E-10, Krishan Vihar, Delhi-110086, have changed my name to Mushbah Kumar Gupta.

040873722-1

INareesh Kumar, father of Chhalesh, R/O VPO-Badshahpur, Tenthar, Kherli Lala (220) Gurgaon Haryana-122103, have changed my minor son's name Chhalesh to Chhalesh Boka, for all purposes.

040873735-9

IHarman Preet Singh R/O Guram Singh R/O B-8/62, Type-2, Police Line, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Harmanpreet Singh.

040873735-2

IKM BABITA RANI AGGARWAL W/O AMIT KUMAR GARG R/O 142/63, LEKHA NAGAR, DELHI-110035 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO BABITA GARG FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

0407105923-1

IChatresh Kumar Saxena R/O Patha, Chhatrapur, Madhya Pradesh-471510, have changed my minor son's name from Lalit Kishor to Raj Saxena.

040873756-6

IMampi Bal D/o Ranjit Kumar R/O C-26, First Floor, Sector-15, Noida, UP-201304, have changed my name to Mampi Deb for all purposes.

040873643-1

IRADHA DEVI/W/O LAXMAN SINGH BISHT R/O H.NO.21, 15.5/FKH, NO. 23, WEST SAGARPUR, SOUTH WEST DELHI-110046, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as RADHA BISHT.

040873735-3

IRajiv Chaudhary S/O Om Prakash Sansawal R/O P-102, Gumbad Wals Khat, Katwaria Sarai, Hazrat Ghas, Delhi-110016, have changed my daughter's name from Kanak Sansawal to Kanak Chaudhary.

040873734-1

IMegha Kochhar D/o Vinod Kumar Chhabra R/O Flat No. C-1/25, Pharma Apartments, Plot No.88, LP, Extension, Patparganj Delhi-110092 have changed my Surname from Megha Chhabra to Megha Chhabra.

071055914-1

IBUSHRITA FAF/W/O ATIF KHURSHED, R/O 25-B/3 BATLA HOUSE CHOWK, JALANAGAR, OKHLA DELHI 110025, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME BUSHRITA ATIF TO BUSHRITA SULTAN PERMANENTLY.

040873733-11

IWahid Hussain/Mohd Abdul Wahid/Hussain/Hussain S/O Badrudin R/O-43, Andh University, Panchkula Road, Goal Market, Delhi-110001, have changed my name to Wahid Hussain for all purposes.

040873735-11

IRitu Rani Alias Ritu Rani Choudhary D/o Dhanam Singh Lamba W/o Rajesh Kumar Choudhary R/O 200, Kohat Enclave, Pitampura, Saraswati Vihar, North West Delhi, Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Ritu Rani Choudhary

071055983-1

ISumit Mittal S/O Late Sh. R. Kumar Mittal R/O PK002R053 (R053) Kensington Park 2, R. Block, Near Promethous School Jaypee Greens w/o, Sector-131, Asgardpur Jagir, Baraulla, Dist. Gt.B. Nagar UP-201304, have changed my minor son's name from Hridhaan Mittal to Hridhaan Sumit Mittal for all future purposes.

040873598-1

IPawan Kumar Pareek S/O Ramnirach Pareek R/O 266, Additional Floor, Portion, 1st Floor, Block-A, Sector-1, Sector-13, Noida-110086, have changed my minor Daughter's name Vandita to Vandita Pareek.

040873735-4

IMOHD QASIM THAKUR S/O PURAN THAKUR, R/O B-4, TOP FLOOR, ST-18, ZAKI NAGAR, OKHLA, NEW DELHI-110025, have changed my name from Mohd Qasim to Mohd Qasim Thakur and both are the same person.

071055961-1

ISUNIL SINGH S/O Nand Lal, R/O-421, Durga Ashram, Chhattarpur, New Delhi-74, have changed my name to SUNIL KUMAR for all purposes.

040873601-2

ISANDEEP JAIN, S/O DHANRAJ JAIN, R/O H No 6-55/Ground Floor, B.L.K., Sec-16, Near R.J Community Hall, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have changed my minor son's name ATISHAY TO ATISHAY JAIN.

040873733-7

IKAPIL MANIK S/O MUKLH RAJ RESIDENT 831, SECTOR-15, KONDAPAT, HARYANA, HAVE CHANGED MY MINOR SON'S NAME FROM DAKSH MANIK TO DAKSHITIA MANIK.

040873734-3

INazra D/o Wahid Hussain, R/O-43, Andh University, Panchkula Road, Goal Market, Delhi-110001, have changed my name to Nazra Bano for all purposes.

040873756-1

IRAVINDRA SINGH, S/O Yogesh Singh, R/O Noida, Sector-15, Noida, G.G. Nagar, UP-201304, S/O Pratap Vihar Part-2, Kirari Suleman Nagar Delhi-110086, have changed my name to RAVINDRA KUMAR.

040873734-2

ISirman, D/O Rameshwar, R/O Surajpur Greater Noida-201306 have changed my name to Simran Kushwah

005295873-1

IKushagra Bakshi, S/O Manek Eshtwar Bakshi R/O C-107/17C, Lawrence Road, Keshav Puram, Delhi-110035, have changed my name from Kushagra Bakshi to Kushagra Manek Bakshi for all future purposes.

040873722-5

IVijay Sharma S/O Om Prakash Sharma R/O D-97 Surajmal Vihar Delhi-92, have changed my name to Vijay Krishna Sharma.

040873733-9

IMohammad Tariq Yameen, S/O Mohammad Yameen, R/O Plot No.1794 Second-Floor, A-Corridor, Vasant Kunj, Enclave New Delhi-110070, have changed my name to Tariq Yamin, for all purposes.

040873736-6

IEkta Arora W/o Manish Bahga R/O 352-A, F/F, Maniram Mandir-Road, Sholanki Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032, have changed my name to Ekta Bhalha.

040873480-12

IJC-478400, N/S/SUB, Rajesh R/O D-60, Gohri, Tehsil-Makrana District, Nagpur, Rajasthan-341319, my service record name of my mother and son has been wrongly mentioned as Ustav Kanwar instead of Uchkar Kanwar as mentioned in Aadhar card, Son as Harwardhan Singh as mentioned in Harwardhan Singh as mentioned in education certificates vide affidavit No. JK442926 dated 20th August 2026 before public notary Kupwara.

040873736-1

IFAFSHA PARVEEN, W/O Asim Ali R/O H.No.-198/3, Gali-No.-4, Purana Kirti Nagar, Delhi-110054 have changed my name from AFSHA PARVEEN TO AFSHA for all future purposes.

040873734-9

IPAWAN KUMAR, S/O LAXMAN DASS, R/O T-1510, ELVIJAY MARG BALI, DISTRICT NAGPAL, NAGAR, CENTRAL DELHI-110008, DECLARE THAT PAWAN KUMAR BROTHER AND I ARE ONE AND SAME PERSON.

040873756-3

Ihitherto known as Susheela, wife of Ravi Datta Sharma residing at D-70, Sector-12, Pratap Vihar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SUSHELA SHARMA.

050259587-1

IMadhusmita Behera, W/o Saumya Ranijan Behera, R/O Flat No-1608, Corporate Executive Apartment, Palam Vihar, Sector-23, Gurgaon, Haryana-122017 India have changed my name to Madhusmita Behera.

040873733-2

ISanjeet Arora S/O Ajoy Arora R/O F-2703, Apex The Kremlin, N-24, Siddhant Vihar, Vijay Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009, inform that in my passport my father's name is mentioned as Ajoy Arora instead of Ajay Arora.

040873819-2

ISatinder Pal Singh Bhatia Alias Satinder Pal Singh S/O Kartar Singh, R/O House No. 359 1st Floor, D. Mukherjee Nagar, PO Dr. Mukherjee Nagar, North West Delhi, Delhi-110009, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Satinder Pal Singh

071055961-1

INareesh Kumar, father of Abhi, R/O VPO-Badshahpur, Tenthar, Kherli Lala (220) Gurgaon Haryana-122103, have changed my minor son's name Abhi to Abhi Boka for all purposes.

040873735-1

ILILSHAD MALIK S/O AJMERI KHAN R/O F-80A, GALI NO.3, CHAND BAGH, NORTH-EAST, DELHI-110094, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM LILSHAD TO LILSHAD MALIK FOR ALL PURPOSES.

071055981-1

INishi Malhotra spouse of Girish Kumar Chopra resident of D-11, Sector-11, Noida, have changed my name from Nishi Malhotra to Nishi Chopra vide Affidavit dated-20.08.2026 at Noida.

040873731-1

ISushila Solanki, D/o Dhooop Singh Dankhar, W/o Satish Kumar Solanki, R/O Plot No.54, F/B/5, Sector-48, Major-Bola Ram-Enclave, Sec-23, Dwarka, Delhi-110078, have changed my name to Sushila Devi.

040873735-1

IDeepak Rana S/O Harvart Singh Rana R/O A-701, Subhakarmanya Apartments, Sector-50, Noida, UP-201301, have changed my minor son's name from REYANSH TO REYANSH ANNA for all purposes.

071055922-1

IUravshi, R/O-Niranjan Singh, R/O-74, C-Pocket D-2, Kondli, Mayur-Vihar Phase-II, Noida-110086, have changed my name to Uravshi Singh. Henceforth, I shall be known as Uravshi Singh, for all purposes and records.

040873756-5

INARINDER KUMAR S/O Purushottam Das R/O-46/14, ASHOK NAGAR, N.D.18, have changed my name to NARENDER KUMAR for all purposes.

040873733-4

ISHWININDER SINGH S/O KULWANT SINGH BHATTAR R/O A-2182, PASCHIM VIHAR, DELHI-110063 have changed my name to ISHWININDER SINGH BHATTIA.

040873733-13

IMAMTA DEVI W/o Sunil Kumar, R/O-421/2, Durga Ashram, Chhattarpur, New Delhi-110074, have changed my name to MAMTA for all purposes.

040873601-1

ILhanpal S/O W/o Nareesh, R/O N-147/25, Munshi Ram Colony, Dr. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi-110009, have changed my name to Munni Devi.

040873732-3

IAtjay Kumar Verma S/O Nand Singh R/O House No. G-270, Gali No.6, Sector Gamma-2, Greater Noida Dist G.B.Nagar, UP-201308 have changed my name from Atjay Kumar Verma to Atjay Kumar. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Atjay Kumar for all future purposes.

071055912-1

ILhazra Bano D/o Wahid Hussain, R/O-43, Andh University, Panchkula Road, Goal Market, Delhi-110001, have changed my name to Hajra Bano for all purposes.

040873735-10

I, HUSSAIN BANO W/O MOHAMMAD SAID D-2683 STREET LATE WALI CHOTI BARADARI BALLIMARAN DELHI 110006, have changed my name to HUSBAN BANO.

071055982-1

Ihitherto known as Aditya Kumar alias Aditya Kumar Thakur S/O Arun Kumar R/O B-177/10, Shastri Nagar, Ashok Vihar, Delhi-110052, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Aditya Kumar Thakur.

040873722-2

ILcheta Vohra, D/O-S.K. Malhotra, R/O No.-J.P-52, IInd Floor, Maurya-Enclave, Pitampura, Near J.P. B.L.K., DDA-MRKT, Maurya-Enclave, North West Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Chetna Malhotra.

040873736-1

IManoj Kumar Sharma S/O Shyam Sunder Sharma, Rank EX POSRI, S. No. 12179R, R/O Flat No. 654, 2nd Floor, Sector-48, Chandigarh-160047 have changed my name from RIDDIHI SHARMA to KANISHKA SHARMA vide affidavit DL17.8.26 before Noida.

071055928-2

IMunni/W/o W/o Wahid Hussain, R/O-43, Andh University, Panchkula Road, Goal Market, Delhi-110001, have changed my name to Munni Bano for all purposes.

040873735-12

ILARJAN A.V. S/O Shri K. Vasudevan, R/O 21-C, Pocket-3, Mayur Vihar Phase-1, Delhi-110091, have changed my name to ARJAN AREKARA VASUDEVAN for all purposes.

040873722-4

INibha D/O Ramanuj Singh R/O R-16, Nihal Vihar, Nanjoli, New Delhi-110041, have changed my name to Nibha Kumar for all future purposes.

040873819-1

ISanjeet Arora S/O Ajoy Arora R/O F-2703, Apex The Kremlin, N-24, Siddhant Vihar, Vijay Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009, inform that in my passport my father's name is mentioned as Ajoy Arora instead of Ajay Arora.

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040873733-13

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040873601-1

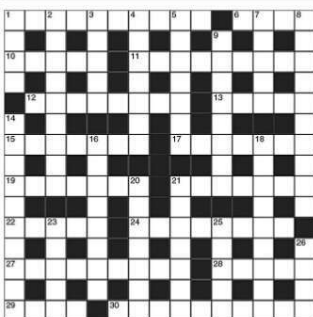
ILhanpal S/O W/o Nareesh, R/O N-147/25, Munshi Ram Colony, Dr. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi-110009, have changed my name to Munni Devi.

040873732-3

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CROSSWORD

6074



ACROSS

1 Socialist soccer player (4-6)
6 The favourite is making no effort we hear (4)
10 A rough job of cleaning (5)
11 Touching on a union with indifferent result (9)
12 Spring a look outside and make illegal entry (8)
13 After a drink half the band provide dance music (5)
15 Heroine died of lost hope and returning trouble (7)
17 Showed no respect and ate greedily (7)
19 We yearn for change in early January (3,4)
21 Unusual gear shown after getting a pass in school (7)
22 Dark disturbing thing (5)
24 Neat and honest (8)
27 Not bubbly but nevertheless a grape product (5,4)
28 Transport from the East is not in time (5)
29 One doesn't have to have it (4)
30 Payment for one episode of a serial (10)

DOWN

1 Getting drunk? That's rich! (4)
2 Down-to-earth entertainment (5,4)
3 Factory labours (5)
4 Falls for a redhead once more and uplifted (7)
5 How time flies! (7)
7 Churned up mud at the starting line (5)
8 Their union offers security (4,3,3)
9 Burn a fuel that draws well (8)
14 It's bright and early (7,3)
16 Speak falsely yet be quiet (3,5)
18 Newcomer with a healthy complexion (5,4)
20 Used by communicators in a USSR translation (7)
21 Running dog on hire (7)
23 A leading publication? (5)
25 One hand is just perfect (5)
26 Cried quietly in the rain (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6073 ACROSS: 1 Lyrical, 5 Light, 8 Ascertain, 9 Via, 10 Heep, 12 Denounce, 14 Rotten, 15 Relief, 17 Pretoria, 18 Weed, 21 Pas, 22 Gladstone, 24 Rest, 25 Dailies DOWN: 1 Loath, 2 Roc, 3 Cure, 4 Leader, 5 Londoner, 6 Give me, 7 Tea leaf, 11 Acres, 13 Besought, 14 Repaper, 16 Riband, 19 Deeds, 20 Asti, 23 Obi

JUMBLED WORDS

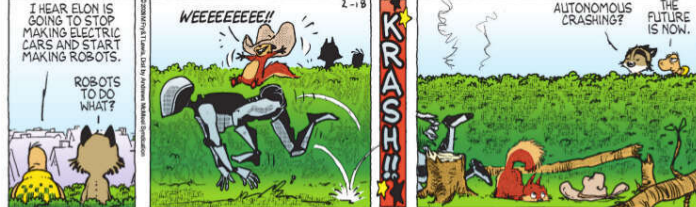
Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

He who would _____ happily must _____ light - Antoine de Saint-Exupéry (6,...,6) (same word twice)

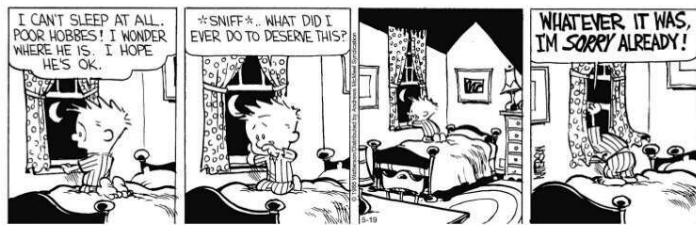


SOLUTIONS: Agave, Drift, Lively, Vector

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



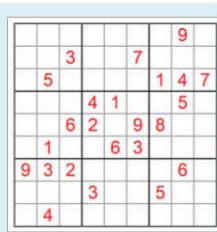
DIFFICULTY LEVEL

45 INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very hard; 6s = Genius



SOLUTION SUDOKU 6417



PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Nadeem Ahmed S/o Jameel Ahmed R/o B-422, Gali No. 11, Subhash Mohalla North Ghonda, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 196/2017 U/s 3181 M.V. ACT, PS Jafraabad, Delhi** and it has been returned to arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nadeem Ahmed** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nadeem Ahmed** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Anushtha Srivastava
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 07, 2nd Floor
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9852/NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Person **Karan, S/o: Shripal R/o: A-73 PH-2 Metro Vihar Holambi Kalan, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 192/2023 Dt. 24.01.2023, U/s: 356/379/411 IPC, PS: Narela Industrial Area, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Karan**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Karan**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Karan**, of **FIR No. 192/2023 Dt. 24.01.2023, U/s: 356/379/411 IPC, PS: Narela Industrial Area, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.09.2026**.

By Order
Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North Court No. 6 Ground Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/11702/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Prem, S/o Chabi Lal, R/o 459-460, 2nd Floor, F-Block, JJ Colony, Shakurpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 258/2024, U/s 188 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Prem** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Prem** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Prem** accused of **FIR No. 258/2024, U/s 188 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.09.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Upasana Satija
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, North-West
Room No. 108, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11757/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rajesh, S/o Lal Bahadur, R/o K-482, JJ Colony, Shakurpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 239/2016, U/s 394/411/34 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Rajesh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Rajesh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Rajesh** accused of **FIR No. 239/2016, U/s 394/411/34 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.10.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Upasana Satija
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, North-West
Room No. 108, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11741/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82(2)(ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Karan, S/o: Shripal R/o: A-73 PH-2 Metro Vihar Holambi Kalan, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 192/2023 Dt. 24.01.2023, U/s: 356/379/411 IPC, PS: Narela Industrial Area, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Karan**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Karan**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Karan**, of **FIR No. 192/2023 Dt. 24.01.2023, U/s: 356/379/411 IPC, PS: Narela Industrial Area, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North, Room No. 06, Ground Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11710/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Vikas @ Foji S/o Chiranjali Lal R/o F-318 Shakurpur, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 253/2021 U/s 379/411/34 IPC**, has been registered at **PS: Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Vikas @ Foji** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vikas @ Foji** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Vikas @ Foji** under **FIR No. 253/2021 U/s 379/411/34 IPC**, registered at **PS: Sarai Rohilla, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.09.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Rangat Ghirra
JMFC-04, Room No. 37
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/11724/NW/2026 (Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ankur Kumar, S/o: Late Lachhman Das Goel, R/o: H.No. 98, Paschim Vihar, Delhi**, Also at: 98, Paschim Vihar Extn. Near Forever Restaurant, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Cr. Case No. 1001/2023, FIR No. 345/2025, U/s: 354D/506/509 IPC, Police Station Nihal Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ankur Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ankur Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ankur Kumar** of **Police Station Nihal Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Komal Garg
Ld. MM-03, West, Room No. 292
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/11731/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82(2)(ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Jaswant Singh S/o Sh. Manpok Singh, R/o: C-12/13, Lal Bagh, Azadpur, N.S. Mandi, Delhi** (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CA No. 92/2025, U/s 279/337/338/304A IPC**, registered at **PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** and the warrant has been returned withing that the said accused **Jaswant Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Jaswant Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Jaswant Singh** accused of **CA No. 92/2025, U/s 279/337/338/304A IPC**, registered at **PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Vandana
Addl. Sessions Judge-02 (North)
Room No. 202, Second Floor,
District Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11648/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Surakhsha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shadab, S/o: Khalil Ahmad, R/o: Naya Bazaar, Near SR Banquet Hall, Sarai Johka, Nehta, Bijnor, Uttar Pradesh** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 316/25, U/s: 303(2)/318 (4)/336(3)/338/340(2)/61 Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita 2023, P.S. Crime Branch, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Shadab** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Shadab** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shadab** of **P.S. Crime Branch, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.10.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Priyanka Rajpoot
Ld. C.J.M, North, Room No. 115,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11779/CRIME/2026

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today begins with a strong energy. You feel keen to get out and talk to others. Make plans this morning. Enjoy socialising. Sports events and fun activities with kids will appeal. Romance is promising. Tonight: You're admired.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): As this day begins, home and family are your focus. Attend to family matters in the morning, because later in the day, you'll want to do something different. Tonight: Explore and learn.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This morning has a busy energy. You might be enthusiastic about getting things done. Conversations with partners, spouses and close friends will be practical and motivational. Tonight: Check your finances.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Money issues and opportunities to shop might absorb your morning. Beware of the moon alert. Late in the day, short trips and an opportunity to get out and spread your wings will appeal. Tonight: Be cooperative.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Explore sports events, fun activities with children and romantic get-togethers. Be aware of the brief moon alert today. The energy will settle down as the day wears on. You might focus on money, work and your health. Tonight: Get better organised.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): The energy of today will definitely shift for you. Play things low-key. Enjoy athletics and sports events, especially competitive team sports with others. A discussion with a female family member could be significant. Tonight: Socialise.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This morning is high energy and full of possibilities. You also might be involved with clubs and groups. You might shop for wardrobe goodies. Be aware of the Moon Alert today. Tonight: Relax at home.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Issues related to your reputation and your career, as well as your ability to earn money, are on your mind this morning. Don't hesitate to make your pitch or put your best foot forward. Tonight: An interesting conversation.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Explore your surroundings for fresh discoveries, particularly this morning. See new places and do what you can to broaden your horizons by learning new things. Check the moon alert. Tonight: Check your belongings.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Tackle financial details related to red tape, credit, taxes and inheritances. However, after the moon alert is over, the moon will be in your sign giving you a slight advantage over everyone else. You can use this! Tonight: You win.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Socialising with others will appeal to you this morning. Discussions with partners and close friends might include travel plans. However, later in the day, you might choose privacy. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You can get a lot done at work or with your to-do list. Favours and gifts from others might come your way today. By this afternoon, you'll prefer to chat with friends and groups, and postpone work for another time. Tonight: Be friendly.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ankur Kumar, S/o: Late Lachhman Das Goel, R/o: H.No. 98, Paschim Vihar, Delhi**, Also at: 98, Paschim Vihar Extn. Near Forever Restaurant, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Cr. Case No. 1001/2023, FIR No. 345/2025, U/s: 354D/506/509 IPC, Police Station Nihal Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ankur Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ankur Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ankur Kumar** of **Police Station Nihal Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Komal Garg
Ld. MM-03, West, Room No. 292
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/11731/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82(2)(ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Jaswant Singh S/o Sh. Manpok Singh, R/o: C-12/13, Lal Bagh, Azadpur, N.S. Mandi, Delhi** (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CA No. 92/2025, U/s 279/337/338/304A IPC**, registered at **PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** and the warrant has been returned withing that the said accused **Jaswant Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Jaswant Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Jaswant Singh** accused of **CA No. 92/2025, U/s 279/337/338/304A IPC**, registered at **PS: Adarsh Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Vandana
Addl. Sessions Judge-02 (North)
Room No. 202, Second Floor,
District Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11648/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Surakhsha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Shadab, S/o: Khalil Ahmad, R/o: Naya Bazaar, Near SR Banquet Hall, Sarai Johka, Nehta, Bijnor, Uttar Pradesh** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 316/25, U/s: 303(2)/318 (4)/336(3)/338/340(2)/61 Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita 2023, P.S. Crime Branch, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Shadab** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Shadab** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Shadab** of **P.S. Crime Branch, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.10.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Priyanka Rajpoot
Ld. C.J.M, North, Room No. 115,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11779/CRIME/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Prem, S/o Chabi Lal, R/o 459-460, 2nd Floor, F-Block, JJ Colony, Shakurpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 258/2024, U/s 188 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Prem** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Prem** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Prem** accused of **FIR No. 258/2024, U/s 188 IPC, P.S. Subhash Place, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.09.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Upasana Satija
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, North-West
Room No. 108, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11757/NW/2026

PR 380808 (Urban Development) 26-27 (D)

SRI LANKA VS INDIA TESTS



Two years on, Padikkal 2.0 primed for bigger battles

Fitter, stronger left-hander waited out 14 Tests for his compelling comeback

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, August 21

IN 2021, the then 21-year-old Devdutt Padikkal was not in India's ODI XI on a white-ball tour of Sri Lanka, but Krishnappa Gowtham, who played his one and only ODI there, remembers him behaving as though he belonged.

"When we were in Sri Lanka together in 2021, he never got an opportunity to play. But his mindset was always switched on throughout the game. He was reading the game. He was thinking, 'What kind of ball would the bowler bowl if this is the field?' He was reading the game back then, and he's reading the game much better now. He was always someone who was into the game. He never drifted away. Even when he's watching the game, he's keenly watching it," Gowtham told *The Indian Express*.

Five years later, in Galle, that curiosity matured into a maiden Test hundred and the Player of the Match honours in India's 165-run win over Sri

Lanka in the first Test. Padikkal arrived in Sri Lanka well-prepared, with a stronger body and a clearer idea of the cricketer he wanted to become.

Mohammed Naseeruddin, Padikkal's coach at the Karnataka Institute of Cricket (KIOC), had seen the work put in behind the scenes.

"Before India's tour of Sri Lanka, we had a conversation, and he said that wherever I get a chance, whichever number I bat, I have to perform and grab the opportunity," Naseeruddin told this paper.

After returning from India's tour of Sri Lanka, Padikkal told Naseeruddin that Sri Lanka used Kookaburra balls, and the sessions at KIOC changed.

"He started practising with Kookaburra balls. I think the wickets here (KIOC) are similar to Sri Lankan wickets, so we had to prepare (him for) turning tracks. In Tests, around 70 percent of the attack is spin, so in every session we made sure he faced different varieties of spinners. We also made sure there were two to three left-arm



Padikkal (top) hit a maiden Test ton in Galle, batter with coach Mohammed Naseeruddin. CREMAS/MOHAMMED NASEERUDDIN

spinners in every session. That was how he prepared. You can see the difference now," Naseeruddin added.

Footwork became key. "For him, it was more about his footwork and stepping out. If you stand there and play the spinner, it is a little difficult to play the ball. So he was stretching and driving, and that is what we practised against most of the spinners. If they flight the ball, he can use his feet, get closer to the ball and drive it."

"Early on in the first innings, he hit a six against (Prabath) Jayasuriya. That was just

to make sure the field spread. After that, he started building his innings, taking ones and twos and hitting the odd boundary. That is the mark of a mature player," he said.

Soaring past hurdles

That maturity had been forged through setbacks. Padikkal almost quit playing the game due to fitness problems after his debut tour to Sri Lanka in 2021. Gowtham recalled the work that went into him becoming physically fit again.

"He has gotten much stronger. There was a point when he almost had to give up cricket, but he fought his way back, regained his fitness and dealt with a lot of issues, including problems with his stomach."

"He also had to follow a particular diet. He handled all those hurdles really well and fought it out. I feel that shows his mental toughness. And when it comes to the game, he always told me that he wanted to play for the Test team. He loves red-ball cricket more than white-ball cricket," Gowtham said.

For Naseeruddin, the biggest change in Padikkal's batting came in Mohali earlier this year. Karnataka needed 250 runs in 40 overs against Punjab. Padikkal, leading the side, opened in place of Mayank Agarwal and smashed an unbeaten 120 off 85 balls to take Karnataka into the Ranji Trophy quarterfinals.

"The innings he played in the Ranji Trophy match against Punjab in Mohali, where he won the match almost single-handedly, changed his whole batting dynamic," he said.

There is also a softer side to the left-hander. "Everyone thinks he is not an easy-going guy. Everyone knows that he is a little shy; he is a little introverted. I have babysat him since he was very young. We have played a lot of cricket together. He likes to be pampered. I don't think people know that," Gowtham added.

Padikkal dominated the first innings with 167 runs from 230 balls. In the second innings, he showed restraint, coming in to bat in the first over and scoring 44 from 75. The two innings, in different ways, showed how much his batting had evolved.

Sat Sudharsan's injury gave Padikkal the opening. He had waited for 14 Tests and almost two years between his last Test appearance in Perth and this one in Galle. On his Test comeback, Padikkal made a compelling claim for the No. 3 spot.

Hasan Mahmud: Balaji fan who won mental health battle before unsettling Australia

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 21

THEY CALLED him 'Balaji.' In a long coaching career, Monir Hossain has watched plenty of accurate mimics. The Lasith Malingas. The Brett Lees. In recent times, the Jasprit Bumrah. Never, though, had he seen someone trying to impersonate Lakshminarayanan Balaji, until he met Hasan Mahmud, his student who, 14 years later, would tame the Australians in their own backyard.

"There aren't many Balaji impersonators even in India, are there?" enquires Hossain, in a conversation with *The Indian Express* from Bangladesh.

No official count exists, but the number is presumably small. Smaller still in Bangladesh. So how did Mahmud end up idolising the former Tamil Nadu and India medium pacer?

It was the summer of 2012. Shakib Al Hasan — long before he became a divisive figure — had fallen an entire nation into supporting Kolkata Knight Riders in the IPL. They won the title that year, with Shakib playing a key role. Hasan, though, was more captivated by the team's seamer, Balaji.

"We used to call him Balaji," recalls Hossain. "Every kid had an idol, but Hasan was the only Balaji fan among us. A shy, soft-spoken boy — he watched Balaji at the IPL and decided he wanted to bowl just like him."

Mahmud's solitary goal was to perfect the art of imitation. Hossain saw something larger.

"Neither was he the fastest nor the strongest, but he had the gift of consistency. You mark an area for him, and he'd bowl exactly on that spot all day. I was astonished, because usually you expect kids to be wayward. Hasan wasn't. That aside, he had a natural outswinger. I knew immediately that the kid was meant to make it big."

He has certainly done that. Nine wickets in Darwin — the most by any Bangladeshi bowler away from home in the team's 26-year Test history. The architect of Bangladesh's first Test victory on Australian soil.

But before the glory came the scars. Not the visible kind. "What people don't know about Hasan is the many mental health battles he has fought," his coach tells this newspaper. The first of those was when he was only 15.

"I got Hasan into our Lakshmipur district team, and in only his first tournament, he



Hasan Mahmud (right) with coach Monir Hossain. EXPRESS

won us the inter-district title. That got him selected for the U-14 Chittagong Division team, and eventually, the U-15 national camp. But he was dropped from the Chittagong U-16 team soon after. This was a brutal blow, to be in the national camp and still lose your place at the division level. He swore he'd never play again."

But he did. "He isolated himself for four months. I kept visiting his house, kept pleading, but he wouldn't budge. Even his parents couldn't convince him. But I didn't give up, and eventually, he gave in."

Hossain's pitch was simple: inter-division cricket would soon be beneath him, because he'd be playing for his country.

Second coming

He was proven right. Figures of 3/15 against India in an U-17 fixture at Cox's Bazar followed. And then, another slide into darkness.

"Everything was going smoothly. The 2018 ICC U-19 World Cup was around the corner, and we were confident Hasan would make the cut. But then, he injured his shoulder while fielding in a local game. Yet again, he was devastated. Fortunately, the injury healed in time for him to play that tournament."

Hasan got nine wickets in the age-group World Cup. Even so, the mental health issues weren't done with him.

Hossain recalls two major incidents. The first of them came in the very year he shone at the U-19 World Cup.

"He finished as Bangladesh's second-highest wicket-taker at the U-19 World Cup, yet

missed out on the 2018 Emerging Teams Asia Cup squad. It broke him. He locked himself in his room and stopped training altogether, convinced cricket wasn't meant for him. I struck a deal with him — don't quit before the 2019 Emerging Teams Asia Cup. If you're still overlooked, do as you please."

He was not overlooked. When the opportunity arrived, Mahmud shone. A senior team call-up seemed inevitable. But in Mahmud's career, nothing has come easy.

"He's come close to quitting more than once, but the darkest stretch of all was during the pandemic. He had persistent back pain that doctors in Bangladesh couldn't diagnose. While he could barely bowl, he watched teammates from that 2019 squad get promoted to the national side. He was certain his career was finished."

It was not, but it could nearly have been. "Things spiralled to the point where he stopped answering calls altogether, not just mine, but his closest friends' too. I knew I could pull him out of it alone this time, so I went to the BCB and made the case for why they needed to step in. It took months — months in which he did nothing at all — but eventually they sent him to England, where a remedy was found."

Mahmud has since repaid that faith many times over. "I used to tell him, 'There will be a day you'll make Bangladesh proud.' Now, he has brought that very argument to their knees who once argued Bangladesh did not deserve Test status. Isn't this the very definition of making the country proud?"

England hand Pakistan innings defeat in first Test

Associated Press
Leeds, August 21

ENGLAND WRAPPED up an innings win over Pakistan inside three days in the first Test, delivering a strong start to the post-Bazball era under returning captain Joe Root.

Dismissed for 409, England took a 238-run advantage into the second innings and skittled Pakistan for 135 in 37.3 overs. England won by an innings and 103 runs for a 1-0 lead.

England's seamers pestered consistently at a fuller length and Pakistan couldn't endure it. Jofra Archer removed the openers, Ollie Robinson got three more wickets, Josh Tongue took three wickets, and Gus Atkinson got the late reward of Mohammad Rizwan.

BRIEF SCORES: Pakistan 171 and 135 (Mohammad Rizwan 41, Ollie Robinson 3/29, Josh Tongue 3/43, Jofra Archer 3/50) lost to England 409 by an innings and 103 runs.

Bahutule on Kuldeep: 'One game doesn't decide performance'

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 21

A BUOYANT India arrived in Colombo with the prospect of clinching a third consecutive series in Sri Lanka, after going 1-0 with a 165-run win in the series opener at Galle.

The win was built on stand-out performances from Devdutt Padikkal and Manav Suthar, whose runs and wickets helped India dominate the series opener. But despite the convincing result, Kuldeep Yadav endured a relatively quiet outing,

finishing with match figures of 1/103 from 25 overs.

Spin bowling coach Sajir Bahutule insisted the left-arm wristspinner had simply fulfilled the role the team required. "He's been bowling extremely well. Just the situation that arose in Galle; he had to play a different role, and he tried his best to adapt and tried to execute as much as possible," he told reporters on Friday.

Bahutule also clarified that Kuldeep's performance in the first Test would not affect his standing within the team.



Kuldeep Yadav took just one wicket in Galle. CREMAS

right combination, is fast bowling an option, is adding a spinner on option, and Kuldeep, for me, I think he has been a fabulous bowler over the years," he stressed.

"Yes, the wickets sometimes are slow, and sometimes the ball operates differently for the spinners on certain surfaces. But for me, he has always been a match winner, and he definitely is in the scheme of things, but we will again decide on the combination," Bahutule added.

India have four spin options in the squad — Kuldeep, Ravindra

Jadeja, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain — and Bahutule said the final combination for the second Test would be dictated entirely by conditions.

"It all depends on the conditions. What is needed at that particular time? What is the right combination? It is an extra fast bowler the better option, or is another spinner the better option?" "Finger spinners, you can manipulate the fingers and bowl at the speeds you want to bowl. So, it is a tough proposition for a spinner, but I don't think one game decides on the way he

(Kuldeep) has been performing and the way he is approaching his cricket. He has been a match-winner for India," the former India left-spinner said.

Bahutule reserved special praise for Suthar, whose control and consistency have quickly made him a dependable option in India's attack. "He is someone who is very accurate. His trajectories are just getting better and better, puts in a lot on the ball, the revs are good and he is somebody who is like a banker for us, consistently being in the lengths which we want to."

CONTINENTAL TOUR SILVER

After consistency at 8-metre plus, Sreeshankar sets sights on bigger jumps

Nihal Koshie
Mumbai, August 21

SREESHANKAR MURALI is at his happy hunting ground, the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar, for the World Athletics Continental Tour Silver. Weeks after winning a second consecutive silver medal at the Commonwealth Games, Sreeshankar's focus will soon shift to next month's Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya. Bhubaneswar, also the venue for an ongoing national cup for the Asiad, is an stepping stone.

"Kalinga Stadium is my favourite track because I have always jumped well here. My first national record came here, my personal best has come here, my season best is here," Sreeshankar said.

A season's best of 8.38 metres makes him a gold-medal favourite for the Continental Tour Silver but there are worthy challenges on paper — subject to last-minute pullouts — in the form of world junior bronze medalist Shahnowaz Khan, NCAA champion Lokesh Satyanathan and National Inter-State medalist P David. All three have registered 8.20m-plus personal-best jumps this year making the men's long jump a potential thriller.

Last month, Sreeshankar, 27, became the first Indian long jumper to win two medals at the Commonwealth Games.

Four years ago in Birmingham, his best jump of 8.08m earned him a silver. At Glasgow, he produced 8.09m for another second-place finish. He may have to jump further to secure



Sreeshankar has bagged two Commonwealth Games medals. PTI

a win in Bhubaneswar.

The weather in Glasgow was a hindrance, says Sreeshankar.

"The CWG was good but weather-wise it was not conducive. For us, it was cold, and the Europeans said it was cold for them too. The conditions affected everyone equally. I was happy with the silver but gold

was well within reach," he said.

With 8-metre-plus jumps in his six competitions this season, Sreeshankar wants to maintain his form going into the Asian Games, where he was a silver medalist three years ago.

"The season has been going well, training has been going well, I am healthy. I have to work on certain tweaks in my technique but there is a very short time between the Commonwealth Games and the

Asian Games... seven-eight weeks. It won't be optimal to make the changes now."

Sreeshankar has a ballpark number of his 8-metre-plus jumps. He puts it at about 60 at the conclusion of the Interstate Senior Athletics Championships in June. The next assignment is to take his leaps to the next level.

"The base has been good. This year was about coming back and setting the base (post knee surgery in 2024). Now I have to set the base like how (Miltiadis) Tentoglou and others are doing — like 8.20s and 8.30s. Now I am consistent over 8 metres. Any particular day, irrespective of the weather, I want to bring the consistency above 8.20m. The 2028 Olympic wave has already started.

Just want to stay healthy."

Excellent speed

Once this season is over, among the tweaks Sreeshankar wants to make is takeoff mechanics. "I tend to go more vertical than horizontal. Long jump is a horizontal jump. But I go a bit more vertical and get more flight time in the air than any other athlete. Basically, I am not utilizing the speed that I have. My speed is comparable with the top three long jumpers in the world but I am not able to use that properly. I have identified a few things which I want to do and once I can do that, it will be the missing piece of the puzzle for that big jump to happen," he hoped.

A surgery for a ruptured patellar tendon came as a setback

for Sreeshankar in 2024, the year of the Paris Olympics, keeping him on the sidelines for 21 months. The doctor said the severity of the rupture was comparable to injuries suffered during an "high impact car crash" or "fall from the top of a building". Anchor screws were implanted during surgery. Sreeshankar has to take extreme care of his knee.

"Every day I have to take care of it (knee), with icing and recovery. There are a few post-surgery complications I have to bear with till the time I am doing sports. I also have to do shock-wave and ultrasound treatment. I have to make sure that my knee is not stiffened up when I travel. So I have to keep on moving during the flight."

Surgery for a ruptured patellar tendon came as a setback

MARCH TO SEMIFINALS

Last pair standing: A doubles gamble keeps India's Worlds alive

15 years after Jwala-Ashwini's bronze, Treesa-Gayatri's unlikely partnership, forged through setbacks, ensures medal streak continues in front of home fans

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 21

PVV LAKSHMI didn't know what the two were up to when they whispered plans for a month, right under her nose. But the 1996 Atlanta Olympics women's doubles shuttler wasn't too thrilled when the father-daughter duo of Pullela Gopichand and Gayatri announced one day that Lakshmi's first-born would drop her singles ambitions and switch to doubles.

Around the same time as the pandemic, Treesa Jolly was training in doubles at the Munday indoor stadium in Kanpur, routinely missing hosted deadlines for dinner and going hungry several nights, while missing her mum's kappas biryani staying away from home.

When she was paired with Gayatri and moved to Hyderabad, one of Indian badminton's most scrutinised journeys would start. On Friday at the Indira Gandhi stadium, a host of unconventional calls were vindicated as Treesa-Gayatri, the pair of 23-year-olds, kept India's World Championships medal streak going, defeating Olympic champion Jia Yifan playing with Zhang Shu Xian, with a sensational 16-21, 21-15, 21-13 come-from-behind result.

The 12-edition, 15-medal streak dates back to Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponappa at London in 2011. The home Worlds witnessed the unexpected pairing step up ahead of the singles stars and even their celebrated doubles seniors Satwik Chirag, who kept the home interest alive on semis Saturday. A win over top-ranked Chinese Liu-Tan could propel the World No 39s into the gold/silver orbit, after their win over World Nos 4 and 7 this week.

"I knew Gayatri was good at singles," Gopichand says, adding, "But she was better in doubles. I'm happy but also relieved that the decision proved right." In the quarterfinals, Treesa-Gayatri started with a 0-6 deficit. From there, Treesa rained down a stinging attack on the Chinese and Gayatri manipulated the shuttle with cool finesse.

Soon after the win, Treesa would rush to hug coach Gopichand who had funnelled all his instructions towards her, urging her to calm down after errors and stay pumped up and

While Gayatri's cross-court drop mirrors her mother Lakshmi's, Treesa learnt the mix-and-match of strokes from her father

aggressive when she found the winners. Treesa had crashed into a teammate during training, injuring her ankle back in April, missing 11 tournaments, but with 50 days to go for the Delhi Worlds, Gopichand had shown up at the Hyderabad academy and insisted they train in basics like net dribbles.

The highlight of Friday's win was Treesa, known for her big smash, confidently dribbling and winning the net eye-ball confrontation with Jia. "Jolly has a very strong attack, and Gayatri is too sharp mentally," the Chinese 4-time World champion would acknowledge.

Unconventional

A long-time criticism of Gopichand as national coach had been that he had showered all attention on singles, ignoring doubles. Ahead of the 2016 Olympics, he began to get serious about producing elite doubles players, and his first experiment had been Manu Attri-Sumeet Reddy, now coaches in Hyderabad with Treesa-Jolly. Arun Vishnu, another protégé, would hone their training earlier.

He had been a former national doubles champ, but women's doubles was a challenge. "You have to become a student as a coach. I watched a lot of matches. I generally spend a lot of time thinking that I'm wrong. Being sceptical. But it's unconventional. It works," Gopi says. On the recovery path, Treesa-Gayatri played a low-tier event in the Philippines - just so they could play more matches and spend time together on court.

"They both kept wondering and would laugh at Gopi asking why we were practising simple things like dribbles and not complex strategy," Sumeet recalls. "But Gopi is one of the best doubles coaches because he doesn't shy away from fresh thought. He breaks rallies into multiple smaller parts. It was how Treesa



Gayatri Gopichand with her father and coach Pullela Gopichand after the historic win at the BWF World Championships. RANUITH KUMAR/RANZI SPORTS

needed to be prepared."

Treesa has always been a prodigious smasher, but tends to get emotional, which is why coaches kept talking to her. The Chinese were eventually ambushed when Treesa found her range and Gayatri went for body attacks and lifts with canny angles.

The lead-up to the Worlds had been tough for Treesa-Gayatri. They had fallen from World No 9 to 41. "Gayatri's injuries meant they missed nine tournaments before the Paris Olympics and couldn't qualify. But Treesa had been very patient," Lakshmi recalls.

"So this time when Treesa got injured, Gayatri stayed supportive. There were a lot of bad days but the bond got thicker due to adversity."

While Gayatri's cross-court drop mirrors her mother's, Treesa learnt the mix-and-match of strokes from her badminton-loving father. But the Gopichand pivot to doubles had been one of self-doubt and tinged with criticism as results took time. Lakshmi refused to become a second strict authority figure at home. "I try to let her be. Eat her chocolate ice cream and brownies. She eats very small quantities," the dotting mother says.

On Treesa, Lakshmi goes for the full gush. "Her attack is so good. But she also has great variations at the net. Together they are perfectly matched. But most importantly, they care a lot for each other," she says.

Indians not intimidated by doubles legends en route to SF

Shivani Naik
New Delhi, August 21

JIA YIFAN had won Tokyo silver and Paris gold while Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand watched the Chinese strut on the big stage.

"She was an Olympic gold medalist when we started on the circuit. But at this level, you can't praise anyone too much before playing them!" Treesa Jolly says.

The highest respect in international sport involves inflicting defeat on the idol. So, Treesa and Gayatri went about decimating the defence of World Nos 4 Jia and Zhang Shu Xian; after lulling them into thinking they could stroll in the park as the score read 0-6. The first game was gone 21-6 as the diagonal interceptions went into the net. But Treesa-Gayatri were just warming up to unleash a torrent.

Zhang, the younger Chinese partner, was clearly targeted, but neither Treesa nor Gayatri spared the seasoned Jia either. Gayatri got down to work in the front court, those angled pings sowing doubt in Zhang's head, while Treesa started bisecting the Chinese in a side-by-side receiving stance. Things were tight as the Indians led 15-14 in the second, even as coach Gopichand kept urging the Indians



Gayatri Gopichand (L) and Treesa Jolly won the match in 3 games. ANI

to push the Chinese back. Gayatri deep smashing then took the lead to 17-14.

Earlier, Treesa dove side and then front, and Gayatri got back a few low retrievers too, but the Indians lost the point at 16-14.

Perhaps the best rally of the match came at 18-14 when the Indians soaked up the attacking pressure, went from defence to offence in a blink before Treesa finished the flurry with a scalding smash. The Indians then Thursday gameplan of sending quick returns on the body, to ensure the reflex responses sail wide when hit from out of position. The Chinese confusion was evident as both went for the same shuttle.

Though the Indians logged a couple of errors, the Chinese were hemmed in by the shuttle stalking them around.

Treesa would start finding gaps left by the wrongfooted Chinese as the Indians settled into a fast-flat game to sprint to a 11-5 lead. Gayatri would intercept high and fast rushing the Chinese as their defence came apart under the blitzing onslaught as the drift was harnessed by the Indians to bring down Jia, a women's doubles giant.

"I had messed up earlier with eagerness to score points. Today I stayed calm," Treesa would say. It was Jia's time to get hurried and rushed.

SatChi's medal quest flattened in two games

British Raj
New Delhi, August 21

USUALLY CHIRPY and vocal on the court, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy-Chirag Shetty quietly walked away as Olympic silver medalist Liang Weikeng and Wang Chang of China celebrated after winning the men's doubles quarter finals at the Badminton World Championships.

The World no 3 pair not only kept the Indian pair quiet throughout the second game but also silenced the noisy IG Indoor Stadium on Friday. Liang and Wang won 21-18, 21-9 in just 36 minutes.

"The first game was really good. But in the second game, we completely fell out of contention," said a disappointed Chirag after the game.

He is not wrong about dominating the first game. The Indian pair was smashing in tandem and troubling the Chinese pair with their chemistry after a nervy start. They went 0-3 down before Satwik smashed one to make it 1-3. He followed it with another smash and one mistake from Wang made the score 4-4.

Both pairs made some unforced errors in the early exchanges and a short serve from Liang meant that the Indian pair went to the mid-game break with a 11-10 lead. "I think our game-plan was working in the first game but then we committed multiple errors," said Chirag.

After the break, the Indians smashed more than the Chinese, catching them out of space in the mid court. At 14-12, Chirag produced three smashes and Satwik produced two to win the point and make it 15-12. Satwik produced another big smash before forcing an error from Liang on the net to make it 15-13. After two more winners, the Indian duo sat with a 18-16 lead.

However, they squandered a 18-16 lead and lost five points consecutively to hand the Chinese the victory in the first game 21-16. From 18-18, it was three consecutive errors that gifted the Chinese pair the first game. "I wouldn't say we played badly recently, but there were many instances where we felt we should have secured points but didn't—even though we played a pretty solid game, including defensively," Chirag

said about the first game.

Flat exchanges

But hindsight, in sports, is like wishful thinking and nothing more. The Chinese stepped up in the second game. The 21-9 scoreline in the second game explains how dominant the Chinese pair was. The main reason behind it was the flat exchanges.

Flat exchanges acted as kryptonite for the Indian pair and the Chinese pair milked it very well.

"We have played the Indian pair so many times and we know their game. It was a conscious strategy to resort to the flat exchanges and we executed it well," Wang said after the match.

Interestingly, Liang and Wang love to play the attacking game more than flat exchanges. "We weren't expecting them to play like this. They usually play the lifting game and they are good at that but today they were just pushing the shuttle constantly. It was difficult to execute the lifts," said Satwik. "They weren't just retrieving the shuttle; they were effectively converting those situations into attacking opportunities." The Indian pair tried to set up a few points but the Chinese pair anticipated well and countered the strategy. "We tried playing soft drops to create an opening, but they were able to convert those situations effectively," explained Satwik.

Apart from the flat exchanges, the Chinese pair also closed the spaces for the Indian pair to attack. Once the spaces were closed, the Indian pair started hitting more on net and making errors. "They were everywhere. Wherever we were hitting, they would counter it," said Satwik.

With the chance to win a Worlds medal in front of the home crowd gone, the Indian duo have an Asian Games to target in the next month. More than that, Satwik would want to nurse his shoulder. "It's been a long time with this injury. Sometimes I feel really good, but the next day I feel very stiff or just terrible. So, it's kind of complicated. But I just need to manage myself and play. I've had a good six weeks of rehab and strength training. So, it's difficult to recover and play again. But today I'm feeling pretty good," said Satwik.



Chirag Shetty (R) and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy lost 18-21, 9-21 to Liang Weikeng and Wang Chang of China. PTI

{ HOCKEY WORLD CUP }

Midfield battle key as India face Dutch challenge

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 21

THE MOST important battle when India face the Netherlands on Saturday may take place nowhere near either circle.

Instead, it will be fought in the middle of the pitch, where Hardik Singh, Manpreet Singh and India's other midfielders will come up against a Dutch side that has made controlling games almost an art form. The Netherlands have started this World Cup in characteristic fashion. They move the ball patiently, drop opponents out and then accelerate through the gaps that appear. Against New Zealand and Argentina, they spent long stretches playing on their terms, turning possession into territory and territory into pressure.

India have seen that side of them before. They also know the Netherlands can be hurt.

When the two teams met in Rotterdam in June, India won 3-2, with Hardik Singh playing a performance that earned him the Dutch. India pressed, broke quickly and repeatedly found ways through a defence rarely made to look uncomfortable.

Midfield battle

Saturday's meeting carries considerably more weight.



Hardik Singh holds the key in midfield. HOCKEY INDIA

Pool E standings

TEAM	PLD	W	D	L	GD	PTS
England	1	1	0	0	+2	3
Netherlands	1	1	0	0	+2	3
India	1	0	0	1	-2	0
Argentina	1	0	0	1	-2	0

● India lost 2-4 to England in Pool D, and that result has been carried forward to Stage 2

● Similarly, Netherlands beat Argentina 3-1 in Pool A and thus

already have three points

● India will take on Netherlands and Argentina, and the top 2 teams from Pool E will make the semis

became almost irrelevant at times as the game turned into an end-to-end contest, with England eventually winning 5-3.

Neither scenario is attractive against the Netherlands. The Dutch are unlikely to allow the match to descend into

the chaos the Pakistan one did. Nor are they likely to simply hand India possession. Their strength lies in making opponents work for the ball and then punishing them when their shape breaks.

That puts particular emphasis on India's ability to connect the two ends of the pitch.

Hardik's ball-carrying and ability to break the first line of pressure will be important. So will Manpreet's experience and the work of the midfielders around them. India have enough pace in the forward line to exploit spaces, but those forwards need the ball early and in the right areas.

There is a direct link to Harmanpreet Singh, as well. A lot of attention on India's captain has been centred on the penalty corner, and he has already shown in this tournament how quickly he can change a game with his drag-flick. But Harmanpreet's chances do not begin at the top of the circle.

They begin with India winning the ball, moving it through the midfield and getting into the Dutch circle.

The more time India spend in the attacking half, the more opportunities there are for Harmanpreet to influence the game with his stick. If the Dutch instead control the middle, Harmanpreet could

find himself spending the evening organising India's defence and dealing with Dutch attacks rather than waiting for penalty corners.

That dual responsibility is part of what makes the midfield battle so important.

India's captain has to be available for the decisive moment, but the players in front of him have to help create those moments.

Recent evidence suggests India can produce those moments. The win in Rotterdam showed that the Dutch can be pressured and that India can match their pace. But the Netherlands are playing at home, have looked composed through the opening phase of the World Cup and know how to make opponents defend for long periods.

For India, this may therefore be less about producing one spectacular performance than about staying consistent for 60 minutes.

The midfield will be where that connection is tested first. And if India can keep the Dutch from taking control there, they may give Harmanpreet exactly what he needs: a game in which his drag-flick, rather than his defensive work, becomes the defining contribution.

Live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar, 7:30 p.m.

Netherlands give Salima & Co the blues as semis hopes take a hit

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, August 21

THERE WAS a strange sight at the Wagener Stadium: India were in orange, the Netherlands in blue. The colour swap was about the only thing the Dutch had surrendered. For long stretches, India surrendered almost everything else.

The Netherlands beat India 2-0 on Friday to underline the gulf between the World No.1 and a team that had arrived in the second round of the World Cup undefeated and with renewed belief. India defended bravely and made the Dutch work for their goals, but never managed to keep the ball for long enough to seriously threaten the hosts.

Yibbi Jansen gave the Netherlands the lead in the second minute, converting their first penalty corner after the ball struck Sushila Chanu's foot inside the circle.

It could have been the beginning of a rout. Instead, India dug in. Bichu Devi made an important save from another Jansen drag-flick in the first quarter, while another effort from the Dutch struck the post. India's defenders threw themselves into the

Pool E standings

TEAM	PLD	W	D	L	GD	PTS
Netherlands	2	2	0	0	4	6
China	2	0	2	0	0	2
Australia	2	0	1	1	-2	1
India	2	0	1	1	-2	1

path of shots and passes, repeatedly denying the Netherlands the clean openings they usually manufacture.

But there was a problem at the other end. India simply couldn't hold on to possession. Every time they won the ball, the Dutch press closed in. Passes went astray, clearances were hurried and promising moments disappeared before India could turn them into sustained attacks. At half-time, Sjoerd Marjine acknowledged as much, urging his team to keep the ball better.

There were flashes of what India could do. Deepika's drag-flick from a penalty corner was blocked, and Naveet Kaur found space after an aerial ball but could not hit the target. Sunelia Toppo also got forward early in the second half, only for the Dutch goalkeeper to deny her. But those moments were rare.

The Netherlands eventually

doubled their advantage in the third quarter. A foot inside the Indian circle handed them another penalty corner, and Frederique Matla made no mistake, sending a precise drag-flick past the onrushing defenders.

For India, the task then became even harder. They had spent much of the evening defending, and the Dutch were not going to willingly give them the ball. The 2-0 scoreline was therefore less a reflection of an Indian collapse than of a team being gradually squeezed out of the contest by opponents who are exceptionally good at controlling games.

However, India left the game with their semi-final hopes still alive - they will face Australia in a do-or-die match on Sunday - but with a much clearer idea of what the next level demands. The Aussies had drawn 1-1 with China earlier in the day.